

SCHOOL OF
SPIRITUAL AND
CULTURAL STUDIES

FOUNDATIONS OF INDIAN HERITAGE



Dedication

The completion of this book could not have been possible without the blessings of Amma, Sat-guru Sri Mata Amritanandamayi Devi, the universal mother, the dispeller of darkness and ignorance in her children. We offer this humble effort at Amma's lotus feet.

Forever grateful for her countless love.

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Preface

"Sitting under the Kalpavriksha, the mythological wish-fulfilling tree, one's every desire would be granted". This majestic tree symbolises the abundance and prosperity at the heart of Indian Culture, yet it is grounded in the profound wisdom of "Dharma" - the righteous path that ultimately frees the individual from the bondage of material cravings. There is no better allegory that represents Indian Culture than Kalpavriksha which symbolises the symbiotic relationship between man and nature, as well as the cyclical nature of existence. In its ability to provide for every human need, while also guiding one towards transcendence, this 'Tree of Life' holds the multifaceted richness of India's heritage. The wisdom that shaped the Indian subcontinent shall be explored through this book, "Foundations of Indian Heritage".

Meticulously structured into fourteen chapters, the book delves into specific aspects of Indian heritage, each woven together by a common thread: the enduring legacy of Indian knowledge systems and their relevance to contemporary challenges. The adventurous journey can only begin by reclaiming and reconnecting with Indian knowledge Systems. The stage for learning shall be set by highlighting the impact of colonialism on India's cultural

and intellectual identity and the importance of decolonizing the mind to appreciate the true essence of Indian Heritage. The book then offers a panoramic view of Indian philosophical systems, or Darshanas, which provide invaluable insights into the nature of reality and human existence. How these philosophical understandings can enhance creativity in science shall always be an attraction for inquisitive minds.

Attempting to bridge the ancient wisdom with contemporary issues, the focus of the book shifts to the epistemological frameworks of Indian philosophies, exploring how ancient Indian thinkers approached the acquisition of knowledge. This highlights the rigorous methodologies that underpin Indian philosophical thought, making one awe-struck about the logical systems that evolved in India. A Vedantic model of human personality is presented, offering insights into the complex interplay between the body, mind, and Atman, providing a holistic understanding of human nature and the path to self-realisation. Drawing from the Upanishads, the book issues a call to awaken to the deeper truths of existence, emphasising the transformative power of self-knowledge and the pursuit of spiritual enlightenment. It explores the Purusharthas, the four goals of human life—Dharma, Artha, Kama, and Moksha, providing a comprehensive framework for understanding the purpose and direction of human life.

Drawing from Indian wisdom traditions, the book identifies six essential qualities that lead one to success. Further, it delves into the concept of Dharma, elucidating its multifaceted nature as duty, righteousness, and the principle that sustains the universe, offering practical insights into living a Dharmic life.

From discussions on one's existence and self, the book unfolds to a new dimension. The importance of family as a foundational

unit of society is explored, highlighting the values and traditions that have sustained Indian families through the ages. The book examines the cultural and civilizational unity of India, despite its diversity, tracing the historical and philosophical lines that bind the Indian subcontinent into a cohesive whole. The contributions of key historical figures who have shaped the Indian nation are celebrated, providing inspiring accounts of their lives and legacies. The book then explores India's interactions with other civilizations, highlighting the exchange of ideas, culture, and knowledge, underscoring India's great role in the global civilizational snapshot.

In its final chapter, the book offers a reflective piece, urging the younger generation to learn from the past and carry forward the baton of Indian heritage. It is a call to action for preserving and nurturing the wisdom of the ages. This book is an opportunity for a reader to take an expedition through time, offering a deep and nuanced understanding of India's contributions to the world. Beginning from the foundation of Indian heritage, this invites one to broaden their horizons, challenge their preconceptions, and develop a more holistic worldview that integrates the best of ancient wisdom with modern knowledge.

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Chapter 1

Decolonisation

On that historical day in 1947, India was declared free and independent. Every year on August 15th, we celebrate this freedom that we got back. It has been __ years since, and we have celebrated __ times.

To us, colonisation is a thing of the past. Something that we remember on Independence day, or during the birthday, or death day of a legendary freedom fighter, or when we happen to stumble upon a majestic statue in the journeys we make.

When we discuss British colonisation, we are often filled with images of violence and suffering, looting, and imposition of law. The Jallianwala Bagh massacre; the Kohinoor diamond displayed in the British museum; Bhagat Singh, sentenced to hang until death at the age of 22; Indian's forced to fight for the British in the World War; the violent creation of Pakistan; the mysterious death / disappearance of Subash Chandra Bose; the assassination of Gandhi, the Mahatma; and then it was all over. We became free (Or so we think).

We think about colonisation with such memory, and we remember it as political and economic control, and a lot of violence. Of course, this memory and recollection is not ours personally. We were never there to witness any of it. But it is our memory too. Our collective memory, or our civilisational memory. And we need it.

We need it because it helps us connect the dots and see how past events have shaped our present (the historical context of current issues). It reminds us that we're all in this together and can learn from the past to build a better future for everyone. And we need it also because colonisation is not over. There is more to colonialism that we need to be aware of, more to it than domination, looting and violence. Because now, we are the ones facing it first hand.

To begin a discussion on decolonisation, we need to first understand what colonisation is, for all the effects it had on our nation. And it so happens that understanding colonisation as such is the beginning of the process of decolonisation.

Activity 1: Define the following words.

1. Maya - _____
2. Atma - _____
3. Ishwara - _____
4. Manas - _____
5. Asura - _____
6. Shakti - _____

Defining Colonisation

Over the past 500 to 600 years, the Europeans set out to "discover" foreign lands. And in their journey they did "discover" - America, Africa, Australia, large parts of Asia, etc. Even today, we learn that Christopher Columbus "discovered" America, and we accept it even though our common sense tells us that this land that was called America by Europeans, was already there before they "discovered" it. There were people there, and great civilisations like the Maya and the Aztec, among many more. Yet still, somehow, they claim to have "discovered" it.

European nations thus colonised numerous regions on Earth for a long time before relinquishing control over many of these territories. Subsequently, research has gone into the impact and experience of colonisation in these places, and hence today, we can examine colonisation on a worldwide scale. We can thus reach a nuanced and unbiased definition of colonisation from all those experiences, a definition that is beyond any kind of religious, nationalistic, or civilisational prejudice.

In an article by Margaret Kohn and Kavita Reddy, published in the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy in 2006, they discuss the difficulty in defining colonialism. Often limited to the term imperialism, there is a tendency to define colonialism as only political and economic control. While these are indeed common features, they are not synonymous. But owing to the consistent difficulty in distinguishing colonialism from imperialism, they chose to define colonialism thus.

> … the process of European settlement, violent dispossession and political domination over the rest of the world, including the Americas, Australia, and parts of Africa and Asia.

> … a broad concept that refers to the project of European political domination that began in the early sixteenth century [1].

Here settlement or population transfer is the only difference between colonialism and imperialism. This definition is also in-line with an earlier work by Ronald J Hovarth in 1972 [2]. In places like America we find why settlement is given more importance. European settlers in America are called Americans today, and the original people of the land are called Native Americans. Did the natives even call themselves American before the advent of Europeans?

In another research discussing the coloniality of knowledge in Africa [3] [4], we find,

> The coloniser does not only distort the history of the colonised, slaughter their knowledge systems and empty their heads of self-confidence and their hearts of the emotional stamina to live without colonial domination. But he goes ahead to manufacture accusations and labels against the colonised...

Here we encounter another dimension of colonialism. There is something about distortion of history, and of knowledge systems, and about labelling the colonised. This aligns with the work of Aimé Césaire, esteemed author and leader, who extensively studied and worked against colonialism in Africa. In 'Discourse on Colonialism' [5], he exclaims,

> Colonial activity, colonial enterprise, colonial conquest, is based on contempt for the native and justified by that contempt.

He talks about 'contempt for native'. What does this have to

do with colonialism?

In an attempt to make subtle and nuanced understanding of colonialism during and after, Nicholas Dirks suggests,

> It is not just that colonialism had cultural effects, it was itself a cultural project of control. In certain ways, culture was what colonialism was all about. During and after colonial rule, colonised societies were classified as traditional societies. The newly classified traditional societies were reconstructed and transformed by and through colonial technologies of conquest and rule. This created new categories and oppositions between colonisers and colonised, European and Asian, modern and traditional, West and East, even male and female [6].

These are acclaimed research studies outside India, with almost 10,000 citations combined. They suggest that beyond political and economic control, and violence, colonisation is also about, transfer of population of the coloniser, contempt for the native, process of culture change, distortion of history and being categorised. This could just be the tip of the iceberg.

Thus we reach a wider definition of colonisation that we need to bother about,

1. Political and Economic Control, with Violence
2. Transfer of population of the coloniser
3. Contempt for the Native
4. Process of Culture Change
5. Distortion of History
6. Distortion of Knowledge Systems
7. Being Categorised (as primitive, underdeveloped etc.)

Of these, we don't have to deal with the first two aspects of colonisation. Our legendary freedom fighters gave up their lives to deal with the first and foremost problem, and by 1947 it was solved. Colonisation in India did not see any permanent settlement of British or other European nationals here. Hence we don't have to face that aspect of colonisation as well.

But the rest is still there, and we have to deal with it. Note that some researchers also define these as 'post-colonialism' [1][2].

In many of these countries today, the native traditions have been lost beyond recovery. For them, understanding and addressing the problem of colonisation only means that they rise to the same level of the colonists, be as good as them, be their equal. In India, the indigenous culture is very much alive. The problem of colonisation has to be addressed to return to our civilizational identity, and to prevent further damage.

The broader definition of colonialism that we reached here is from global studies of colonialism. This does not mean that this problem has not been identified in India. Though they do not use the word colonisation or decolonisation, many luminaries in India had already identified this problem, and had discussed it. Reading their works brings about a natural process of decolonisation. Who are they?

1. Swami Vivekananda
2. Rabindranath Tagore
3. Sri Aurobindo
4. Mahatma Gandhi
5. Subash Chandra Bose etc.

If you take this entire definition of colonialism into consideration,

we can immediately see that colonisation is not over. This means that we continue to be colonised, that we are facing it first hand, and we need to gain freedom from this colonisation too. To understand this, and the effect these things have on the core of our being, and our relationship with family, society and nation, we need to first understand how colonialism affects us individually [7], and collectively. Only with such an understanding can a definition of colonialism be complete.

Taking Notice of Colonisation

The Monoculture

A very visible aspect of colonisation that we constantly see in the world today is the kind of monoculture that has settled in. What does this mean?

There are hundreds of thousands of communities in India, and millions more across the world. The differences between them is perceivable. How do we understand one community to be different from others? What do we differentiate? Broadly speaking, among other things, we primarily notice the following [8],

1. Language
2. Dress
3. Aesthetics - Ornaments, art, etc.
4. Architecture
5. Food (medicine, ecosystem)
6. Divine and the Sacred

Activity 2: Divide the class into groups of 5 or 6 students, and prepare a graphic presentation of these six aspects of community, for different states of India.

When you take the indigenous framework of lifestyle and living, you find such variations based on geography, climate, and other factors. But how has colonial frameworks changed all this? We can find that colonisation has led to a kind of monoculture in all aspects - linguistic monoculture, aesthetic monoculture, technological monoculture, biological / medicinal monoculture etc.

A common language, style of dressing, global styles, and concrete in architecture. As you look closer, you find more and more. Is monoculture a good thing? Are they based on any scientific study?

Colonised Identity

Imagine that you are introducing yourself to someone. What details would you give as pertaining to the definition of you. This can be an activity.

You would first tell them your name; followed by where you come from, which is your origin. You may talk about your hobbies, your interests and your goals. And when you get closer you share your perceptions of life that take you forward, your view of the world, and what you are setting out to achieve. These are the things that make up your identity and define who you are.

Now imagine, that someone is trying to artificially remove your memory, and hence your identity. You can relate to the very popular movies like Bourne Series, Inception, The Maze Runner, Shutter Island, Total Recall, among many more that portray a theft of memory and identity, and the journey back.

We trade many things, but we dont give or take our core identity. We won't allow it to be snatched away, manipulated or controlled. On an individual level if such a manipulation happens to us, we can detect and solve it by psychological means. But what if this

happens to us collectively, as a community or nation. Is it acceptable if over hundreds of years, our identities, our memories, and our perceptions have been collectively hijacked and manipulated? [8]

Robbery of memory personally, is akin to robbery (or distortion) of history in the collective sense. Similarly, forcing a change in our culture implies a forced estrangement of identity on an individual level. Imagine a situation where someone shows contempt for what you believe in! If colonisation is contempt for native culture, it is also contempt for your personal beliefs.

This exactly is at the core of the definition of colonialism.

Colonisation is the hijacking of our collective identity, by manipulating our past, history, culture, and philosophy, to serve the purposes of the coloniser. Decolonising, hence, is the process of coming back to our true identity.

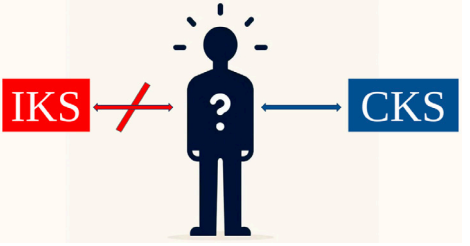
Inability to Access Indian Knowledge Systems

How did you define Maya, Atma, Ishwara, Asura, Shakti, or Manas? You will have found yourself saying that Maya means illusion, and then explained what illusion is. You will have defined Atma as soul, and then you defined soul. Or Ishwara is God, and then defined God. Right?

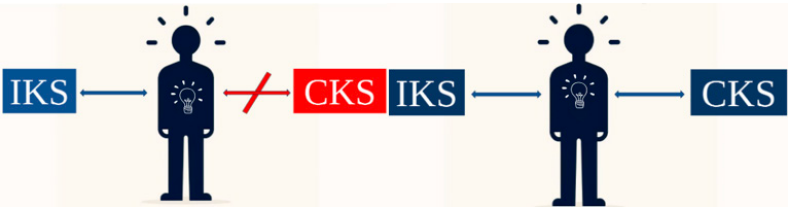
Make one more attempt to define all these terms. This time, don't go for the English words, illusion, soul, god, etc. Try to describe them in your native language. Are you able to do it? You will be surprised at how hard it is. These terms are very personal to you as well, right? When you try to define Manas, remember that you are trying to define your manas, or Atma is your Atma. How come you do not know what all these things mean?

This is the most visible effect of colonisation. It disconnected us

from our culture (Indian Knowledge Systems), and had us connect to the culture of the coloniser (Coloniser Knowledge Systems) instead. And hence when we try to define any such terms, unable



to access IKS, we automatically go to CKS (where we establish a weak connection). In our case, the Coloniser Knowledge Systems is primarily the English or British Knowledge Systems.



The solution is now clear. We need to establish our connection with Indian Knowledge Systems, irrespective of the status of our connection with CKS.

Colonial Shadows Within Us

If you think that all this is not for you, that you are not colonised, think again! Let us evaluate ourselves based on a scale set for us in another work of research [9]. This work describes what we can take to be the five symptoms of a still colonised mind.

1. A sceptical attitude towards Indian cultural creations and institutions. Unless approved or recognised by the west, nothing in India is good enough.

2. A worshipping attitude towards western cultural creations and institutions, justified in the name of "progress". Unless deemed inadequate in a western evaluation, nothing from the west is to be rejected.
3. An intellectual tendency to compare India of the past with the west of the present, rather than a contemporaneous comparison.
4. A general tendency to judge the west based on its ideals as it were from time to time, as against the tendency to judge Indian society and culture based only on what prevails at the present, without regard to the millenia of foreign invasions.
5. A tendency to assess and judge Indian culture, society, and spirituality using Western intellectual frameworks, while disregarding the insights and tools of analysis offered by Indian philosophical traditions, which are often dismissed as unscientific or irrelevant when applied to Western culture.

If you are able to relate to any of these symptoms, have no doubt you are colonised. This colonisation is essentially a disease of the mind that needs to be cured.

A decolonised mind is essentially free to think, is able to accept and transfer knowledge without biases. All biases? No. It goes to say that there are personal elements that can lead to bias or block our thinking. Here it is the ability to think originally, owing to the return of our identity, that was collectively hijacked by the colonisers.

Whether we accept it or not, we maintain rigid borders in our thought processes. Because, aligning ourselves with the British coloniser, we have divided everything and everyone around us into what is "modern" and what is not. Or what is "progressive"

and what is not. What is "science" or "scientific" and what is not.

Our imaginations are trapped within these boundaries. We don't allow it to soar wide and free. Decolonisation means that you can dissolve those boundaries, and allow yourself to apply your logic and reasoning to anything and everything around you, be it tradition, faith, arts, sports, science, philosophy and much more.

A decolonised mind is hence free to think, without ideas of the coloniser running in the background.

Notions of Benefit and Progress

Almost eight decades after colonisation, we are still chasing western ideas and notions, even when it comes to understanding India. We wholeheartedly agree with the British when they say that it was them who brought progress and modernity to India. We have no problem creating a pros and cons list to discuss the British or Mughal presence in India. Even the violent realities of their presence does not prevent us from thinking about the so-called benefits. We agree to all this without thorough study or research.

> **Activity 3:** Divide the class into groups of 5 or 6 students. Let each group create a pros and cons list of European and Mughal presence in India.

The existence of these notions, despite lack of proof or study, is another way colonisation can be visibly perceived. For example, the British brought progress to India - Education, Medicine, Law and Administration, or that before the British, India was not united as one nation.

How did you come by these notions? Have you been presented with any kind of study or proof that these things are true? You may have read minimally on such matters, but then how did you come to believe that these things are true?

Let us discuss and critically analyse the notion that it was the British who educated Indians, or improved our system of education. And thus let us learn to analyse any such notion, before accepting them as true.

Indian Education - Pre and Post Colonial

Activity 4: When you think about education in Ancient India, what comes to mind? List five things you know.

Activity 5: This is an activity for a group of two students. Imagine that one of you is born to a family of carpenters in Britain of the 1800s, and the other a woman born in a royal family in Britain, at the same time. What would be your futures? Discuss and contrast.

The history of India is replete with contributions in many fields of study. Physics, mathematics, chemistry, medicine, astronomy, metallurgy, linguistics, philosophy, law and administration, architecture, accounting, sports and games, arts, and much more.

Table 1: Contributions and Contributors of Ancient India

Sl. No	Contributors	Area of Contribution	Published / Implemented	Approximate Year of Publication
1	Sushruta	Medicine	Sushruta Samhita	600 BCE
2	Lagadha	Astronomy	Vedanga Jyothisha	500 BCE
3	Panini	Linguistics	Ashtadyayi	4th Century BCE
4	Chanakya	Economics, Law & Administration	Arthashasthra, Neethishasthra	3rd Century BCE
5	Patanjali	Linguistics, Yoga	Mahabhashya,Yoga sutras	2nd Century BCE
6	Bharat Muni	Art	Natyashastra	between 200 BCE and 200 CE.
7	Nagarjuna	Chemistry, Metallurgy	Rasaratnakara	1st Century BCE
8	Charaka	Medicine	Charaka Samhita	100 CE

9	Chandragupta II	Metallurgy	The Iron Pillar	375 - 415 CE
10	Thiruvalluvar	Philosophy, Poet	Tirukkural	500 CE
11	Aryabhatta	Mathematics, Astronomy	Aryabhattiya Arya Siddhanta	510 CE
12	Varahamihira	Astronomy and Mathematics	Brihat Samhita Aryabhattiyabhashya,	550 CE
13	Bhaskara 1	Mathematics	Mahabhashkariya, Laghubhashkariya	629 CE
14	Brahmagupta	Mathematics, Astronomy	Brahmasphutasiddhanta	665 CE
15	Adi Shankaracharya	Philosophy	Commentaries (Bhashyas) on the Upanishads, Brahmasutra and Bhagavadgita. Bhaja Govindam	8th Century CE
16	Bhoja Narapati	Naval Engineering	Yukti Kalpa Taru	1000-1050 CE
17	Bhaskara II	Mathematics	Sidhanta Siromani	1150 CE
18	Queen Udayamati	Architecture	Rani-ki-Vav (the Queen's Stepwell), a distinctive form of subterranean water architecture of the Indian subcontinent, located in Patan	11th Century CE
19	Swami Vivekananda	Philosophy	Bartaman Bharat, Vedanta Philosophy, Karma Yoga, Bhakti Yoga, Sangeet Kalpataru, Practical Vedanta and many more.	1863 - 1902 CE

Now, there is an inevitable question that must be pondered. Can there be a contribution to any field of expertise, without opportunities for systematic guidance and support? One can argue that, for example in mathematics, people would know basic counting or calculations without a stream of mathematics learning. But can there be a cutting edge research finding, or proposal of new theorems, only with individual effort. For an advanced research to happen, there must have been previous research to which the researcher had access. This can be through

books, or by direct learning.

If there are contributions in any field, that implies that that stream of learning flourished in that region. Take popular examples even today. Can there be a Sachin Tendulkar, if cricket was not thriving in India. Can there be Lionel Messi if Argentina did not cherish football? Can there be a Nambi Narayanan or an APJ Abdul Kalam, if India did not have Aerospace Engineering?

This implies that a lot of streams including the ones that have been listed in the table above flourished in India. India has a rich educational heritage, with great universities that harboured scholars all over India and abroad. Nalanda, Takshashila, Kanthalloor Sala, etc. are examples of the great universities of India.

Figure 1 reveals a teacher-disciple line, in the fields of Astronomy and Mathematics, extending to as much as 700 years [11].

Now consider this - You knew many of these things, of the contributions from India, or of the universities in Ancient India. But when asked about education in Ancient India, you ended up picturing a Guru sitting under a tree, teaching Vedas and spirituality. Why?

The British Contribution

The British claimed that it was they who educated and civilised India, that they brought modernity to India. Contrary to their claims, research suggests that Indian education was much ahead, extensive and open than other nations at the time, especially Britain. The British education system was not so open, or welcoming, and only included the children of "gentlemen" or "nobles". In an extensive research on indigenous education in India in the 18th century, Dharampal quotes A E Dobbs (who researched on education in Britain from 1700 - 1850) thus,


Govinda Bhattatiri of Talakkulattur
(1237 - 1296 CE)
Grandfather of Paramesvara
(13th - 14th Century CE)
Paramesvara
(1360-1430 CE)
Damodara
(15th Century CE)
Nilakantha Somayajin
(1443 - 1555 CE)
Jyesthadeva
(1500 – 1600 CE)
Acyuta Pisarati
(1559 -1621 CE)
Trppanikkara Poduval
(17th Century)
Navayikkulathu Azhati
(17th Century)
Pulimukhattu Potti
(1686 - 1758 CE)
Raman Asan
(18th Century)
Krsna Asan (Krsnadasa)
(1756 - 1812 CE)

Figure 1

> …meet for the ploughman's son to go to the plough, and the artificer's son to apply the trade of his parent's vocation: and the gentlemen's children are meet to have the knowledge of Government and rule in the commonwealth. For we have as much need of ploughmen as any other State: and all sorts of men may not go to school [12].

Britain's perspective on education back in the 18th century is very clear. That education is not meant for all. That birth decides whether one gets educated or not.

Dharampal presents the status of indigenous education in India, as per surveys conducted by the British themselves. It reveals that India had at least one school per village or panchayat at the time. The surveys record as high as 100,000 schools in places like Bengal, Bihar, Punjab, Madras, etc [12].

In comparison, Britain was much behind, not just on numbers alone.

> … in many respects Indian schooling seems to have been much more extensive (and, it should be remembered, that it is a greatly damaged and disorganised India that one is referring to). The content of studies was better than what was then studied in England. The duration of study was more prolonged. The method of school teaching was superior and it is this very method which is said to have greatly helped the introduction of popular education in England but which had prevailed in India for centuries. School attendance, especially in the districts of the Madras Presidency, even in the decayed state of the period 1822-25, was proportionately far higher than the numbers in all variety of schools in England in 1800. The conditions under which teaching took place in the Indian schools

> were less dingy and more natural; and, it was observed, the teachers in the Indian schools were generally more dedicated and sober than in the English versions [12].

Furthermore, we have in Dharmapal's work, a report by the district collector of Ballari in 1823,

> The economy with which children are taught to write in the native schools, and the system by which the more advanced scholars are caused to teach the less advanced and at the same time to confirm their own knowledge is certainly admirable, and well deserved the imitation it has received in England [12].

Here we have direct acknowledgement from the British that the system of education in India is being imitated in Britain. With all these hard facts proven by meticulous research, how are Indians today stuck with the perception that it was the British who educated India? And to top it all, the actual impact that the British had on Indian education was disruptive.

Mahatma Gandhi's long address at the Royal Institute of International Affairs, London on 20 October, 1931, stated that literacy had declined in India in the past 50-100 years and held the British responsible for it [12]. When Dharampal published this research, he titled it 'The Beautiful Tree', based on this statement made by Mahatma Gandhi,

> …today India is more illiterate than it was fifty or a hundred years ago, and so is Burma, because the British administrators, when they came to India, instead of taking hold of things as they were, began to root them out. They scratched the soil and began to look at the root, and left the root like that, and the beautiful tree perished.

'The Beautiful Tree' that Mahatma Gandhi refers to here is the beautiful tree of education in India.

What really happened to education in India?

Given all the facts above, the reality is that we are still left with a British-introduced format of education in India. What happened? If not to improve, what could have been the reason behind changing the way education was in India.

One popular argument was that Macaulay wanted to remove the quality of Indianness from Indians, and wanted to make them more like the British. His speech in the British Parliament in 1835 is popular,

> We must at present do our best to form a class who may be interpreters between us and the millions whom we govern; a class of persons, Indian in blood and colour, but English in taste, in opinions, in morals, and in intellect.

To understand this better, we need to understand the vision that the British had on education itself, and India's vision of education.

The British view on education is well recorded. We saw that only children of nobles were educated. And before 1830, while 'schooling for all' was being pondered, no entity powerful enough ever spoke in favour of it [13]. In fact you find that such people opposed the idea. In 1807 a British scientist Davies Gilbert thus spoke in the House of Commons,

> However specious in theory the project might be of giving education to the labouring classes of the poor, it would in effect be prejudicial to their morals and happiness: it would teach them to despise their lot in life, instead

> of making them good servants to agriculture and other laborious employments to which their rank in society had destined them: instead of teaching them subordination, it would render them factious and refractory, as was evident in the manufacturing counties… It would render them insolent and indolent to their superiors… [13]

Those who promoted education for the working class viewed it more as a 'means of control' than a 'means of liberation', or a 'means of empowerment'. Education was seen as a way to pacify and mould the working class to fit into the existing social order.

Nobody was worried about giving education in light of the inherent higher purpose - the search for truth, or the real purpose of elevation.

In India, education has always been a path to liberation. It is the inner journey of each and every individual that takes them forward from wherever they are. It is about seeking and gaining knowledge to enlighten our minds and our hearts. Amma, Satguru Sri Mata Amritanandamayi Devi, often reinforces this great vision of education, "Education should spread light within and without. Education should equally develop discernment and contemplation. It should develop the child. Education should teach us to keep our inner eyes open just as much as our external eyes. Education should instil awareness and strengthen the deep bond between the student and his Nation, the World, his fellow human beings and other creatures, Nature and God."

It was in this vision that education was widespread in India. So, no matter what anyone learned, be it mathematics, physics, chemistry, or law, or be it carpentry, smithy etc., they learnt because they wanted to know more. Knowing in itself made them happy. This doesn't imply that gaining of wealth or means

of livelihood was absent in India. It is just that priorities that influenced education were different.

Read

'Jonathan Livingston Seagull' by Richard Bach

When the British were here, they may have found that people were educated, but they were definitely not employable for their purposes. For example, education in India did not teach how to be a good clerk or an accountant. This is where the British started creating their own educational institutions, that 'certified' people and ensured cheap employable human resources for their purposes.

Imagine the kind of education that only aims to make clerks, assistants, accountants, etc. out of you. British education hence generated a class of Indians who could work in the middle between the ruling British and the millions of Indians they governed.

Research also tells us that there are other things that the British did that disrupted education in India. For example, destroying the flow of funds that supported education in India. While these factors are there, what really broke the backbone of Indian Education is the disruption of vision of education.

Conclusion

Colonisation has rendered us prejudiced against our own Mother. Her knowledge and wisdom is second class to us. And we are drawn to all that glitters everywhere else. This does not mean that we demoralise European or western knowledge. There is good everywhere, wisdom everywhere.

So what is a decolonised mind? In very simple terms, a mind that is not colonised, right? It is not so difficult to understand

what being 'colonised' and 'not colonised' is. But what is difficult is that when we live thinking we are not colonised anymore (after 1947), someone comes along and tells you otherwise.

Decolonization simply means to recognise the colonisation of the mind that has happened to us, that it is very real. And to set ourselves free from this colonisation by being critical of the notions that come our way. We need to willingly make an effort to analyse before we accept something as true.
Being free thus means to be free of prejudices, to have a framework that automatically filters in the truth only, and to soar the skies of wisdom all over the world.

आ नो भद्राः क्रतवो यन्तु विश्वत्व् अदब्धासो अपरीतास उद्भिदः ।
देवा नो यथा सदमिद्वृधे असन्न-प्रायुवो रक्षितारो दिवे-दिवे ॥

ā no bhadrāḥ kratavo yantu viśvatv adabdhāso aparītāsa udbhidaḥ |
devā no yathā sadamidvṛdhe asanna-prāyuvo rakṣitāro dive-dive ||

May noble thoughts come to us from every side,
unchanged, unhindered, undefeated in every way;
May the devas always be with us for our gain and our
protectors caring for us, ceaseless, everyday.

Rigveda 1.89.1

Explore

1. We explored the effects of colonisation on those who were colonised. But what about the coloniser? Did colonisation have any effect on the British or Europeans? History of the coloniser is chocked up with a number of mass genocides. From the Jews in Germany, to the slaves in Africa, to the many many forced migrations, including the Goans in India, we can clearly see that colonialism has made the European colonists insensitive to genocides.

2. Have we ever questioned the traditions and beliefs of the British, and asked if they are progressive, scientific or modern? Whatever we are taught as better, were always things that were not pertaining to us. Moreover, to be that "better" we are taught to leave our culture and identity behind.

3. Even today, we talk about good education, or being a good student, to cause good employability. While this makes sense today, is there any other way of looking at education, and our studentship? Read 'Jonathan Livingston Seagull' by Richard Bach, and reflect on the decisions you have made regarding your education.

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Chapter 2

Windows to the Universe: Indian Darshanas

Introduction

The ancient temples of South India are adorned with stone-carved windows that captivate the eye and the mind. These windows, with their intricate patterns, not only frame the outside world, but also shape our perception of it. They act as mediators between the observer and the observed, inviting us to explore different ways of knowing and being. The remarkable diversity of these windows, found in the temples of Pallavas, Chalukyas, Cholas, and others, may also mirror the rich epistemological pluralism that characterises Indian culture, a culture that celebrates multiple paths to reality.

Pointing out the organic relationship between epistemology and science, Albert Einstein said:

> Epistemology[1] without contact with science becomes an empty scheme. Science without epistemology is — insofar as it is thinkable at all — primitive and muddled.

Epistemology and Science

A notable instance is natural theology, which views the world as a masterpiece created by a divine designer. According to this theory, the world is like a clock or a watch, and God is the master Watchmaker behind it all. The sophistications and intricateness of the workings of the world (watch), are understood as reflections of the intelligence of God (watchmaker). This philosophy has inspired scientists and thinkers to explore the complexities of living things, believing they were evidence of a grand plan by a divine creator. However, when Darwin's theory of evolution came along, it proposed something different. Evolution showed that life's diversity and complexity could arise from a process without any guiding hand - like a watchmaker who doesn't need to see what they're making - a 'Blind Watchmaker'. Natural theology faced a serious dilemma. Instead of a deliberate designer, evolution revealed a 'Blind Watchmaker' at work - where changes in living things are driven by factors like the environment, genetic variations, and survival pressures over time. This revelation shook the foundations of natural theology, leading to cling to ideas like 'Intelligent design' and 'Creationism' in an attempt to reconcile science with their theological beliefs.

Another instance comes from Marxism and the Soviet Union.

Pierre Duhem (1861–1916), was a physicist and a philosopher of

[1] Epistemology, the study of knowledge and its justification, not only enables us to explore various domains of inquiry, but also allows us to appreciate the scientific implications of our findings. However, epistemological conflicts may arise when scientific discoveries challenge or undermine a particular philosophical worldview.

science. He presented a unique perspective in his book, 'The Aim and Structure of Physical Theory'. Instead of seeing the laws of physics as definite truths, he viewed them as close approximations. Duhem described these laws as neither completely true nor false but rather as symbolic representations that capture aspects of reality in a more or less precise manner.

Later developments in Physics revealed that Duhem had actually touched the heart of a problem that physicists would debate passionately in the coming decades. For example, Louis de Broglie, famous for his equation of particle wavelength, saw the work of Duhem as 'a beautiful and great work where physicists of today can still find numerous topics worthy of reflection and study'. This acknowledgment reveals the relevance and impact of Duhem's ideas.

However, Vladimir Lenin[2] (1870 - 1924) disagreed with this view, and regarded it as containing 'the beginning of the falsity'. In 1908, Vladimir Lenin wrote a concise work called 'Materialism and Empirio-criticism'. In this work, Lenin critiqued and judged prominent scientists and philosophers of science of his time, including Alexander Bogdanov, Pierre Duhem, and Henri Poincare. Lenin's work set a standard where every scientific discovery and theory had to align with the specific ideology of marxism, with "correctness" determined by ideological commissars. This approach escalated into a state-controlled investigation during Stalin's[3] rule, leading to the persecution of geneticists and the condemnation of Mendelian genetics as

[2] Vladimir Ilyich Ulyanov, was a prominent Russian revolutionary, politician, and political theorist. Lenin served as the first head of government of Soviet Russia until his death in 1924. His legacy includes being the founder of the Russian Communist Party and a key figure in shaping the Communist worldview through "Leninism."

[3] Joseph Stalin was a prominent Soviet politician who ruled the Soviet Union from the mid-1920s until his death in 1953.

non-science, resulting in the imprisonment, torture, and even execution of geneticists.

So epistemological diversity is not just an abstract notion but a much needed one for the post-Darwinian and post-New Physics societies which value advancement in knowledge. This can be illustrated with two contrasting examples:

When Lenin wrote 'Materialism and Empirio-criticism', New Physics[4] was dawning. Science was well nearing what would be the epicentre of quantum revolutions. So the signs were clear as to the direction into which science was moving. Lenin's assertion that science should align with dialectical materialism[5], even if reluctantly or with reservations, reflects a rigid and dogmatic approach akin to religious beliefs. This perspective suggests that science should conform to predetermined ideological frameworks, endorsing theology or ideology, rather than allowing for open-minded exploration and discovery.

On the other hand Swami Vivekananda (1863-1902) considered religion to submit itself to the methods of science mercilessly -

> Is religion to justify itself by the discoveries of reason, through which every other concrete science justifies itself? Are the same methods of investigation which we apply to sciences and knowledge outside, to be applied to the science of Religion? In my opinion, this must be so, and I am also of the opinion that the sooner it is done the better. If a religion is destroyed by such investigations, it

[4] New physics refers to a range of fundamental developments and paradigm shifts that have occurred in the physical sciences, particularly during the latter half of the 20th century.

[5] Dialectical materialism is a framework for understanding societal development and historical change, emphasising the role of material conditions and the conflicts they generate. It forms the philosophical basis for Marxist theory, providing a method to analyse and predict the dynamics of social transformation.

> was then all the time useless, unworthy superstition; and the sooner it goes the better. I am thoroughly convinced that its destruction would be the best thing that could happen. All that is dross would be taken off, no doubt, but the essential parts of religion will emerge triumphant out of this investigation.

Yet his Vedanta could provide a framework that was far more visionary and holistic than the framework of dialectical materialism which not just strangulated science but sent scientists to gallows and labour camps in the USSR:

> Take anything before you, the most material thing — take one of the most material sciences, as chemistry or physics, astronomy or biology — study it, push the study forward and forward, and the gross forms will begin to melt and become finer and finer, until they come to a point where you are bound to make a tremendous leap from these material things into the immaterial. The gross melts into the fine, physics into metaphysics, in every department of knowledge.

The statement was made in 1896. It would be 29 years later, and 23 years after the samadhi of Vivekananda, that Niels Bohr and Werner Heisenberg would come up with the Copenhagen Interpretation of Quantum Mechanics[6] which would disturb Einstein enough to make the statement that, "God would not play dice with the universe". Einstein would collaborate with physicists Boris Podolsky and Nathan Rosen to prove the incompleteness of quantum mechanics, which in turn would unveil stranger non-localised quantum phenomena. But all that

[6] Highlighting the probabilistic nature of quantum phenomena, it introduces the concept of complementarity, stating that certain properties cannot be simultaneously observed. This view emphasises the role of observation in defining quantum states and remains a key aspect of quantum theory.

would be in the future. Much before any of those developments, this monk from a colonised world could predict the direction science would take in the next century.

Now let us briefly consider three traditional Indian knowledge frameworks (or epistemologies) and see how they could be used to view developments in modern science. Let us consider briefly three instances of how the Indic frameworks provide us ways to explore and view the problems and discoveries of science respectively.

Vedantic Satkaryavada

Have you ever thought about how a tiny seed can hold the potential to become a majestic banyan tree? When you plant the seed and it grows into a tree, you are not creating something entirely new or separate from the seed. Instead, you are helping to bring out the hidden potential that was there all along. The banyan tree is inherent in the seed, meaning that the essence or possibility of the tree already exists within the seed itself. This is the idea of Satkaryavada. It suggests that the effect (the banyan tree) is not something entirely new that emerges from the cause (the seed), but rather a transformation or manifestation of what was already present in a latent form.

Satkaryavada is the idea that cause is already present in the effect and the effect is present in the cause. Understanding the concept of Satkaryavada provides a specific kind of view on how cause and effect are interconnected. It is an integral part of three out of six schools, the Six Darshanas[7], Yoga, Vedanta and Samkhya. Through various metaphors, proverbs and philosophical

[7] The Six Darshanas are the six Schools of Philosophy in India, based on the Vedas. They are Samkhya, Yoga, Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Mimamsa, and Vedanta, each presenting distinct viewpoints on reality and spirituality.

discussions, this notion has become ingrained in the collective consciousness of Indian society, making it very easy for the Indian mind to embrace the concept of evolution. Unlike the ongoing conflicts in the West between religious fundamentalists and proponents of science education, India has a smoother acceptance of evolution due to the seamless integration of Satkaryavada into its cultural and philosophical framework.

Swami Vivekananda suggested the significance of Satkaryavada in the context of biological evolution. He proposed that evolution is not a simple process of new forms emerging from pre-existing ones, but rather a manifestation of what was already present in a latent form. He believed that evolution presupposes involution, meaning that the potential for evolution is already present in the original cause.

Interestingly, Swami Vivekananda also criticised the concept of 'Social Darwinism', which was popularised by British philosopher Herbert Spencer. Social Darwinism is the application of the principles of natural selection to society, suggesting that the strong should prevail over the weak. Vivekananda rejected this idea and proposed the concept of "Infilling of Nature"[8] (Prakrtyapurat), which emphasises the harmonious development of all living beings.

Similarly, Sri Aurobindo also recognized the relevance of Satkaryavada in the context of evolution. He would literally sing evolution into his mystic English verses of Savitri, where he described evolution as a process of rapid and sudden outbursts of manifestation from the unmanifest.

[8] Infilling of nature is seen as a natural process that occurs over time, driven by the inherent qualities and tendencies of each species. It is a continuous process of evolution and transformation, where each species is gradually shaped and moulded by the forces of nature. This idea is based on the Sanskrit term "prakrtyapurat" used by Patanjali, which refers to the process by which nature fills in and transforms one species into another.

The perspectives of Vivekananda and Sri Aurobindo align closely with the evolutionary theory of punctuated equilibrium proposed by Stephen Jay Gould. Punctuated equilibrium is based on the idea that species remain relatively stable (equilibrium) for extended periods, showing little morphological change, until a rapid burst (punctuation) of evolution results in the emergence of a new species. This theory challenged the traditional view of evolution as a slow and gradual process, suggesting instead that most evolutionary changes occur rapidly during speciation events, with little change happening between these periods.

It is not that Vivekananda and Aurobindo "discovered" or "knew" about punctuated equilibrium before Gould. It is about how they offered the Indian mindset a conceptual foundation and a comprehensive worldview to understand such concepts when they were introduced. They provided a framework that resonated with the idea of punctuated equilibrium, emphasising sudden bursts of change and manifestation from the unmanifest, akin to the punctuated shifts in evolutionary development described by Gould. Despite these insightful parallels, the challenge lies in how these Indian perspectives were often overlooked or underutilised in favour of non-Indic frameworks, reflecting a broader societal inclination towards external influences rather than drawing from indigenous philosophical traditions.Consider the following verses of Aurobindo in Savitri. What better way to introduce an Indian student, of any discipline of science and arts, to the wonder of evolution than through a panel depicting the phylogenetic tree of life with these verses?

If in the meaningless Void creation rose,
If from a bodiless Force Matter was born,
If Life could climb in the unconscious tree,
Its green delight break into emerald leaves

And its laughter of beauty blossom in the flower,
If sense could wake in tissue, nerve and cell
And Thought seize the grey matter of the brain,
And soul peep from its secrecy through the flesh,
How shall the nameless Light not leap on men,
And unknown powers emerge from Nature's sleep?
Savitri, Canto IV: The Dream Twilight of the Earthly Real

Jain Saptabhangi

Have you ever found yourself in a situation where you and your friend disagree about something, but both of your viewpoints seem valid? That's where the Jain concept of Syadvada comes in! Syadvada is all about understanding that truth can be relative and depends on the perspective and context.

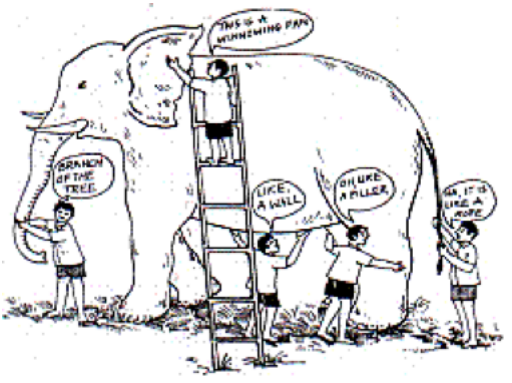
The term "syādvāda" comes from the Sanskrit roots "syāt" (meaning "may be" or "perhaps") and "vāda" (meaning "assertion" or "discussion"). In this context, "syāt" is often translated as "in some ways" or "from a perspective", emphasising the conditional and relative nature of the truth claim.

This approach suggests that every statement or belief should come with a reminder that it may only be true under certain conditions. By doing this, we can understand that apparently conflicting ideas might actually both be valid when viewed from different angles. So next time you and your friend have a differing opinion, remember Syadvada - it might help you understand each other better!

Syadvada is a philosophical concept in Jainism. It emphasises the relativity and conditionality of truth. It suggests that all philosophical statements should be predicated with the word

"syāt", indicating that the statement is true from a certain perspective or under certain conditions. For example,

1. The sky is blue, perhaps.
2. Maybe the pot is big.
3. Perhaps, the tree is tall.
4. Perhaps the river is flowing.



While addition of 'syat' (Perhaps or maybe), seems unnecessary here, the philosophy of 'Syadvada' asserts possibilities recognising that things may have many characters and can be perceived from different points of view. The old story of the blind men describing an elephant is one example.

The theory of Syadvada is manifested in Saptabhangi. "Sapt' means seven, and "bhangi" means "propositions" or "aspects". In the place of a binary truth table, this system of philosophy provides the seven possible states of any instance of reality.

1. Syād-asti ("in some ways it is")
2. Syād-nāsti ("in some ways it is not")
3. Syād-asti-nāsti ("in some ways it is and it is not")
4. Syād-avaktavyaḥ ("in some ways it is indescribable")
5. Syād-asti cha avaktavyascha ("in some ways it is and also

indescribable")

6. Syad-nāsti cha avaktavyascha ("in some ways it is not and also indescribable")
7. Syad-asti nāsti cha avaktavyascha ("in some ways, it is and it is not and also indescribable")

Have you heard of Schrödinger's cat, in quantum mechanics? According to the principles of quantum mechanics, until someone opens the box that contains the cat and observes the system, the cat can be considered to be both alive and dead at the same time. Do you think that a person who is familiar with Saptabangi will be able to appreciate the cat problem more easily?

Haldane, the polymath biologist, was so intrigued by this epistemological system that he attempted to create a 'logical classification of animal behaviours' based on this Saptabhangi model. Ever cautious, at the end of the paper, Haldane stated, "It is foolish to pretend that ancient philosophers anticipated all modern intellectual developments. And I believe that we, today, can do more honour to their memories by thinking for ourselves, as they did, than by devoting our lives to commentaries on them." And then he said, "But if we do so, it is our duty to point out cases where it turns out that our own thought has run parallel to theirs. I was unaware of Bhadrabahu's existence when I wrote the paper to which I refer. The fact that I reached a conclusion so like his own suggests that we may both have seen the same facet of many-splendored truth… If on the other hand, the contemplation of one's own mind, and that of the minds of animals, lead to similar results, such results are perhaps worthy of serious consideration."

It was not only Haldane who was enamoured by the Saptabhangi and Syadvada.

Bio-physicist Dr. G N Ramachandran was the one who

discovered the triple helical structure of collagen. It was he who developed the famous "Ramachandran Plot" which is used in the investigation of peptides, the building blocks of proteins. He also developed a vector matrix based on Saptabhangi. In his paper on Vedanta and modern epistemology, Dr. Ramachandran pointed out in simple terms the relevance of Syadvada and Saptabhangi to the method of science:

> For example, Newton's Laws of Motion were taken to be the absolute basis for physics, and a nineteenth century scientist would have answered the question 'Are Newton's Laws absolutely valid?' by a firm definite 'yes'. But twentieth century physics found it necessary to modify it, and replace it by Einstein's equations. In fact, nobody can say, even now, that Einstein's equations are the last word, because newer observations and theories can make still-further changes in them. In this sense, any theory (or any knowledge) derived from necessarily limited, incomplete, observation of facts, can never be absolutely true. This purely philosophical concept, which is obviously a very valid one in epistemology, was put in a practical form by the Jain philosophers.

Saptabhangi still awaits its integration into the science and arts education of the nation of its origin, so that Indians can frame the questions of exploration in science and experience the discoveries of science in a new light.

Buddhist Pratityasamutpada

Pratityasamutpada is also called 'dependent causation'. It is a fundamental concept in Buddhism that discusses how things happen because of a set of causes and conditions coming together. It helps us understand why things happen, and why it stops happening as well. "A substance does not exist in isolation," says

Nagarjuna[9], taking the example of the sprout: "for the sprout does not exist in the seed which is its cause; it does not exist in each one of earth, water, fire, wind and so forth, which are agreed to be its conditions; it does not exist in the combinations of conditions, nor in the combination of causes and conditions, and it does not exist as separate from these, free from causes and conditions."

Through this example, Nagarjuna reveals that nothing exists on its own. The existence of each and every phenomenon relies on a complex interplay of causes and conditions. Nothing can be isolated from its context.

Perhaps, Pratityasamutpada provides one of the most comprehensive frameworks to understand the concept of coevolution. Coevolution is the adaptation and counter-adaptation of species, where they evolve together based on the pressures they impose on each other. This leads to complex interdependencies and specialised adaptations in the interacting species.

Coevolution was familiar to Darwin. He wrote about "how a flower and a bee might slowly become, either simultaneously or one after the other, modified and adapted in the most perfect manner to each other".

The term 'coevolution' itself was coined only a century and five years after Darwin wrote those words in 1858. In 1964, Paul Ehrlich and Peter Raven[10] studied plants eaten by butterfly larvae. They discovered the plants evolving chemicals to reduce the larvae

[9] Nagarjuna was an Indian Mahāyāna Buddhist philosopher monk of the Madhyamaka school. He is widely regarded as one of the most important Buddhist philosophers, known for his critical analyses of false views about existence, knowledge, and reality. Nagarjuna established the concept of sunyata, or emptiness, as a fundamental tenet of the Madhyamika school.

[10] Ehrlich and Raven's seminal study, in 1964, introduced the concept of coevolution to a wider audience. Examining butterflies and their host plants, they proposed that plants' evolutionary development of defences could lead to rapid diversification in insects through counter-adaptation, a process known as adaptive radiation.

attacks and larvae evolving resistance for the same chemicals. They termed it coevolution. Since their paper- 'Butterflies and Plants: A Study in Coevolution', scientists, particularly ecologists and evolutionists, have recognised coevolution as, "one of the most important processes shaping biodiversity".

Another example of coevolution is the horse and the tundra grass. This coevolutionary relationship has been observed in cold, arctic regions such as the tundras of northern America, Eurasia and Greenland. Here, the horses living in the cold, harsh tundra regions, that have sparse vegetation (other than tundra grass), developed specialised teeth and digestive systems over time, to efficiently process the tough, fibrous tundra grass. In response, the tundra grass evolved features like increased silica content and deeper root systems to withstand the grazing of the horse, and maintain their presence in the ecosystem.

One wonders what example Nagarjuna would have given had he known coevolution. Just comparing this statement of Gregory Bateson[11], one of the greatest systems thinkers of our times, with Nagarjuna's statement shows the parallels: "the horse didn't evolve, the field grass didn't evolve. It is the relationship that evolved. The horse and the tundra with grassy plains are interlocked. It's an evolution in which the grass needs the horse as much as the horse needs the grass."

Nagarjuna's concept of dependent causation emphasises that things are shaped and defined by their relationships, rather than existing independently. Recognizing the interconnectedness of the world around us provides valuable insights that can advance our knowledge and improve our

[11] Gregory Bateson was an anthropologist, social scientist, and cyberneticist who made significant contributions to the fields of communication, systems theory, and ecological anthropology. He is best known for his work on the nature of communication. Bateson's interdisciplinary approach to understanding complex systems has had a lasting impact on a wide range of fields, including psychology, sociology, and environmental studies.

ability to solve problems. In this way, Nagarjuna's focus on dependent causation has important implications not only for philosophy but also for the pursuit of scientific knowledge.

Maya and the 'World-Knot'

Another great conceptual tool India has is its conceptualization or rather the discovery of Maya. In modern times, many have tended to dismiss Maya as just 'illusion'. Not only Westerners even within Indian tradition when Advaita had to be caricatured, its opponents tended to call it Mayavada. There might be some justification to this criticism because of some later day institutional development of Advaita. However when one goes through the texts and the possible interpretative space they contain one can only wonder at the expansive nature of Maya as a framework for doing and experiencing science.

Maya is feminine and is at once both the interface and the co-creator of reality as we perceive it. Then she allows us to understand the reality between the apparent binaries. While maya has often been portrayed as a kind of illusion and even an obstruction to realising the reality, Adi Sankara clearly points to her being essential for the ultimate realisation. He speaks of Maya thus:

> She is the undefined (Avyaktanaamnee) and the power of the Paramesa (Paramesa Sakthi); She is without beginning and is Avidya. She is the inner soul of three Gunas (Trigunaatmika). She is the highest inner Principle (Para); She can be inferred through the effects and can be done so only by those clear reasoning; Such is She, the Maya through whom emerges the entire existence.[12]

Of primary importance is the use of the term 'Avyakta'. In the

[12] Vivekachudamani (crest-jewel of discrimination: verse 108)

Saptabhangi or Syadvada of the Jains, 'Avyakta' becomes an important component. Of the seven states, four have Avyakta in them. Sri Lalita Sahasranama makes each of the defining names given by Adi Sankara to Maya, the name of the goddess Herself. Thus, she is Avyakta; she is Trigunaatmika; she is para; she is Avidya. In the sequence of names, while Avyakta is a separate name for the goddess, its opposite state, 'Vyakta', is not so. Instead, it is 'Vyakta-Avyakta' – there is no manifest system that does not have undefinedness or Avyakta in it.

What kind of visions can such a window help us see?

In a 2018 article, neurobiologists Todd E Feinberg and Jon Mallatt outline a crucial problem in the study of consciousness – 'an epistemic barrier' called 'auto-irreducibility':

> Auto-irreducibility means that once conscious is created, we have no knowledge of what neural processes are causing our experiences. In other words, we have no direct access to our neurons, only to the experiences they create. This barrier was first pointed out by Gordon Globus who called this an aspect of the 'world knot', a term coined by Schopenhauer to describe the multiple enigmas that are confronted when trying to explain the relationship between the brain and consciousness.[13]

The authors have already seen this as an evolutionary development. According to them, subjectivity itself "evolved such that it cannot be objectively 'experienced'..."[14]

The quoted Prof. Gordon Globus, now a professor of psychiatry and philosophy, has pointed out, in his original paper, 'The nervous system has no sensory apparatus directed to its own structure'. On his 1973 paper he wrote:

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[13] 'Unlocking the Mystery of Consciousness' (Scientific American, 17 October 2018)

[14] The Ancient Origins of Consciousness, MIT Press, 2016.

> The enigma of the relationship between mind and matter ... was termed by Schopenhauer the 'world knot' presumably because so many issues are tangled up in it. ...Mental events contain no information about any neural embodiments, ... Just as mental events contain no information about neural embodiments, the neural events per se contain no information that these events are neurally embedded.[15]

He formulated two identities – one is the subjective (S) perspective of a mental event that he called psychoevent identity, and another, the perspective of observer (O) in which the "S's mental events are strictly identical with S's neural events (psychoneural identity)." These two perspectives should be treated using Niels Bohr's principle of complementarity to move forward, Gordon asserted:

> Although equal in status, the perspectives cannot be applied concurrently and each provides different accounts of reality, just as light appears to be a wave or a particle depending on the method of observation, which methods cannot be applied simultaneously. Thus psychoevent and psychoneural identity are complementary in Bohr's sense... The relationship of the present application of Bohr's complementarity principle to the problem of mind and matter would seem to be deeper than a simple analogy to its application in quantum physics. Rather, both applications illustrate the use of a general philosophical principle.

Indian physicist and educationist D S Kothari (1906-1993) too had pointed out in his last paper, how Bohr's complementarity principle is a larger darshana (big picture) that can be applied in many domains of science. He also pointed out how this resonates

[15] Unexpected Symmetries in the "World Knot", Science, 15 June 1973: Volume 180, Issue 4091, pages 1129-1136.

with traditional Vedantic and Jain approaches to seemingly opposite perspectives:

> The core of the profound ethical and spiritual insights propounded in the Upanishads, Buddhism, and Jainism rests essentially on the complementarity approach to the problems of life and existence though the formulations may vary.[16]

Then, he quotes Sri Aurobindo's commentary on Isa Upanishad, where the seer lists binary pairs starting from the conscious Purusha and phenomenal Prakriti and, among others, the one stable Brahman and the multiple Movement, being and becoming, the Active Lord, and the indifferent Akshara Brahman, Vidya and Avidya, etc. Particular emphasis on Kothari's paper is on Avyakta in the fourth predication of reality in Syadvada, which he applied to wave-particle duality.

Conclusion

Let us be cautious. This is not to say we had all the knowledge. We come back to the windows. It is not about Globus and his approach to reality being right or wrong. More importantly he provides an instance of how the Indian Darshanas can provide impetus to do and experience science. One should remember here again that Niels Bohr's 'Copenhagen Interpretation' and David Bohm's 'Pilot Wave Theory' may be at odds with each other. But both Bohr and Bohm could use the frameworks provided by 'Eastern' traditions.

Each Darshana and concept can thus become a window. We have a unique opportunity of a variety of windows, through which we can shape our personal lives, our intellectual quests,

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[16] The Complementarity Principle and Eastern philosophy, Niels Bohr Centenary Volume, Harvard University Press, 1985, pages 325-331

our explorations into nature, and our experience of the universe. Indian culture in its entirety is then the grand temple of ages, and what beautiful windows they have – ones worthy of being guarded by Gods themselves!

Chapter 3

Ancient Wisdom for Modern Challenges: Panchamahayajna

Introduction

The 21st chapter of the ninth Skandha of Sri Bhagavata Purana, describes the story of Rantideva [1]. Sri Shuka narrates about the lineage of Rantideva and eulogises him for his compassionate actions. He was a king who inherited a large amount of property from his ancestors. However he gave up all his wealth for the poor and needy and ended up extremely poor. Enduring hardships with his family, there came a time when they had nothing at all to eat. Many days passed and once he happened to get by chance ghee and some cooked rice (saṃyāva). He whose family was distressed and trembling due to utter starvation and parched with thirst, was about to partake the food when a Brahmana guest arrived, just at the time of their breaking the fast. Since

the king visualised 'Ishwara' everywhere and in everybody, he happily offered his share of food to the guest who partook of the meal and left contented. Distributing the remaining food among themselves, while they were able to eat, another stranger arrived. Without any reluctance, Rantideva offered him food. After he ate and departed, there was very little food left. Then came another stranger surrounded by a pack of hounds. This person requested, "Oh King! Please give me and my dogs something to eat, we are hungry". The king received them kindly and gave to him and the dogs respectfully whatever food that remained with him. They left content and now there was only some water left to drink. While he was about to drink it, a Chandala came up and requested, "Give water to me please". Hearing his pitiful request, the king was deeply moved with compassion and he spoke thus, "I do not seek the highest position or powers or even emancipation from samsara[1]; I would rather prefer to dwell in all beings and undergo sufferings for them, whereby they may be free from miseries". Expressing such nobility of heart, the king who was compassionate by nature and full of fortitude, gave that water to the Chandala, though he himself was on the point of death through thirst. To him, Brahma and other Devas appeared and blessed him and he remained devoid of any desires, with his mind eternally fixed on Vasudeva.

The story of Rantideva is often cited as an example of the virtues of charity, selflessness, and righteousness, and it continues to be celebrated in Bharat's tradition as an inspiring tale of devotion to Dharma. But, is this idea of self sacrificing for the benefit of another person, a very singular idea appearing only in Bhagavata Purana? Unsurprisingly, no! The entire Purana-Itihasa corpus

[1] The cycle of Samsara is seen as perpetuated by karma and desire/attachment. Liberation or emancipation from samsara (called moksha) is considered the ultimate spiritual goal in many Indian traditions. This liberation is viewed as freedom from the limitations and sufferings of worldly existence.

of literature is abundant with praiseworthy stories in parallel to the story of Rantideva. In Shanti parva of Mahabharata, Bhishma narrates the story of a pigeon who sacrificed itself for removing the hunger of a hunter [2]. In another context from Mahabharata, Sage Markandeya narrates to Yudhishtira about the story of King Shibi who cut flesh from his own thigh in order to protect a dove and feed a hawk [3].

The famous dictum, 'Atithidevo bhava', originates in the Shishyanushasanam of the Shikshavalli in the Taittiriyopanishad; 'Shishyanushasanam' means the Guru is authoritatively giving final instructions to his student who has completed his stipulated study, and is now about to begin the independent life of a householder. The entire verse from Taittiriyopanishad of Yajur Veda [4] is:

मातृदेवो भव | पितृदेवो भव | आचार्यदेवो भव | अतिथिदेवो भव।

mātṛdevo bhava. pitṛdevo bhava.
ācāryadevo bhava. atithidevo bhava.

Be one to whom Mother is as Deva, Be one to whom Father is as Deva, Be one to whom a Teacher is as Deva, Be one to whom a Guest is as Deva. Or simply put, consider and treat your Mother, Father, Teacher and Guest as manifestations of Divinity.

This idea of deep concern for everything and anything other than oneself is not just an appreciation of the universal value of 'compassion'. If we try tracing the origin of this 'selflessness' aspect underlying the Indian way of thinking, we can see it to be the reflection of another profound underlying idea - "Interconnectedness of everything". This, in fact, forms the foundation on which the entire schema of traditions, practices and beliefs systems are built.

Are We Connected?

Many social scientists are of the opinion that it is this view of 'Interconnectedness' that distinguishes the western and eastern way of looking at things. An American social psychologist, Richard Nisbett's research on culture and cognition has explored how cultural factors influence perception, reasoning, and decision-making. In his book, "The Geography of thought- How Asians and Westerners Think Differently… and Why", he quotes -

> The collective or interdependent nature of Asian society is consistent with Asians' broad, contextual view of the world and their belief that events are highly complex and determined by many factors. The individualistic or independent nature of Western society seems consistent with the Western focus on particular objects in isolation from their context and with Westerners' belief that they can know the rules governing objects and therefore can control the objects' behaviour. [5]

From Vedic times to modern times, this view of interconnectedness is emphasised through dictums, stories, customs and practices. The entrance hall of the parliament of India is engraved with a verse which appears in Maha Upanishad and Hitopadesha - "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam" meaning "The World is one family" [6].

Mata Amritanandamayi Devi, popularly known as Amma, emphasises the importance of understanding this interconnectedness to lead a harmonious life.

> Everything in the universe is interconnected. The universe is a net held by each of us. When there is movement in one corner of a net held by four people, it reverberates everywhere. At times, people have told Amma about

experiencing a sense of imbalance similar to vertigo. This can be due to the disturbance of cells in the ears. The situation with nature has become like this these days. With each tree man chops down, he is making his own coffin. When we milk a cow, we should leave some milk for its calf. But today man milks until he gets the last drop. This harms the next generation. For this generation at least some fresh water remains. People make money and procreate, but imagine if there was no water left to drink! Along with making money and procreating, it is important to think of preserving Nature for the future generations.

Say a fire breaks out in a 10 story building and the person living on the first floor cries out, "Please help! Please come down and help! If we all try together, we can put out the fire!" But the people living on the top floor say, "It is not my floor; it is yours. It is not my problem but yours". But soon it will become their problem too. What is "his" problem now will become my problem in the future. It will come back to us. We should be aware of that.

This is how it is currently. One thinks it is someone else's problem – not mine. If an earthquake happens in one place, all the planes can be grounded for hours. So many businessmen can then be affected. No exports or imports, and so on. Like this, an earthquake in one place can affect the world. So many lives around the world. It is because of this that Amma always says that there is harmony in the universe. [7]

Will this understanding help solve problems?

This concept has important implications for our understanding of the world and our place in it, and it can help us to cultivate

a greater sense of compassion, empathy, and connection with all beings and entities.

On a global scale, we all have acknowledged various problems like poverty, climate change, equality and so on. From various small scale local clubs to highest bodies like the UN, people have resolved to address these challenges in different measures. It is true that within their scope of work, through events, activities and awareness programs, each of them have produced outcomes. But still, until one's attitude changes, all these measures to eradicate global problems shall remain superficial without touching the crux of the problem.

The Framework of Yajna

Yajna, a name that resonates from the vedic times, plays a very significant role in Indian culture and tradition. We find the reference of Yajna everywhere in Vedic and Post-Vedic literature. In the Bhumi Sukta of Atharva Veda, which is a collection of beautiful hymns describing our Mother Earth, it is said that Yajna is one of the principles that uphold and sustain the Earth [8].

However, there is a general notion today that 'Yajna' is a relic of the past. But once we understand the significance and the idea behind 'Yajna' we will be able to appreciate it and perform it even in the wake of this twenty-first century. Though a layman would relate Yajna to all different fire sacrifices that were performed during vedic times, Dhatupatha or the text that gives the etymology of the Sanskrit words ascribes three meanings to the root word 'Yaj' from which the word 'Yajna' is derived. 'Yaj Devapuja, Sangateekarana Daneshu'. The threefold meanings are Devapuja or worship of Devas, Sangateekarana or to bring together for a

collective effort and Daana means 'to offer'.

The Panchamahayajna Model

'Pancha' in Sanskrit means five and 'Maha' means great. This Yajna addresses five important relationships that, if kept harmonious, ensure happiness and prosperity at the personal and social levels. Sanatana Dharma instructs everyone to follow these five Yajnas every day.

The first is known as Brahma Yajna or Rishi Yajna. All of us are indebted to the ancient seers and sages for the treasure house of knowledge they have gifted us. Brahma Yajna is to understand the essence of ancient scriptures like the Vedas. Spending time with a spiritually illumined Mahatma and contemplating on his / her teachings is the best possible way to conduct this Yajna. However not everyone can meet and spend time with a Satguru. The next best option is to study the Itihasa-Purana corpus like Ramayana or Mahabharata or Bhagavata Purana, or Upanishads according to our temperament and contemplating on the teachings and applying the principles we imbibed into our own lives. Persistent efforts in this direction makes one stronger and wiser day by day, and such a person will be less afflicted by sorrows and pains of the world.

The second of the Panchamahayajna is Deva Yajna or 'Worshipping the Devas'. Deva Yajna is cultivating devotion in one's heart with a very strong understanding that all creation is a manifestation of Iswara. "Isavasyamidam Sarvam", says the Isavasya Upanishad [9]. Everything here is Iswara. Mantra Japa or repeated chanting of the mantra, contemplating and meditating on the Divine, doing Archana or chanting of divine names of God, Bhajans, are all different forms of Deva Yajna. Simply put, praying everyday and maintaining an inner connectivity to Divinity is Deva Yajna. Deva Yajna is also showing gratitude towards forces of nature.

Each element of Nature has a presiding deity like Surya Deva for Sun, Indra for rain, Varuna for ocean etc. Human beings' existence is dependent to a greater extent on these natural forces, and showing them gratitude is an acknowledgement of the interdependence.

Pitr Yajna is the conduct of reverential bonding with parents, grandparents, and ancestors, fostering family values for the unity and well being of the family. Rituals for the deceased, famous as 'Pitru Tarpana' is a common practice amongst Hindus and the details of the rituals can be found in many Smritis. The Shraddha ceremony has become a very important part of religious and social life, presently. Accordingly, immediately after a man has died, offerings are made to provide for him. Very interestingly, in the Itihasa Ramayana, we can see the Avatara Purusha, Sri Rama, doing obsequies or funeral rights for Jatayu, the vulture, Bali the monkey king and even for the enemy, whom he killed, Ravana. As per vedic culture, our self identity is not looked at only from an individual standpoint but it includes the family and cultural background as well. The individual is considered independent and yet an essential and integral part of a larger family unit where the well-being of one member lies in the well-being of all. A certain amount of voluntary sacrifice is needed to understand and accept this.

Serving humanity is the fourth Yajna known as Nru Yajna or Manushya Yajna. If we can sit patiently and think calmly, we can appreciate that each of our existence today, including health, wealth, education, position etc. is not the result of our efforts alone. It could possibly be the cumulative effort of millions. Once we realise and acknowledge that inter-connectedness, it would be quite natural for us to perform this Yajna as an obligation towards society. We can share our knowledge, resources, time and also pray for others. Merely accumulating wealth alone is

'not really living'. We should enkindle the spirit of sharing and caring for our fellow beings. There was a prevalent custom in Kerala, which existed till 50 years back. In traditional houses, before they shut down their gates at night, one of the family members would call loudly to check whether there was any person starving that night. If somebody responds, only after having served them food, would the house gates be locked at night. If you explore further back in time, you can see people adhering to practices like eating their meal only after having fed somebody else etc.

In Mahabharata, Ramayana and other ancient works, we find many discussions on the importance of supporting fellow beings. For instance, when Draupadi was married into the Pandava family, Kunti tells her how to divide food among themselves and Pandavas.

> "First take a portion and offer it to the Gods. Then give some alms to a Brahmana. Feed some to those who are needy, and give some to men who are around. Then, divide the rest into two parts. O fortunate one! Give half to Bhima, because that dark youth with a strong body is like a mad bull and is a warrior who always eats a lot. Then divide the other half into six, among the rest of them." [10]

One part of one's income was compulsorily required to be given in charity. In retrospect, how small have we reverse metamorphosed into our cocoon of self-importance.

The fifth and the last Yajna is Bhuta Yajna acknowledging one's connection with the flora and fauna. Living in conformity with Nature, showing compassion to plants and animals considering them as the manifestation of the same Iswara, is Bhuta Yajna. Sanatana Dharma is not an anthropocentric culture having humans as the central and most important

element of existence. 'The Earth does not belong to us but rather we belong to the Earth' is the beautiful perspective that thrived here. When we are in harmony with the natural laws which are consistent, unbiased and non-separate from Iswara, we remain in harmony with ourselves. Feeding animals and birds around us and watering and nourishing trees and plants are examples of conducting the Bhuta Yajna. There are many houses in India where they still practise this Yajna very devotedly. Once a day at least, people would feed crows or dogs or cats etc. which live around.

Human beings are deeply interconnected with the natural world around them, relying heavily on both animals and plants for their survival and wellbeing. We depend on animals for food, clothing, transportation, companionship, and even medical advancements. Countless industries and livelihoods are built around the use of animals. Similarly, plants provide us with the oxygen we breathe, the food we eat, the materials we use to build and clothe ourselves, as well as the medicines that sustain our health. Plants also play a crucial role in regulating the climate, preventing soil erosion, and maintaining the delicate balance of ecosystems. This intricate web of interdependence means that the wellbeing of humans is inextricably linked to the health and preservation of the animal and plant life around us. Recognizing and respecting this symbiotic relationship is essential for ensuring a sustainable future for our species and the planet as a whole.

Conclusion

Isn't the concept of Panchamahayajna a breathtakingly beautiful idea expressing and acknowledging the interconnectedness between everything that surrounds us? This deeper understanding of the oneness of all Creation, teaches humans to love Nature, and to develop a sense of reverence and devotion to all.

Amma's words echo through our hearts, reminding us that our entire life can become a sacred worship when we use our body to serve, our mind to empathise, and our intellect to share knowledge with others. If we observe Her daily routine, we will discover that she is the perfect embodiment of this profound wisdom.

The transformation we envision for a brighter future can only be achieved through our collective efforts. However, if we fail to shift our perspective on the world, the solutions we devise to tackle the problems will remain superficial, and the root causes will continue to simmer beneath the surface, waiting to resurface in unexpected ways. The ancient wisdom of Panchamahayajna invokes an individual's smart choice to live more harmoniously. These deep-seated challenges can be addressed to a greater extent, through a more profound understanding of the interconnectedness of all existence if more people subscribe to such a model.

Activity: Yajna in our daily Lives

As a student, can you suggest how one can practicalize the Panchamahayajnas in our daily lives?

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Chapter 4

Epistemology of Indian Philosophies

There is no greater wealth in the world than wisdom. Na hi jñānena sadrishaṃ, says Bhagavad Gita—there is nothing comparable to knowledge. How might one acquire this great wealth? What are the means to obtain it?

Bhagavad Gita says - shraddhāvān labhate jñānam, he who possesses shraddha shall obtain knowledge. Shraddha can be understood to mean faith, trust, or belief. It is developed alongside knowledge with which it has a dynamic relationship. For example, if we wish to put our trust in a particular person, we will first want to get to know them; and if we put faith in that person, we will be open to understanding them better. Thus, knowledge and shraddha increase and deepen together.

Faith and trust could be short-lived without the support of knowledge. If, say, we put our faith in a device that has not yet been sufficiently tested to warrant our confidence, we may be disappointed when the testing and use of the device reveal its flaws. Shraddha will be lost when knowledge reveals the truth

of the object. On the other hand, it may be difficult to develop shraddha with insufficient knowledge. For instance, parents may encourage their children to pray to God with faith and devotion. However, for a child who does not yet understand the concept of God, they cannot experience shraddha easily. For these and many other reasons, right knowledge is necessary for us to live life and progress spiritually, with confidence and conviction.

How, then, can we obtain right knowledge? According to Indian tradition, right knowledge is the outcome of rigorous investigation, jijñāsā.

There was once a conference held where many scholars and wise men from different nationalities, religions and traditions gathered. A question naturally arose: "Which of the traditions of the world is to be trusted to guide one to the Truth?" The scholars in attendance concluded that a tradition where there was freedom to investigate any subject or practice thoroughly by means of a rigorous system, was worth trusting and following.

Imagine two jewelry shops one next to the other. A customer comes to purchase gold and needs to decide on which shop to buy from. In the first shop, the shopkeeper assures the customer that they sell the purest gold. However, the customer can't ask for a certificate of authenticity nor are they allowed to test the metal in any way. "Just trust me," says the shopkeeper. In contrast, the owner of the second shop says that the gold sold there can be tested anywhere and in any way the customer wants; should an issue arise with the quality of the gold, they can always return it and receive a full refund.

In the above scenario, most people would of course purchase from the second shop: the freedom to test and examine inspires confidence. Likewise, a practice, a religion, or a tradition—whether it be Sanatana Dharma, or any other path—that welcomes an

intelligent investigation of its doctrines, inspires trust.

For an outcome of an investigation to be considered valid, the process must follow a time-tested rigorous system. With respect to theoretical investigation in the field of knowledge, all schools of Indian philosophy or darshana follow the principle of "vichara" or investigation supported by proof: pramāṇena vastuparikshanam vicharaḥ. The texts produced by all schools of darshana typically begin with a discussion of right knowledge. Vedanta, for instance, suggests athāto brahma jijñāsā or "let us investigate Brahman". It doesn't force the idea on the reader but rather invites one to examine and investigate the subject. Mimamsa, too, in dealing with the concepts of dharma and karma, proposes to study and gain right knowledge about them instead of postulating them as unassailable truths, immune to questioning. It is no coincidence that the Yoga Sūtras of Patañjali also start with an invitation to explore the ideas of Yoga: atha yoga-anushāsanam. Rather than giving an injunction, "shāsanam", the sutra suggests "anushāsanam"—a disciplined study of its subject. Nyāya, Vaisheshika,

Table 1: The Darshanas and their Pramanas

Sl. No	Darshana / School	No of Pramanas	Name of Pramana(s)
1	Sankhya	3	Perception, Inference, and Verbal Testimony
2	Yoga	3	Perception, Inference, and Verbal Testimony
3	Nyaya	4	Perception, Inference, Comparison and Verbal Testimony
4	Vaisheshika	2	Perception and Inference
5	Poorva - Meemamsa	6	Perception, Inference, Comparison, Postulation, Verbal Testimony & Non-Apprehension (Shabda is most important)
6	Vedanta	6	Perception, Inference, Comparison, Postulation, Verbal Testimony & Non-Apprehension (Shabda is most important)

and Sānkhya follow the same principle of fostering a healthy, methodical debate in pursuit of right knowledge.

There are six āstika schools of Indian philosophy which rest upon the authority of the Vedic revelation. In their texts, pramānas, or valid means of gaining right knowledge, are invariably discussed. We can see six pramānas outlined in the shat darshana texts,

Table 2: The Six Pramanas

Sl. No	Pramana	Definition	Example
1	Pratyaksha (Perception)	Knowledge gained by the means of senses is called perception.	That which is understood by the sense of sight.
2	Anumana (Inference)	Knowledge gained by the means of applying reason and prior knowledge to one or more observations in order to reach a new conclusion.	Inferring fire after observing smoke.
3	Upamana (Comparison & Analogy)	Knowledge gained by the means of either observing similarities or by understanding analogies of a similar word, object or situation.	A wild buffalo is like a domestic buffalo.
4	Shabda (Verbal Testimony)	Knowledge gained by the means of verbal testimony (Veda or Shruti).	Existence of heaven, hell and soul.
5	Arthapatti (Postulation)	Knowledge gained by the means of either supposition of a fact derived from circumstance or an already established fact.	Guessing movement of Earth by observing sunset and sunrise.
6	Anupalabdhi (Non-Apprehension)	Knowledge gained by the means of using existing knowledge of a negative as cognitive proof to derive further knowledge.	Vase in which there are no flowers.

with some schools accepting all the six while others may only accept three or four. The six pramānas are: pratyaksha, anumāna, upamāna, shabda, arthāpatti, and abhava. **Pratyaksha** is direct perception. When the proper senses engage with the proper object in the right way, the knowledge that is experienced in the mind is called pratyaksha. A defect in the functioning of the senses or in the object will result in wrong knowledge, pratyaksha-avabhāsa.

Anumāna is inference. An example of anumāna is when we see smoke on the hill and infer that there is a fire there. Here, we have knowledge about the relationship between fire and smoke through direct perception, pratyaksha. We know that where there is smoke, there is usually fire. By using this knowledge, we make an informed guess.

Upamāna is a simile or analogy. Upamāna is used where the object under discussion hasn't been seen or experienced. Let us take the example of "A wild buffalo is like a domestic buffalo". We may not have seen a wild buffalo so the person describing it to us compares it to a regular buffalo that we have seen before. Most of their qualities would be similar, so we can gain, say, 80% understanding of what a wild buffalo is using upamāna. Therefore, a simile or analogy can be a means of gaining right knowledge.

Shabda is infallible testimony, verbal or scriptural. In the Indian tradition, this pramāna refers to the testimony of the Vedas. The Vedas are believed to be apaurusheya, not crafted by humans, and thus free from error. Had they been created by man, they would reflect personal inclinations or prejudices towards caste, creed, religion or nationality. However, the Vedas are universally valid. In Indian philosophy, they are believed to have been discovered by the great sages in the same way that the law of gravity was discovered, not created, by Newton. Thus, the testimony of the

Vedas is accepted as infallible.

Arthāpatti. Many philosophers argue against accepting arthāpatti as a separate pramāna, postulating that it's the same as anumāna. There is, however, a subtle but important difference. In the case of anumāna, both cause and effect are known; with arthāpatti, we know only the effect, and it is by looking at the effect that we attempt to determine the cause. For instance, the Sun rises in the east and sets in the west. Even though we can't see the movement of the Earth, we can understand that it moves based on the effect on the position of the Sun. As this example shows, arthāpatti involves guessing the cause, which has never been observed directly, by observing the effect; anumāna, however, involves making a guess having observed both the cause and the effect.

Abhava is the absence or non-existence of a perceived object. Take the example of a vase in which there are no flowers: usually, there would be flowers in the vase, but they are absent. Not all schools of philosophy accept abhava as a pramāna, but some do because non-existence can be observed and experienced.

We can clearly see from the above that the six Indian philosophical schools place great importance on determining what is and what is not right knowledge. Each philosophical system's texts contain hundreds of pages of such deliberations. Mimamsa is especially preoccupied with working out a methodology for acquiring knowledge. The system it arrives at comprises five steps.

viṣayo viśayaścaiva pūrvapakṣastatottarama
saṅgatiścaiva pañcāṅgaṃ śāstre'dhikaraṇaṃ viduḥ

First, a proper subject is required for investigation; second, the doubts about the subject must be clearly stated; third, the counterarguments are postulated; fourth, the answer to the doubts, believed to be the correct solution is given and, finally,

a conclusion is arrived at where any doubts about the subject are clearly resolved.

The Indian philosophical tradition, we can conclude, is not one of blind faith and obedience to dogma. An example can be observed in the Bhagavad Gita when Sri Krishna and Arjuna engage in a dialogue, Arjuna is encouraged to ask questions and offer counterarguments to Sri Krishna's statements. When questions arise, Sri Krishna responds with logical explanations, but leaves Arjuna to freely choose his course.

iti te jñānam ākhyātaṁ guhyād guhyataraṁ mayā
vimṛiśhyaitad aśheṣheṇa yathechchhasi tathā kuru

Bhagavad Gita 18.63

Sanatana Dharma encourages learning and personal growth while providing reliable tools for obtaining right knowledge. A wealth of tried and tested wisdom is available to any seeker, along with the freedom of choice.

Chapter 5

A Vedantic Modelling of Human Personality

Introduction

Pakṣīkalpana Prakriya of the Taittirīya Upaniśad

Svābhāvika Kalpana is a natural assumption about what we are, the world etc. – this perception however commences at that which is tangible – the body.

Naturally it follows that in Euro-American Psychology, the path of inquiry is from the body to the brain to the mind and then to Consciousness, with consciousness being seen primarily as an emergent property of the brain.

In a diametrically different starting point, Indian spiritual psychology commences with a single unitary Consciousness that manifests numerously spatially and temporally. Thus, mind and therefore, psychology is emergent from Consciousness.

The Upaniṣads use a variety of approaches to validate the existence and the immanence of Consciousness and one such approach

is the narrative of Prakriya. Prakriyā – Pratikalpana.

In the Brahmānandavalli, specifically, a very beautiful imagery known as the Pakṣī kalpanā is used to explain the complexity of the human system, not merely as a way to understand the intra-system dynamics, but more significantly to help the seeker comprehend the nature of the Self within. Each of the Pañcamaya is explained in this text using the metaphor of a bird comprising head, two wings, torso and tail. Thus, the five dimensions of the human system are very elaborately understood through the five constituent components of each dimension. The allocation of different functions and processes to the different parts of the bird are not random. There is great coherence when we explore the interconnectedness of these five bird models and their constituent parts.

The Pañcamaya Prakriya is discussed in Chapters 2 and 3 of Taittirīya Upaniṣad, with the elaboration using the pakṣī-kalpanā appearing in Chapter 2 – Brahmānandavallī. The term, "Maya" implies a covering or sheath, however it is not one sitting on the other, but rather interacting aspects of the human system that both inform and influence each other very closely.

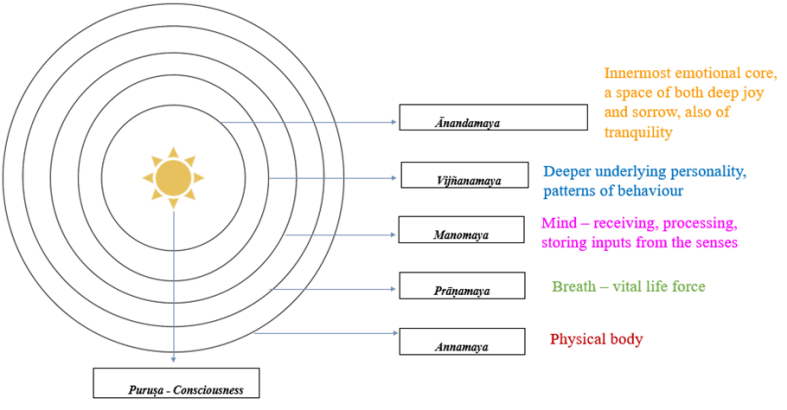


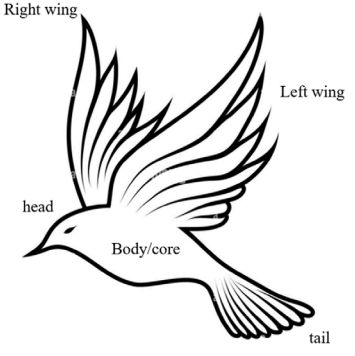
Figure 1: Pañcamaya Śarīra

The Pakṣīkalpanā model is a Vedantic one at core, intended to explain to a young student the truth of the ātman that exists within the five dimensions of the human system, transcending the material nature of the body and yet empowering and enlivening the system itself. This model is useful because it presents a remarkable way of understanding the complex dynamics between the body, breath, mind, personality and emotions. It can be applied in any therapeutic context and also from an HR (Human Resources) perspective, to understand or to explain many choices and outcomes through a cause-effect lens.

Annamaya

Annamaya is the physical body; the backbone is the skeletal structure – that which gives it form. At its core, you have the skeletal structure; at the outer level, you have skin. Within this, we are contained. We are made up of the seven Dhatu-s (of Ayurveda). The bird describing the Annamaya is simply a bird with head, wings, torso and tail.

For a bird, the head sets the direction, the wings enable flight, and the tail helps the bird navigate with ease and stability in flight while the torso holds the different parts together. Each part has a clearly defined role and purpose, much like the human body itself.



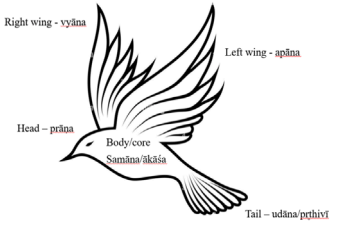
Brahmananadavalli (Chapter 2, Taittiriya Upanishad) defines annam as "adyate atti ca bhutani," which means that, when your adherence to diet is appropriate, it will sustain and nourish you.

When it is inappropriate (excessive, wrong), then that itself

becomes the cause for our illnesses – that is why it is, "that which consumes and that which is consumed". When food is abused, then it will itself become your enemy. This is why Annamaya is referenced here as Annarasamaya. Modern medical science now has much to tell us about the gut biome and its impact on psychological wellness. When the principles of Āyurvedic food and nutrition that are individual centric are applied, then one can work on positively supporting the intestinal biome, thus laying a foundation for salutogenesis in the system. A cross reference to Bhagavad Gīta, Chapter 17, Slokas 8, 9, and 10[1], shows us how food choices determine one's personality as sāttvika, rājasika and tāmasika.

Chandogya Upanishad (6.5.4) tells us, "Annamayam hi manah" – what you eat is the essence of your mind. Understanding food and principles of nutrition is essential in working with individuals in the context of health and wellness.

Prānamaya



Pranamaya – vital or energy body; physiological. This is the part of the system where prana is key. Merely having the shell is not adequate. That shell needs to be empowered, enlivened. That quality of life is given by the flow of prana. The prana is vital to hold this external superstructure. Symptoms can manifest at this level, too. Prana is responsible for the optimum functioning of the Annamaya.

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[1] āyu:sattvabalārogyasukhaprītivivardhanā: |
rasyā: snigdhā: sthirā hṛdyā āhārā: sāttvikapriyā: || 8 ||
kaṭvamlalavaṇātyuṣṇatīkṣṇarūkṣavidāhina: |
āhārā rājasasyeṣṭā du:khaśokāmayapradā: || 9 ||
yātayāmaṃ gatarasaṃ pūti paryuṣitaṃ ca yat |
ucchiṣṭamapi cāmedhyaṃ bhojanaṃ tāmasapriyam || 10 ||

Table 1: The Five Components of Pranamaya

Prāṇa	Location	Direction	Function
Prāṇa	Heart, Lungs	Upwards	Respiration, Vitality, Life-giving
Apāna	Lower Abdomen	Downwards	Excretion, Reproduction (Prājāpatya and Sūtika)
Vyāna	All Over the body	Circular	Circulation, Distribution
Udāna	Throat	Upwards	Communication, Holds Ādhyātmika Prāṇa in.
Samāna	Navel	Inwards	Digestion

The prāṇamaya or vital aspect of our system is made up of five components – prāṇa, apāna, vyāna, udāna and samāna. Their locations and functions are summarised in the table below and these are also correlated to the specific parts of the bird, as indicated in the diagram.

In the context of prāṇāmaya, some questions are worth pondering, for their answers will also reveal what makes us feel secure and what doesn't.

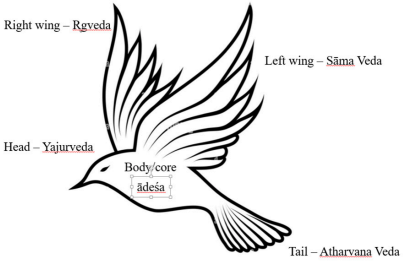
- With whom do we share our prāṇa space freely?
- How do we feel the depletion of prāṇa after being in a crowded space?
- How do we replenish prāṇa?
- Trauma as a transgression of prāṇā space
- Nurturing relationships, love, trust – connection to prāṇa and breath – willing permission given to share prāṇa space-
- Adrenaline surges – due to fear and excitement – how they deplete prāṇa

Our prāṇamaya is nurtured by our capacity to breathe in and out slowly and deeply, which as modern medical science today indicates, stimulates the vagus nerve which is responsible for

the rest and digest response of the body, essential for building immunity and sustaining health.

Manomaya

Manomaya - represents all cognitive functions and the use of the senses to process information.



Through the senses, we acquire information about the world around us. It is the ability to think and process that is manomaya. What we retain is the memory that we use to do our work in our life. It includes the senses because the mind cannot do anything without the input given to us by the senses.

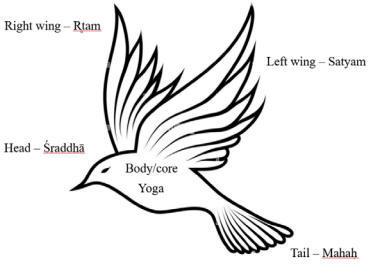
One's ability to understand something is based on our exposure to education. That plays an important role in our understanding of our purpose of life and the choices we make.

Essentially, manomaya represents knowledge gained through the senses, the storage and retrieval of this knowledge and how we are able to appropriately apply this accumulated knowledge contextually.

In the Upanishad, the four Vedas form the head, wings, and tail of the bird, for in that period of time, the Vedas were the means of education. The specific instructions communicated in the brāhmaṇa portions of Vedic literature as taught by one's teacher forms the core. This is comparable to modern systems of education in school and college as well, where diverse aspects of knowledge are gained through instructions as a preparation for further application.

Vijñānamaya

The Vijñānamaya is a deeper aspect of the mind. This is where all of our saṁskāra-s (habits / patterns accumulated over time through various experiences) are stored. This underlies the manomaya and colors the functioning of the manomaya. One's ability to think and to reason is colored by the baggage one is carrying. Most of us never see things as they are; we see things through a projected lens. Those projections are from the Vijñānamaya.



In the bird, śraddhā or an unwavering conviction in our path and the teachings of the Guru set the direction as the head. The wings are ṛtam and satyam, representing our capacity to comprehend the absolute, eternal Truth that underpins the cosmos and also how we are able to interpret and communicate that absolute truth (Ṛtam) through our words and behavior. Our intellectual honesty and sincerity stem therefore from this deeper aspect of one's personality, as also the absence of such a value based ethics.

For example, addiction to substances. There is some knowledge at the manomaya level. Everyone knows the harmful effects of smoking. Why is there such a high prevalence of smokers, despite knowing at the manomaya level? There is a total inability to act on it because the addiction has formed at the Vijñānamaya level. They think, "This makes me feel good" – and it is hard to break that.

The most important dimension of the Vijñānamaya is Sraddha or faith. The more intense one's conviction in oneself, and one's teacher and one's tradition, the less difficult our path seems to be.

The tail is mahaḥ, the sum total of all accumulated experiences that are subliminally embedded in the mind and which propel the ātma on cycle after cycle of embodiment.

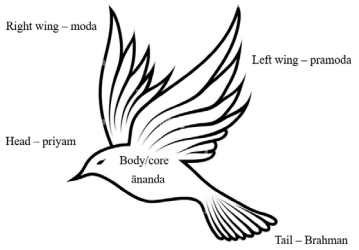
The core in the Vijñānamaya bird is Yoga. Here it is indicative of a state of mental resolution and the capacity to accept what is and to accordingly orient oneself to situations as they unfold. Naturally, the greater the resoluteness of the mind, the easier it is to navigate through challenges of life. This is why Vijñānamaya is the true indicator of an individual's personality and what affects or drives him / her.

Renowned Yoga master, T K V Desikachar called this, "Yukti." Yukti is an intelligent application – the ability to reflect on what is appropriate, for whom it is appropriate, how that tool is appropriate, and to apply the tool in the context of the individual.

For any relationship to thrive, both individuals must have strong dedication (Sraddha) to work together. This collaboration is essential to change ingrained but harmful patterns of thinking, speaking, and behaving that are detrimental to health. This transformation occurs on the Vijñānamaya level.

Ānandamaya

The innermost aspect of the mind, most proximate, is Ānandamaya. As the name implies, it is that capacity of the mind to transcend the waves of sukha and duḥka, and to remain in serene stillness, in spite of the sukha and duḥka that are parts of our life experiences. There is an ability to be fully at peace no matter what's happening on the surface. When you connect to that, you are basically tapping into your Ānandamaya. The purpose of all spiritual sadhana is to tap into that and make that very strong, so that it anchors us. No matter what happens in terms of sukha and duḥka, the Ānandamaya can anchor us, and give us hope. Meditation is essentially a stimulation of the Ānandamaya.



In the Upanishad, the head is represented as 'Priyam', the affection that arises in our minds as our first thread of connection to someone, the basis for any relationship. 'Moda' and 'Pramoda' are the increasing grades of joy experienced through the concretization of such relationships, and the delight of ānanda is the core of the Ānandamaya bird. As humans, we seek meaningful relationships between ourselves, and between us and nature, and these relationships fill us, literally and figuratively. Naturally, when relationships sour or in the face of loss, grief and anger, the relationships that fill us with ānanda also become a source of deep distress and pain.

When our Ānandamaya is so deeply affected, one finds it difficult to see pleasure in ordinary things. The Ānandamaya, when it blossoms, bestows a state where everything is experienced as joyful and beautiful. To be stable in this experience, is the state of the Yogi. But, for several of us, it can be the extreme opposite. This is where people with a lot of emotional trauma operate from – a place of hopelessness and despair. This is not our nature. It is a deep and systemic disturbance of our essential nature because of certain difficult and traumatic circumstances.

At the core of any holistic transformation lies connection. If there is no rapport, nothing will work. Such a deep relationship is what can touch an individual at the Ānandamaya level.

But, the pinnacle of human spiritual growth is to develop the capacity to experience every moment deeply and fully, receiving and giving, and yet without becoming entangled in the prisons of our affections. This is a knife's edge walk but the outcome is a serenity and fulfillment that is unparalleled. The tail of the

Ānandamaya bird represents our connection to the source not just of all that we experience but the very source of the universe itself, for all that there is, is simply the outpouring of Brahmānanda

Conclusion

This is but a brief glimpse into one of the most beautiful and useful models to understand the different dimensions that constitute an individual. As mentioned in the beginning, this model is presented to help us understand the nature of the ātma as verily the infinite Brahman, which is eternal Trueth (Satyam), the epitome of intelligence (Jñanam) and without beginning or end (infinite). This model can be unpacked to reveal deeper meanings and interconnections which can serve as a reference point to understand ourselves and others as well. The three Guṇas (sattva, rajas and tamas) form the building blocks of the universe and the dominance of any one of the triguṇā over the others at any given point of time determines our state of mind, the choices we make and therefore, the consequences of those choices. The Pakṣīkalpanā model has far reaching implications when integrated with psychological approaches, Yoga therapy, counseling, personality development methods, aptitude based training and so on.

References

1. Taittirīya Upaniṣad – Dvitīya Brahmāandavallī, along with commentaries of Śaṅkaracārya, Bhattabhāskara and contemporary commentators such as Swami chinmayananda and Swami Dayananda.
2. The Yogasūtra of Patañjali
3. The Heart of Yoga – TKV Desikachar
4. Health, Healing and Beyond – TKV Desikachar with Richard Cravens
5. Class notes from personal study with TKV Desikachar from 2003 till 2012.
6. Insights gained from 21 years of experience working as a Yoga Therapist at Krishnamacharya Yoga Mandiram

Chapter 6

The Wake-up Call from the Upanishads

In Search of a Human

People in ancient Corinth got amused by seeing him. In full daylight, he was strolling through the streets with a lamp, as if he were searching for something in pitch darkness. He was the great Greek philosopher, Diogenes. When people asked what he was searching for, he answered forthwith, "I am looking for a human." In a street crowded with hundreds of people, he is still searching for a "human". Another renowned Greek philosopher, Sophocles, says, "Wonders are many, and none is more wonderful than man." Have you ever wondered, what makes human beings special? Sophocles continues, "The power that crosses the white sea, driven by stormy wind, making a path under surges that threaten to engulf him." He is right; even though we don't have the physical ability to run like a cheetah, attack like an elephant, see like an eagle, or sniff like a dog, we still survive and transcend many limitations and challenges from nature.

Observe the accomplishments of mankind. They not only crossed the mighty oceans, but they even touched the moon. As an artist designs an art, scientists manage to design and edit human DNA. With their brilliant intelligence, they even started to make intelligence itself. They increased their quality of life and lifespan. However, if we look into them carefully, all these are nothing but their efforts to minimise sorrow and maximise happiness. That is common for all living beings. Moreover, we find that these advancements often complicate and even threaten the very existence of life. In his famous work, Acharya Chanakya says:

> Humans have eating, sleeping, fearing, and mating in common with animals. That in which men excel the beasts is discretionary knowledge; Hence, indiscreet men who are without knowledge should be regarded as beasts[1].

According to him, knowledge is the one thing that distinguishes humans from other animals. That knowledge is not ordinary knowledge that is only useful for living. Because even animals have the knowledge and necessary skills to get their food, make nests to safely live in, protect themselves from predators, attract their mates, and raise their children. Then what would be that knowledge that distinguishes humans from animals?

Conversation with Death

There is a beautiful story in the Katha Upanishad. A boy named Nachiketa went to the world of death. The god of death offered three boons for the boy[2]. The third boon he requested was actually a doubt. He asked for knowledge about death and life. Yama was reluctant to answer; He said that this knowledge is very

[1] "आहारनिद्राभयमैथुनानि समानि चैतानि नृणां पशूनाम् । ज्ञानं नराणामधिको विशेषो ज्ञानेन हीनाः पशुभिः समानाः॥", *Chapter 17, Chanakya Neeti*

[2] *The first boon was to pacify his father's anger towards Nachiketa, the second boon was knowledge about a sacred Yajna.*

subtle, and requested that Nachiketa ask something else. Yama offered him many precious worldly things; however, the boy, with strong determination, politely rejected all those gifts, and humbly requested that Yama clear his doubt. After many rounds of discussion, Yama was finally convinced by the boy's strong dedication and determination. He revealed the secret of death and life. The Upanishads say that eligibility for that supreme knowledge alone distinguishes human beings from animals, and that is the cheat code to crack the snake and ladder game of life and death.

Upanishads are part of the Vedas, and they discuss this supreme knowledge. Even though they are considered sacred literature, they are different from other religious scriptures. While religious texts are filled with matters related to God, praises to God, detailed descriptions of heaven and hell, and dos and don'ts, the focus of the Upanishad is more on the supreme knowledge that frees humans from the limitations and bondages of the world. While all other knowledge is about the objects that we perceive through either our sense organs or our mind, the supreme knowledge of the Upanishads is interested not in the objects that we perceive but in the perceiver itself. While answering Nachiketa, Yama is saying that:

> The knowing Self is not born; It does not die. It has not sprung from anything; nothing has sprung from It. Birthless, eternal, everlasting and ancient, It is not killed when the body is killed.
>
> Katha Upanishad 1.2.18[3]

This is the true nature of the self—Atman. It is not limited to the body, mind, birth, death, happiness, and sorrow.

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[3] न जायते म्रियते वा विपश्चिन् नायं कुतश्चिन्न बभूव कश्चित् । अजो नित्यः शाश्वतोऽयं पुराणो न हन्यते हन्यमाने शरीरे ॥ कठ उपनिषद् 1.2.18

Knowing the 'I'

We are always curious about the things we perceive. However, have you ever thought about the perceiver—the 'I'? All our actions are pivoted on this 'I', in all our conversations we repeat this word like a mantra, yet we are less informed about that very 'I'. You may know a thousand things about the world that you see with your eyes, but do you know the phenomenon that experiences the vision? Maybe you can describe the physical and cognitive processes of vision. But who is experiencing all these? What is that fundamental subjective experience?

There is a fascinating story. Once King Janaka had a bewildering dream. In his dream, he found himself as a destitute beggar, pleading for scraps and eventually collapsing from hunger on the streets. Suddenly he woke up from the dream. As he opened his eyes, the street and burning sun had vanished. He looked at his own body. He was not covered in tattered rags anymore. He was richly adorned with precious gems and dazzling stones that glistened like stars in the night sky. He was inside his luxurious palace, surrounded by servants attending to his every need.

This experience baffled him, and raised a question in his mind, "Am I the king who dreamt that he was a beggar? Or am I the beggar who is dreaming that he is a king? Which is my real identity?" He wanted an answer. So he sought his Guru.

The Guru revealed that Janaka was neither the humble beggar of his dreams nor an illustrious king, as he finds himself now. He is not even the unconscious one in the state of deep sleep. Reality is that he / she is the experiencer (the 'I'), unaffected by the experiences that come during sleep, dream or waking states.

That 'I' is not any of the objects we perceive because I am distinct from the objects that I perceive. Similarly, I am not any of the

sense organs, since I can perceive them also. How can I be the mind, different emotions, intellect, or thoughts? Because I can perceive them too! The Upanishads teach us that 'I' or Self is the 'witness'. It is free from all dyads like pleasure and pain, happiness and sorrow, and desire and distress.

The Real Nature

It is reasonable to doubt the existence of things like God(s), hell, heaven, angels, etc. that are beyond our sensory experience. One can even doubt the existence of objects that are empirically experienceable. For example, in deserts, we may see an oasis with our eyes, but when we reach closer, we realise there is no oasis; it was a mirage. Sometimes we may even doubt the existence of our own body. However, irrespective of the situation, nobody can doubt the existence of the 'I'. Because existence is the very nature of the self, it is called 'Sat'.

This 'I' consciousness forms the basis of all sensory perception and knowledge acquisition. Knowledge, or cognition, is possible only if there is a perceiver to perceive and comprehend. This consciousness is the light that illuminates everything. We can know about things outside of us through our sense organs. Things in the dream and mind we can know through the mind itself. However, without the mind or sensory organs, we are still able to know the presence of that subjective experience. We know because it is self-luminous. This consciousness is the nature of the 'I', it is the base of all other knowledge. It is called 'Chit'.

In the Brihadaranyaka Upanishad, King Janaka asks Sage Yajnavalkya, "What is the light that illuminates a person, the light that awakens and impels him to perform all that he does?" "Sun", the Sage replied. But the King again asked, "What helps a person in the absence of the sun at night?" "Moon", Yajnavalkya replied. "What is the light in the absence of both the sun and

the moon?"Janaka raised another question. "Fire is the light for us in the absence of the sun and moon", the Sage answered. The king did not stop there, "What is the light in the absence of the sun, moon and fire". "Voice is the light in the absence of other lights. We use voice and move forward in the absence of light", the Sage replied. "What is the light in the absence of sun, moon, fire and voice?", he wondered again. The Sage replied, "Even in the absence of the sun, moon, fire and voice, we have a light, that is the Self."

After listening to this answer, Janaka got the clarity that the self is the light of lights, which illuminates even the fire, moon and sun. In a dark room, when we switch on the light, everything is revealed by that light— tables, chairs, beds, everything in that room is revealed by that light. But to see that light we don't need any other light. Because that light is visible by its own light. Similarly, consciousness is the very nature of Self. Self is consciousness. All the experiences, thoughts, and physical world are based on consciousness. Just like we are watching a movie on screen, everything appears on the screen of consciousness.

In the absence of emotions, thoughts, and external objects, what is our experience? For example, in deep sleep, we are completely separated from things that bring happiness or sorrow. There are no thoughts or dreams in the mind to indulge in. Without internal and external things, we experience absolute peace, or bliss. Irrespective of external situations, whether you are a millionaire or a beggar, in deep sleep you experience bliss. Bliss, or Ananda, is the nature of the 'I'.

The Upanishads teach us that, Sat-Chit-Ananda (Existence, consciousness, and bliss) is the real nature of the individual self. They also proclaim that the world that we perceive has a relative existence; the base of the ever changing world is the changeless supreme self. Even though different

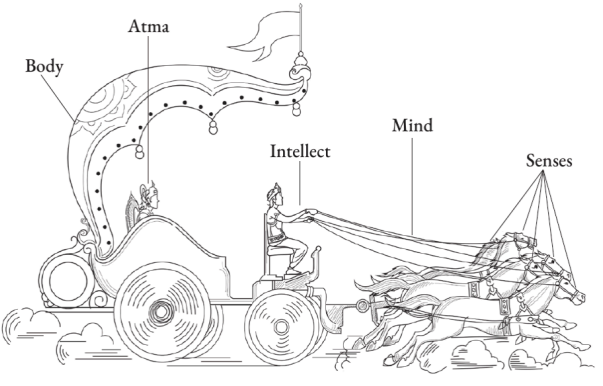
ornaments have relative existence, in reality they are just the same gold. Similarly, the world that we experience is the non-dual supreme self in ultimate reality. According to the Upanishads, when we realise this non-dual nature of reality, we transcend all delusions and grief. This potential for realising this knowledge, makes human beings distinct from animals.

Ignorance to Awareness

In our worldly circumstances, we experience suffering and grief, but upanishads say our true nature is Ananda; how could that be possible? The Upanishads point towards ignorance, where we wrongly perceive ourselves as a combination of mind, body, and intellect. As one thinks the moon is distorted, by seeing the reflection of the moon in moving water, we are wrongly identifying ourselves with body, mind, and intellect. In fact, as the moon is not affected by the distortion of its reflection, so is the self unaffected by different states of the body, and emotions, and thoughts of the mind.

Yama illustrates this idea through the brilliant analogy of a chariot.

He says the senses are the horses, and they run through different roads that are the objects. The Body is the chariot and intellect



is the charioteer who controls the sense–horses with the reins of mind. Atman, or the self, is the master of the chariot and unaffected by mind, body, and intellect[4].

> **Activity:** Reflect on the chariot metaphor from the Katha Upanishad: Why are senses compared to horses, objects to roads, body to the chariot, and intellect to the charioteer? Why is Atman, the self, depicted as the master of the chariot, unaffected by mind, body, and intellect?

According to the Upanishads, we are not sinners or slaves, but we are the children of immortality. Shvetashvatara Upanishad glorifies us as "Listen, O the children of immortality the world over"[5]. All of us are potentially divine. They call on us to remove the wrong identification, and realise our true nature, which is free from all grief and delusion.

Amma says, "We are not candles to be lit by somebody else. We are the self-effulgent sun."

Upanishads ask us to be strong by shedding down false identifications and weaknesses. According to them, that should be the ultimate aim of all spiritual and religious practices. They proclaim eternal independence from all the bonds. To realise this ultimate knowledge, the Lord of Death suggests a practical method,

Uttishtata jagrata prapya varannibodhata

Arise! Awake! Approach the great and learn[6]

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[4] Katha Upanishad 1.3.4

[5] शृण्वन्तु विश्वे अमृतस्य पुत्रा (śṛṇvantu viśve amṛtasya putrā), Shvetashvatara Upanishad 2.5

[6] Katha Upanishad 1.3.14

"The Upanishads are the great mine of strength. Therein lies strength enough to invigorate the whole world; the whole world can be vivified, made strong, energised through them. They will call with trumpet voice upon the weak, the miserable, and the downtrodden of all races, all creeds, and all sects to stand on their feet and be free. Freedom, physical freedom, mental freedom, and spiritual freedom are the watchwords of the Upanishads."

Swami Vivekananda (Lectures from Colombo to Almora-Vedanta in its Application to Indian Life)

Chapter 7

Goals of Life

Amidst the roaring waves and bone chilling cold, Abhilash Tommy was not distressed because he had a mission to accomplish. Abhilash Tommy is a retired Indian Navy officer, and he is the first Indian to have completed a solo, non-stop circumnavigation of the world under sail. Have you ever wondered how such adventures are even possible for a human being? According to the conventional way of looking at life, survival is the most important thing. But in the case of Abhilash Tommy, he was not only making a world record, but he was actually proving that the conventional way of looking at life is wrong.

Survival and procreation might be enough for animals and other creatures, but in the case of humans, they owe much more. They can transcend these basic requirements and pursue more meaningful things. The needs of each person are different. Once they have their basic necessities, they will pursue different things. Some of them will try to earn more money, while others are interested in name and fame; some might be more into luxuries; some spend their time studying more things; and some others

do all kinds of crazy stuff. Although people pursue different things in life, there is something in common. If you look carefully you will find that, at the core of all these pursuits are two main goals: enjoyment of pleasure, and avoidance of pain.

The means might be different, but all our endeavours are aimed at getting happiness or avoiding sorrow. This pleasure seeking attitude is driving human behaviour. Indian knowledge systems (IKS) identify this attitude as one of the important goals of human life. It is called 'Kāma'. Kāma means 'desire'. It can be any desire - desire for sensual pleasures, name, or fame, etc.

If you have a kāma, or a desire for something, it immediately creates a feeling of lack in your mind. For instance, if you have a strong desire to watch a new movie, it will automatically create a feeling of uneasiness in your mind, something like a craving. You will get rid of that by watching that movie. To get rid of that uncomfortable feeling, you will try to fulfil that desire.

To fulfil any kāma it is necessary to make an effort. For example, if you have the desire to eat a mango, you have to first pluck it from a mango tree. This is where effort comes in, while fulfilling a desire. You can also buy it from a shop using the money that you have. Even in that case, money is nothing but the result of your previous efforts. This is not just the case of eating a mango or banana; even if you have a kāma to buy a Lamborghini or a Porsche, you need enough money. IKS considers this economic value or effort factor as another aim for human life, and it is called Artha.

Artha is not only money; anything that we consider to be wealth is artha. Health, education, family, friends, power, and position provide access to kāma. In that context, they all can be called artha.

All our pleasures are related to these two aspects, artha and kāma. For a successful life, we need to understand how to properly manage them. All the conflicts we see in the world are nothing

but the result of poor management of artha and kāma. If a person focuses only on fulfilling kāma without paying attention to gaining artha, it is a trap that not only gradually removes their access to any kāma, but also pushes them into extreme pain and distress. We often hear about people who fail to tally their expenses with their income and end up in debt traps. Even if we manage to get some artha, mindful and smart management are required to sustain it. There is another category; people focus just on artha. They just earn more and more money, gold, and other assets. However, in this process, they forget to enjoy their lives.

And there are people who don't care for their health or family, and focus on work instead. This too is mismanagement of artha. While such people may earn money, they lose out on good health, and care of loved ones. What kāma can we enjoy, in poor health, physical or mental? Amma often discusses the case of people who commit suicides in air conditioned homes.

Now we know kāma and artha, but still, something is missing. What will happen if everyone starts pursuing artha and kāma without any checks and balances?

First of all, we don't have that many resources to fulfil everyone's kāma. Needs thus are unlimited, but actual resources are not. It will lead to social turmoil and conflicts. Already, we are short of resources. We humans are using natural resources 1.7 times faster than the earth's biocapacity can regenerate. In other words, we are using the resources of 1.7 Earths! According to the Global Footprint Network's calculation, if everyone in the world is desiring to live like an average American, then we require 5.1 earths to provide those resources.

Activity 2: Visit https://overshoot.footprintnetwork.org/ and look into the "How many Earths would we need if everyone on the planet lived like the residents of your

country?" Study and analyse India's data.

Many of the wars and conflicts have been happening to gain more resources, to fulfil either the ruler's kāma or the citizen's kāma.

Activity 3: List out the wars and conflicts and map it with the Artha-Kama concept

Even if we have enough resources, an immature way of enjoying kāma will not help us get happiness. Only if we fulfil our kāma without harming our body, mind, family, society, or environment, can we achieve happiness and peace. Substance abuse and the consumption of unhealthy foods may give temporary satisfaction, but it will harm our body and eventually destroy not only our Artha, but also the very ability to experience pleasure. Therefore, IKS identifies 'Dharma' as an important aim for human life.

Activity 4: How does fulfilling kāma by harming the body, mind, family, society or environment, eventually destroy artha and denies access to pleasures? Discuss with examples.

Dharma is a non-translatable Sanskrit term. Dharma is often translated as 'righteousness', but dharma has more deep and encompassing aspects than righteousness. IKS describes it as the principle that sustains the entire world and the reason for the complete wellbeing of all the living beings[1]. In the Mahabharata, Maharshi Veda Vyasa emphasises the importance of Dharma in achieving kāma and artha.

"I cry with my arms raised, but nobody listens to me. From Dharma come artha and kāma. Why doesn't anybody heed this?"[2]

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[1] "jagatah sthiti karanam praninam sakshat-abhyudaya-nihshreyasa-hetuh", Bhagavad Gita Bhasya of Sri Sankaracharya.

[2] ūrdhvabāhurviraumyeṣa na ca kaścicchṛṇoti me | dharmādarthaśca kāmaśca sa kimarthaṃ na sevyate || Mahabharata 18.5.49

How long can one acquire artha, and enjoy kama, adharmically (illegally, disrupting the existing system or unsustainably, causing hurt in the process, etc.). Acquiring artha adharmically may seem like easy money, but it's highly risky, and never lasts. Over and above, if one has what it takes to take such risks, why not use it to achieve by fair means? This is exactly what Maharshi's Vyasa expresses in his lamentation.

Dharma also denotes fundamental quality, for example it says heat and light are the Dharmas of fire. Dharma can have the meaning of duty or responsibility. For instance, the Dharma of a king is to protect his citizens.

Similarly each and everyone has their own dharma to play, it is known as 'svadharma'. Svadharma is not only based on one's own responsibilities but also their Guṇas (qualities and aptitude). In the present day scenario, people might do things to gain money. There is no harm in that, but IKS suggests that it should align with one's qualities and aptitudes as well as the collective good.

In short, Indian Knowledge Systems advises us to gain artha and fulfil kāma according to Dharma. Because, it is only through Dharma can we truly gain artha and fulfil our kama. And it is only through Dharma that we truly grow as a person (leading us to the fourth goal).

But still the happiness we are achieving through fulfilling our kāma is momentary. For instance, you had a kāma to buy a brand new phone. You then managed to arrange enough money to buy that phone, and you bought it. You will feel extreme happiness; however, it won't last forever, if it gets damaged, you will lose your happiness, and even if it doesn't, you will also get bored with that phone eventually. As a trough follows a crest in waves, so does sorrow follow happiness. So, to attain eternal happiness and a permanent cessation of sorrow, one has to

transcend their kāma.

The Bhagavata Purana articulates this through the simile of fire and ghee. The purana says: "As supplying butter to a fire does not diminish the fire but instead increases it more and more, the endeavour to stop desires by continual enjoyment can never be successful"[3]. Today, we have enough empirical studies to back this up. First of all, things do not feel the way we anticipate they will [1]. Even if they provide satisfaction, it will not last forever [2].

> **Activity 5:** Share some of your experiences of a fulfilled desire. How did you feel after fulfilling it? Was it the same as your anticipation? How long did that happiness last with the same intensity?

It is in this very pursuit of eternal happiness and a permanent cessation of sorrow, that the great Rishis discovered moksha. Simply put Moksha is permanent liberation from sorrow. According to the Rishis, the real source of happiness is not the objects, but it is within us. Just like a musk deer searching for the cause of the fragrance of the musk, we are in search of happiness. Happiness is not something to achieve; in fact, our real nature is happiness. By realising this, one can permanently be liberated from the cycle of the dualities: happiness and sorrow; punya and papa, life and death. This realisation is the goal of all spiritual practices.

The four aims of life are: Dharma, Artha, Kama, and Moksha. Together, they are called Purusharthas. Dharma is considered the primary Purushartha, since it ensures the sustenance of person and the society. Purusharthas are the blueprint for a successful life. Indian Knowledge Systems advise us to gain Artha and

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[3] na jātu kāmaḥ kāmānām upabhogena śāṁyati | haviṣā kṛṣṇa-vartmeva bhūya evābhivardhate || Srimad Bhagavata Purana 9.19.14

fulfil Kama adhering to Dharma, and also realise mokṣa as the ultimate aim. Though a bird travels miles in search of food, it is not forgetting its nest. In a similar manner, we can try to fulfil our Kāma, gain Artha, according to Dharma. At the same time we should not forget the truth that the happiness we gain from artha-kamas have limitations. The true happiness and permanent redemption from sorrow is only possible through Moksha, that is the realisation of our true nature.

Activity 6: Categorise all of your needs and wants into these four categories, and try to find out if anything does not fall under the framework of Purusharthas.

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Chapter 8

The Six Ingredients of Success

"With hard work comes knowledge, respect, wealth, and more"

These words are very popular. The most coveted possessions in life – health, wealth, knowledge, meaningful relationships, and respect – are all rooted in the soil of diligent effort. The capacity to achieve anything through sheer hard work is a remarkable gift, special to human kind.

Yet, it is also in our experience that, many times, our efforts don't yield the desired fruits. Students who fail after studying hard, dedicated and hardworking employees overlooked for promotion, and people whose ailments remain despite treatment. The list goes on. Sincere love that is misunderstood, favours that are left unappreciated, and service activities that do not give satisfaction, are all familiar to us.

What could be the reason behind such failures? Isn't success achievable through effort alone? Or are there other factors that control our successes? Such thoughts are likely to arise

in anyone's mind at such moments. Scholars posit that there are other factors supporting the success of efforts. There is a subhashita that reveals six necessary qualifications in addition to effort, for all round achievement -

प्रसन्नमूर्त्तिः समुदारचेताः वम्शाभिमानी शुभवाग्विलासः |
अनीतिभीतिर्गुरुसाधुनम्रः साम्राज्यलक्ष्मीं लभते मनुष्यः ||

prasannamūrtti: samudāracetā: vamśābhimānī śubhavāgvilāsa:
anītibhītirgurusādhunamra: sāmrājyalakṣmīṃ labhate manuṣya:

A person who has a pleasant demeanour, a noble mind, pride in their lineage, eloquent speech, fear of wrong doing, and humility towards the Masters and the virtuous, attains the wealth and prosperity of an empire.

This subhashita reveals what kind of a personality it takes to make that great achievement of full and well rounded success. Only a person who is pleasant, magnanimous, proud of their lineage, speaks auspicious words, fears wrongdoing, and is humble towards teachers and virtuous individuals can attain such success. Let us examine these six qualities, which accompany effort, and form the foundation of success.

1. Prasannamūrttih

This means, 'a person with a pleasant disposition'. The great malayalam poet K C Keshavapillai highlights the importance of a pleasant demeanour thus, "The Purushothama (supreme human being) is one who has grace in his face, compassion in his eyes, and sweetness in his words." Highlighting the greatness of such pleasantness in attitude, Swami Vivekananda says, "Despair, whatever form it may take, is not a religion. By being content and having a pleasant face, you are approaching God. No prayer has this power"[1]. To remove the obstacles in our path to victory,

[1] 'Thus Spake Vivekananda', Sri Ramakrishna Math Chennai, 1987.

we chant in the beginning of all our rituals, this invocation-

शुक्लाम्बरधरं विष्णुं शशिवर्णं चतुर्भुजम् ।
प्रसन्नवदनं ध्यायेत् सर्वविघ्नोपशान्तये ||

śuklāmbaradharaṃ viṣṇuṃ śaśivarṇaṃ caturbhujam
prasannavadanaṃ dhyāyet sarvavighnopaśāntaye

I meditate upon (Lord Ganesa), the one who wears a white garment, who is all-pervasive, who has a (bright) complexion like the moon, who has four hands, who has a cheerful face, for the removal of all obstacles.

Here, pay attention to the word 'Prasannavadanaṃ' (pleasing face). Doesn't the statement that the 'Prasannamoorthi' (the one with a pleasing face) removes obstacles indicate that our own 'Prasannata' (pleasing nature) leads us to victory?

2. Samudāracetāh

Samudāracetāh means 'one who has a generous mind'. Generosity is always superior to selfishness. But to be generous one needs a lot of patience. We can see a lot of tales portraying this virtue in our Itihasas and Puranas, and in the annals of our history.

Let us visit a popular short story. One day, a poet from the court of King Bhoja[2] was walking through the streets of the capital at noon. The ground was scorching hot due to the sun. At the same time, an old beggar was walking along the street. He had no footwear and was walking with great difficulty. Seeing the beggar in such a pitiable state, the poet's heart melted. The poet gave his own sandals to the beggar. Although the sandals were old, they were still usable. The beggar was relieved, but the poet was now in discomfort. He had never walked without sandals

[2] King Bhoja (1010-1055 CE) was a renowned scholar-king of the Paramara dynasty. He is celebrated for his contributions to literature, architecture, and education. Bhoja authored or commissioned at least 84 works on diverse subjects. He founded the city of Bhopal and constructed the Bhojeshwar Temple.

before. Now, the ground was scorching, and his feet burned. The poet hurried along. Just then, the king's mahout came by with the royal elephant. Seeing the royal poet in distress, the mahout quickly helped him onto the elephant. After a short distance, they encountered King Bhoja himself, travelling in his chariot along the same path. Seeing the poet on the elephant, King Bhoja asked in amazement, "How did you get on the royal elephant?" The royal poet replied with a verse,

उपानहं मया दत्तं जीर्णं कर्णविवर्जितम् ।
तत्पुण्येन गजारूढो न दत्तं वैहि तद्गतम् ॥

upānahaṃ mayā dattaṃ jīrṇaṃ karṇavivarjitam
tatpuṇyena gajārūḍho na dattaṃ vaihi tadgatam

I gave away my old, strapless sandals.
That merit lifted me onto the elephant.
What is not given is as good as lost, is it not?

The profound meaning of this statement greatly impressed the noble-hearted King Bhoja. He gifted the elephant to the poet! We do not need to be wealthy to show generosity. It is enough to share a portion of what we have with those in need. This act of sharing is praised as a sacrifice, a principle that sages repeatedly emphasised as a way of life that should never be forsaken. To understand the true essence of generosity, one only need to look at the life of the generous Amma. 'Give! Give! Keep on giving!' - that is the motto of Amma, who has made selflessness her life's vow. This generosity is one of the fundamental principles of success.

3. Vamśābhimānī

It means, 'one who takes pride in one's heritage and lineage'. As Indians, we all have a magnificent heritage in our claim. The very meaning of the name 'Bharat' is 'one that revels in light', 'to find happiness in the light of knowledge.' We are destined to walk in the light of the most sacred knowledge.

This is the land once ruled by the Rajarshis. The Rishis of Bharat are ones who bore witness to that which forms the foundation of this whole world. We should be proud to be the descendants of these great Rishis, and the selfless rulers, and of the people who were ruled by them. We are the descendants of King Shibi, who donated parts of his own body to save a dove. The great Sage Dadhichi is our ancestor, who sacrificed his bones to defeat the asuras.

न कामयेऽहं गतिमीश्वरात् पराम् अष्टर्द्धियुक्तामपुनर्भवं वा ।
आर्तिं प्रपद्येऽखिलदेहभाजाम् अन्तःस्थितो येन भवन्त्यदुःखाः ॥

na kāmaye'haṃ gatimīśvarāt parā-
maṣṭarddhiyuktāmapunarbhavaṃ vā
ārtiṃ prapadye'khiladehabhājā-
manta:sthito yena bhavantyadu:khā:

I do not desire the supreme position, endowed with the eight perfections, nor liberation from rebirth. I seek only to alleviate the sufferings of all living beings who have taken on physical bodies, by residing within them.

Srimad Bhagavatam 9.12.21

We follow in the footsteps of King Rantideva, who prayed, "I do not desire the eight perfections or even liberation from rebirth from the Lord. I only wish to reside within all living beings, taking on their suffering, and freeing them from misery." If we embrace even a fraction of such noble ideals, we too can make our lives truly successful. For this, we must take pride in being the descendants of these illustrious figures who embody these ideals.

4. Śubhavāgvilāsah

It means, 'a person who uses auspicious words'. The influence of words in the world is well known. There is a popular subhashita,

लक्ष्मीर्वसति जिह्वाग्रे जिह्वाग्रे मित्रबान्धवाः।
जिह्वाग्रे बन्धनं प्राप्तं जिह्वाग्रे मरणं ध्रुवम्।।

lakṣmīrvasati jihvāgre jihvāgre mitrabāndhavāḥ
jihvāgre bandhanaṃ prāptaṃ jihvāgre maraṇaṃ dhruvam

On the tip of the tongue resides Lakshmi. On the tip of the tongue relatives and friends are sustained. On the tip of the tongue is bondage. Death too is on the tip of the tongue.

Subhashitaratnabhandagara 155.87

There goes a saying, "Good words are essential for all achievements". As Amma says, "Appropriate words are like a golden key that can open any heart. The same words, if used wrongly, can lock any heart. By paying enough attention to the words we use, we can bring spring not only to our own lives but also to the lives of others."

The power of words to lift us out of difficult situations is indescribable. Recall Bhagavad Gita, and how the words of Sri Krishna uplifted Arjuna from his despondency. Remember Ramayana, where Jambavan's words imparted great strength to Hanuman to accomplish a monumental task. Think of Hanuman's graceful speech that brought Sita Devi from the depths of despair to the golden shores of hope while she was imprisoned by Ravana. Speaking auspicious words is an unwritten rule we must invariably follow to make our lives blessed.

5. Anītibhītih

It means, 'a person who fears wrongdoing'. This is a popular sloka written with Sri Rama and Ravana in mind,

यान्ति न्यायप्रवृत्तस्य तिर्यञ्चोऽपि सहायताम् ।
अपन्थानं तु गच्छन्तं सोदरोऽपि विमुञ्चति ।।

yānti nyāyapravṛttasya tiryañco'pi sahāyatām
apanthānaṃ tu gacchantaṃ sodaro'pi vimuñcati

Even animals assist those who act according to justice.
But when one strays from the righteous path,
even their own brother will abandon them.

Anargharaghava, Act 1, Verse 5.

"Those who strive for their goals through righteous means are even supported by birds and animals. However, even a brother will abandon someone who strays from the path of righteousness". This reminds us about Sri Rama and Ravana. Sri Rama had to make great efforts to rescue Sita. Monkeys, bears, and even squirrels were ready to support Rama, who was dedicated to righteousness. Conversely, what about the story of Ravana? Ravana, who followed the path of injustice, was abandoned even by his own brother, Vibhishana. Only the path of justice brings lasting achievements. Those who gain power, wealth, and knowledge through unjust means will eventually lose everything.

Duryodhana ruled the kingdom for thirteen years after deceitfully winning it through a rigged game of dice. Ultimately, he was left with only the destruction of his dynasty and a legacy of infamy. Karna deceitfully obtained his martial skills by deceiving his teacher, but it did not serve him well in the end. This principle illustrated in the Itihasas and Puranas can also be observed in modern history.

Even today, we see these scenarios playing out around us. Only those who fear following the path of injustice can achieve true success. The path of righteousness is the royal road that leads to the pinnacle of victory.

6. Gurusādhunamrah

This means, 'a person who is humble before the Guru and virtuous people'. Humility is the quality that makes one deserving of wealth, power, and knowledge -

विनयात् याति पात्रताम्

Vinayād yāti pātratām

Through humility, one becomes deserving.

Hitopadesha 6

Only when one becomes deserving, only when one earns merit, can one's desires be fulfilled. A person who lacks respect for teachers and virtuous people is considered arrogant.

Nature never tolerates such individuals. Amma emphasises. "A violent storm can uproot trees, but it can't do anything to grass." According to divine law, all achievements flow towards those who are humble. Remember the proverb, "Water always flows to low land; it is only there God gives support." This is why it is said, "Pride comes before a fall, but humility comes before honour."

Humility and devotion towards the Guru are essential to reach and maintain great heights. There are countless stories of those who, due to a lack of reverence for the Guru (Gurutvam), have failed to achieve success or lost the successes they had gained. Humility towards the Guru and the virtuous is indispensable for our success.

Remember Poonthanam's words in Jnanappana, "When you see virtuous people, bow down without any shame."[3] To attain the grace essential for ultimate success, humble devotion to teachers and virtuous individuals paves the way.

Conclusion

When combined with effort, these six foundational elements of success ensure that our efforts bear fruit. They bring us the

[3] സജ്ജനങ്ങളെക്കാണുന്ന നേരത്തു ലജ്ജ കൂടാതെ വീണു നമിക്കണം.
sajjanaṅṅaḷĕkkāṇunna nerattu lajja kūṭātĕ vīṇu namikkaṇaṃ.

Goddess of Victory, the Vijaya Samrajya Lakshmi. They instil in us self-confidence and guide us forward on the path to success.

We often measure success in terms of effort and hard work alone, but true, lasting, and well-rounded success requires more. To support the roof of success, there are six essential pillars, which correspond to the features of a personality (as given in the sloka):

1. Prasannamūrttih - One of Cheerful Disposition
2. Samudāracetāh - One with Generous and Noble Mind
3. Vamśābhimānī - One with Pride in his Heritage and Lineage
4. Śubhavāgvilāsah - A Person with Talent for Gracious and Auspicious Speech
5. Anītibhītih - One Who Fears Wrongdoing
6. Gurusādhunamrah - One Who is Humble before Teachers and Virtuous People.

These qualities attract grace and good fortune, while shielding us from downfalls. They make us worthy to receive the blessings of success. They offer a guiding framework to ensure our successes have genuine substance and are worthy of being called "victories".

Let us strive to inculcate these ennobling qualities alongside our diligent efforts. By doing so, we open the doors to realising our highest potential and supreme accomplishment.

Chapter 9

Making Sense of Dharma

"Dharma is a universal principle that governs the world, working all around us, and within each and everyone of us. It is not a human construct, but rather a discovery of an eternal law that exists, much like gravity. Gravity has always been present, regardless of our awareness about it, and the terminology we assigned it. Similarly, Dharma has always been there. Dharma is not a principle exclusive to any religion. Dharma is the name given for that which tunes humanity, nature and God in perfect harmony", says Amma, Sri Mata Amritanandamayi Devi.

Who are the pioneers who discovered Dharma? We can ascribe this pioneering to our Rishis of antiquity, whose legacy continues unbroken till date.

Why do we emphasise the discovery of Dharma? Is it a big deal?

> **Activity 1:** Explore other cultures and civilisations, and see if they subscribe to principles congruent with Dharma. How many civilisations come close to this concept? Compare your findings with our concept of Dharma.

We will find that not many civilisations have recognised a principle similar to Dharma. It is as Yudhishthira says in Mahabharata, "The concept of Dharma is subtle and escapes our intelligence."[1]

Why Dharma?

In a previous chapter you were introduced to this principle called Dharma, through the framework of the Purusharthas. You saw how the purpose of any human being can be modelled into four verticals - Dharma, Artha, Kama, and Moksha.

You may have pondered, "Why is Dharma my Purushartha? Or, "Why is Dharma my purpose?" "Over and above ethical and harmonious living, is there something about Dharma that benefits me personally?"

Imagine this simple scenario. One fine day, you had a big craving for ice cream, and you went and bought yourself a scoop. Just as you were about to take a lick, moments before your tongue could savour it, you took notice of a poor child watching you and you stopped short. You couldn't just take that ice cream anymore, and you gave it to the child instead.

At this moment you can imagine further, the more profound and deeper happiness that you have obtained out of giving. This happiness would last much longer in your heart, than the happiness you get from enjoying the ice cream itself. To which Purushartha can we assign this happiness? You spent your hard earned money (Artha) to buy the ice cream, so Artha has been lost, not gained. The enjoyment of ice cream was the Kama here, but you gave that up. So no Kama has been enjoyed. You did not get liberated in this process, so no Moksha as well.

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[1] tarko'pratiṣṭhaḥ śrutayo vibhinnā naiko ṛṣiryasya mataṃ pramāṇam |
dharmasya tattvaṃ nihitaṃ guhāyāṃ mahājano yena gataḥ sa panthāḥ ||
Mahabharata, Gita Press, Vana Parva, 117

Can we hence conclude that the happiness enjoyed here came from Dharma?

Sometimes Dharma becomes a source of deep joy, and benefits us personally. And this immediate joy is only the visible fruit of dharmic actions, the 'drishta phalam'. Amma says that for every action (karma) there is a 'drishta phalam', and there is also an 'adrishta phalam'. It is a consequence of our actions that are not immediately apparent, and comes back to us later. When our actions are Dharmic, this 'adrishta phalam' is 'punya'. Through Dharma we gain Punya. Punya comes back to us as good fortune and grace (kripa). For those who seek Punya, Dharma is the way. And hence, Dharma is an objective of ours, and benefits us personally.

There is one more manner in which Dharma is personally relevant to us. We gather this too from the framework of Purusharthas. We saw that Artha gives us access to Kama. That is, without Artha, we cannot afford Kama.

What about Dharma? Does it play a role in providing access to other Purusharthas? Can we say that Artha and Kama gathered by adharmic means runs a high risk of being unsustainable, in comparison to the same gathered by means of Dharma? We can safely conclude that without Dharma our access to Artha and Kama may be short lived. What about Moksha? Can we expect to achieve Moksha when we lead an adharmic life? Not at all. In that sense, without Dharma in our actions, we surely lose access to Moksha.

This implies that without Dharma in our actions, we create a probability of losing access to Artha and Kama[2], and we definitely lose access to Moksha. Hence a person who ignores Dharma,

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[2] sukhasya mūlaṃ dharma:
Cāṇakya Nīti 1

may end up losing out on all Purusharthas, and hence life itself could become meaningless. Hence Dharma is personally essential, as it ensures our access to the other Purusharthas.

At the end of the Itihasa Mahabharata, we find Maharshi Vyasa lamenting for the world. He was sad that people are not taking up Dharma. He said that Artha and Kama come from Dharma! Then why not take up Dharma?[3]

Popular Definitions of Dharma

How do you understand Dharma? You see many instances where Dharma is translated to duty, righteousness, law, order, etc. Even if we ascribe all these words together to the meaning of the term Dharma, it will still not catch it in essence.

First and foremost, we can understand that Dharma represents a concept or a framework (and is hence a technical term), revealed to the pioneering subject matter experts of Sanatana Dharma. We saw earlier that these pioneers are our Rishis.

Understanding Dharma as a technical term is very important. It is not just another word in the dictionary. For example, take the word organic. There is a literal sense to this word that is in use by the layman or a common crowd. But when you go to Science, to Chemistry, then it means something else. You don't call it a word anymore, it is a technical term. You cannot look for its meaning in the English dictionary. Another example could be words like stress or strain. Will a dictionary definition of these terms suffice, to study stress and strain in material science?

Just like that, Dharma is a technical term. Furthermore, it is

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[3] ūrdhvabāhurviraumyeṣa na ca kaścicchṛṇoti me | dharmādarthaśca kāmaśca sa kimarthaṃ na sevyate || Mahabharata 18.5.49

always a technical term. There is no separate layman sense to it. Only depth of meaning may vary. We have such examples in Science too. Can you use words like micro or mega, without intending its technical sense. Or what about terms like rotation or average? The layman sense of the word is a partial of its technical contextual definition. Dharma is a term that cannot be too far away from its technical definition.

Before we discuss this technical definition of Dharma, let us take a look at some popular definitions and see if it makes sense.

Dharma as Duty

One popular definition is that, 'Dharma is Duty'. The problem with this definition is that it fails to communicate the true sense of Dharma that makes it duty. A more accurate statement than, 'Dharma is duty' is that 'understanding Dharma our duty becomes clear'. Hence a knowledge of Dharma leads to clarity in duty, or Dharma leads to duty.

For example, it is the duty of a police officer to protect, to inspire a feeling of safety, to enforce the law when needed, to handle cases where law is broken, to deal with emergency safety situations, etc. If we replace the word duty here with Dharma, the sentence is still correct, but the sense of it has gone much deeper. It's like saying, "Keeping people safe and following the law are deeply ingrained in what it means to be a police officer."

To understand this deeper sense, try thinking about the following sentences.

1. Heat and light is the Dharma of fire.
2. It is the Dharma of water to be wet.
3. It is the Dharma of sugar to be sweet.
4. It is the Dharma of the river to flow.

Similarly, when a woman becomes a mother, she embraces the Dharma of a mother, and hence follows the duties of a mother. A police officer is a man who became one at some point of time in his life. He then embraced the Dharma of a police officer, which was followed by the list of duties and accountabilities.

So now, what is more sensible to say? "Dharma is duty", or "Duty emanates from Dharma"?

Dharma as Righteousness

Another definition is, Dharma is righteousness. A similar exercise will bring clarity here as well. Is Dharma righteousness, or does it have something to do with righteousness? Take the case of a police officer again. Understanding the Dharma of a police officer leads him / her to also understand what is adharma there. This clarity leads to what is right and what is wrong. Hence what is righteous and what is not can be determined only if you have clarity of what is Dharma.

On the other side, think about Adharma. The tendency is to view adharma as something immoral, in that there is a judgement of ethics and morality that defines the term. Take an example. It is Adharma for a student to gossip, and spread harmful rumours about a classmate. Why is it so? Is it only because a student got hurt? If that is the case then we should say that fire is inherently Adharmic, as it will always hurt and destroy anyone who embraces it. We don't say that, right? We say that heat is the Dharma of fire. So why in the case of a student, gossipping about a classmate is Adharma?

To get a sense, take another example. It is the Dharma of a train to run on its tracks, and Adharma to run outside. When we say it's Adharma to run outside the tracks, there is no scope for moral judgement that can be placed on the train (as the train is not a living being with any intentions). Then how do you

understand adharma there?

Adharma is simply the act of derailing from Dharma. Hence when a student spreads harmful gossip about a classmate, over and above the fact that the classmate got hurt, the student is deviating or derailing from his / her Dharma. What Dharmas did he / she derail from?

1. The Dharma of a friend, in being trustworthy, and well wishing.
2. The Dharma of a fellow student, to not cause emotional distress that disrupts learning and growing.
3. The Dharma of a social human being, to not lie for ill purposes, or to not speak a truth that is hurtful.

Hence knowledge of Dharma gives clarity regarding righteousness. Or righteousness is understanding Dharma and sticking to it.

Dharma as Law & Order

Another definition ascribed to Dharma is that it is law and order. Here, it is knowledge of Dharma that allows us to define a law. It is knowledge of Dharma that allows us to recognise order from disorder. Understanding Dharma helps us make laws and keep things in order. Hence, law and order becomes a direct consequence of Dharma. The deeper the knowledge of Dharma of a lawmaker, the more profound the quality of law.

Discussing law and order brings us to human community living, and how people define laws naturally as they come together. Laws ensure that two or more people live together harmoniously. If there were only one person, there would be no need for any law at all. Hence two or more. If we take the case of two people, only rules that are acceptable to both become established. Else the law will fail.

As an example, take the case of watching television at home.

If there is only one person in the house, there is no restriction on his / her usage of it. But let's say there is one more person. Immediately the complication starts. TV time would need to be divided among both, based on individual requirements (favourite programs, free time etc.). Let's say there is a third person in the house. Then we have even more complications. And maybe, they start watching TV together, aligning their interests, and letting go of one thing or the other for each other's sake.

> **Activity:** Divide the class into groups of 5 or 6. Let each group imagine that they are siblings in a family, living in one house. Discuss how they would divide TV time? Bring to discussion what programs each member would love to watch? Simulate real life conflicts that can arise, and reach a resolution.

A Right Place for Equality

"There are over eight billion people in the world. Can all of them own a car one day? Can there be eight billion cars?" The heart of this question is that while there are unlimited needs in the world, the resources are limited. How then can we think of equal distribution of resources? More importantly do we need to, all the time? Is there a better way to think about a fair and just living, a better way to apply equality?

Funnily enough, we see the solution in our home everyday. Whatever ideology you subscribe to, you see this at your own home. When we sit with our family, at the dining table, all the food is kept at the center. Each family member takes what she / he wants, or is capable of eating, and finds satisfaction.

Was this satisfaction achieved by equal distribution of food? Or was it by embracing the diverse capacities of each member and taking as needed. In terms of choice of food too, we can see the same. Will everyone in a family want the same dish, or

be happy with the same dish. This may be managed by cooking different dishes day to day, or multiple dishes in a meal, so that there is something for everyone in a day, or there is something for everyone in a week. Here too we cannot apply some kind of equality, force everyone to eat the same food always, and be happy with it.

Food was distributed based on the need and capacity of each person.

As another example, take again the case of watching television at home. We cannot say that the TV time is divided equally among all members of the household. This depends on the people there. The children in the house may not get as much TV time as parents. Or sometimes, the regular adjustments may be changed when there are special telecasts happening, maybe a world cup live or a television premier of a much awaited movie. Here too we find uneven distribution necessary to maintain happiness, or collective harmony.

Even in simple examples like eating food or watching tv, as more and more people are involved, the Dharma of it becomes more and more complicated. Imagine again what must be the complexities and subtleties of Dharma when entire communities or societies are involved. Further, can we ignore diversity, blindly apply some sort of equality and leave it at that? Imagine once more, the hurt that such an act will cost, and the inadequacy that will be veiled beneath it.

Inequality is inherent in the material world. Resources are limited. Hence it becomes inevitable that they be fairly distributed to those in need, according to the needs only. This automatically leads us to Dharma.

Amma has often advised, at least for the past 15 years, that her children take up carpooling while going to the office, and

wherever possible. "Try to take at least two other people in your vehicle when you travel to work. But please make sure that they are not strangers; you should make sure that you are safe. You can also do the same kind of carpooling when you travel to a temple or when coming here to the Ashram." Amma pointed out that carpooling like this saves money, fuel, reduces environmental pollution, and gradually reduces traffic and even road accidents. Many children of Amma in America and Europe have taken this up, and have started a carpooling system.

Is it really better to live in a world where everyone mindlessly attempts to own a piece of everything for themselves? Dharma can draw that subtle line that maintains a harmonious balance between individual needs and collective harmony.

Defining Dharma

How do we understand Dharma now? So far we got the hint that Dharma has something to do with individual happiness and collective harmony. When it comes to law and order, Dharma is more about the collective. And, when it comes to righteousness and duty, it is more about the individual.

Formally in Indian Knowledge Systems, Dharma is 'that which upholds' or 'that which sustains'. Sri Adishankaracharya defines, "That which is the reason for the sustenance of the world, that which ensures the progress of all living beings and is the one and only reason for their welfare and prosperity, that is termed as Dharma."[4] This same definition is also revealed to us by Maharshi Vyasa in Mahabharata, 'dhāraṇāt dharmam iti āhu:'[5] (Dharma is that which sustains or upholds).

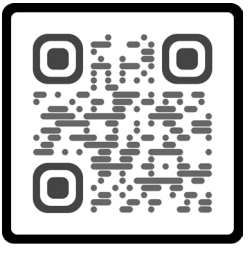
These formal definitions may feel too abstract, and difficult to grasp. But let's look at some examples.

[4] yaḥ jagataḥ sthitikāraṇaṃ prāṇināṃ sākṣāt abhyudayaniḥśreyasahetuḥ saḥ dharmaḥ
Bhagavad Gita Bhashya, Adi Shankaracharya

[5] Mahabharata, Critical Edition, 8.01.50

Yellowstone National Park

There is a place called Yellowstone in the United States. It is a national park, a protected habitat today. Yellowstone had lots of grey wolves, elks, grizzly bears, rabbits, beavers, flowers and trees, birds and bees, etc. and a river that flowed amidst it. The ecosystem was thriving. But the people who lived nearby were constantly attacked by the grey wolves there. They frequently lost their cattle, and they were scared. The wolf was becoming a problem, and they solved it by enabling people to come and hunt down wolves as game. So people started hunting. In 20-30 years, the wolf population was almost gone, with lone wolves here and there.



Scan to watch a documentary on the
'Wolves of Yellowstone' by National Geographic

The repercussions of this was unimaginable. The population of elks started increasing. With no wolf to control them, they started grazing freely in the forest and by the river. The river banks lost the grass and the shrubbery, and soil erosion started. The water became muddy and murky. The fish suffered because of that. With the shrubs and the small plants gone, the beavers were not able to make dams. The beaver dams were also suitable habitat for fish, and with fish thriving, otters were also thriving. But all these were affected. The elks ate the berries, and the berry plants, and this affected the grizzly bears. No fish or berries.

There were fewer flowering plants, and pollination stopped. Birds and bees were reduced. The rabbits were not able to hide in the shrubbery anymore and were more exposed to their prey.

All this, because the wolf was taken out of the ecosystem. People thought that the solution to their problem was simple. They acted on what they saw in front of them, without thinking deeply, considering the probable or potential effects. Later they did this, reactively (if not proactively) and discovered all these things. Realising the deeper problems, they reintroduced the grey wolves in 1995. At the time the population of the elks was 17000. When the wolves came back, things started becoming normal. Scared of the wolves, the elks refrained from spending too much time on the river banks. The greenery on the banks were back, erosion reduced, water became clear, fish thrived. The beaver dams came back. The otters and fish came back. The grizzly bear got its fish and berries. The flowers came back, and so did the bees and the birds[6].

When the wolf was reintroduced, amazingly, the entire ecosystem returned to its full health.

Here you can see, the ecosystem was naturally thriving. Everyone and everything there had a role, a Dharma, and they also kept a check on everyone else in the system. But, the whole system was disrupted by people, when they intervened without understanding the Dharma at play. And the whole ecosystem broke down.

Being Part of a Team

Let's say that we are part of a sports team, say cricket. We are therefore working to take our team to greater heights. Each team member has a role - bowling, batting, wicket keeping, etc.

[6] Smith, Douglas W., and Edward E. Bangs. "Reintroduction of wolves to Yellowstone National Park: history, values and ecosystem restoration." Reintroduction of top-order predators (2009): 92-125.

A bowler is not expected to excel in batting, and vice versa. Not all players are expected to be good wicket keepers. Whereas all players are expected to be good in fielding. In addition to this, roles like Captain and Vice Captain are given to some players. The coach has a visionary role, and every player is expected to submit to his vision. Now, how do we define Dharma in this context?

One layer of Dharma is the element of fairplay during the game, overseen by the umpire. A more important layer is of the Dharma that sustains the team, in its purpose, vision and continuous progress (Adharma hence is that which disrupts it). Whatever that helps uphold / sustain / maintain the team, and ensures its progress, is Dharma.

1. When each player caters to his Dharma (as in duty) well - batting, bowling, wicket keeping, fielding etc., it contributes to overall Dharma (healthy sustenance of the team) as well. When any player slacks off, it becomes Adharma as it brings down the team.
2. Healthy competition with team members will improve the team and is Dharma, whereas unhealthy competition guided by ego or jealousy will disrupt the rapport and synergy of the team, and is Adharma. Here is where inner strength leads us away from Adharma, as we will be strong enough to win over ego.
3. When a player accepts bribes and manipulates the game, it is Adharma on both layers - in the game and for the general progress of the team.
4. Disobeying the captain, or the coach, questioning their decisions, comparing with other players, etc. in light of some notion of right and wrong will seem Dharmic from an individual point of view, but is Adharma most of the time as it creates disharmony within the team.

5. Can you list more such instances of Dharma and Adharma here?

In this manner, we find that, as long as individual players stick to Dharma, the team will surely experience progress and stability. So what is Dharma here in the context of this cricket team? Whatever it is that sustains the team (dharanam) is Dharma. Anything that hurts the team is Adharma.

We can extend this understanding to all contexts we are in. Why don't you investigate the following.

1. What is Dharma in the context of our family?
2. What is Dharma at the workplace?
3. What is Dharma in our class at the university?
4. What is Dharma in the context of our nation?
5. What is Dharma in the context of the whole world?

The Pleasurable and the Beneficial

What do you choose most of the time? A delicious but unhealthy dessert or a healthy nutritious meal. Will you spend your entire leisure time playing video games, or will you dedicate at least some time to study? If you manage to save some money, will you spend it all on an expensive vacation, or will you save at least part of it for your long term financial goals. What sounds better? Binge watching a TV series or dedicating some time on a personal project or volunteering activity?

In life we often find ourselves choosing between,

1. That which is pleasurable and gives us immediate joy.
2. That which is beneficial for us, and paves way for our improvement.

Once, Yama, the Lord of Death, advised a young Nachiketas, "The good is one thing and the pleasant, another. These two, having

different ends, bind a man. It is well with him who chooses the good. He who chooses the pleasant misses the true end. The good and the pleasant approach man; the wise examines both and discriminates between them; the wise prefers the good to the pleasant, but the foolish man chooses the pleasant through love of bodily pleasure[7]."

Here Yama draws a contrast between what is "good" or "noble" and what is "pleasant" or "gratifying". We often encounter both goodness and pleasure. Those of us who lack wisdom may succumb to the allure of pleasure, favouring immediate gratification over the pursuit of a meaningful existence.

Though this conversation between Yama and Nachiketas is not a conversation on Dharma, we can get yet another sense of Dharma here. It brings to our attention that such decision making is always happening within us. And abiding by Dharma often means to take up what is beneficial over what is pleasurable. Be it personal, or when we are part of a team. We may not always be strong enough to evade pleasure, and choose what is good. But we can keep trying[8], and improve ourselves.

Those who can regulate their tendencies to enjoy immediate pleasures, and choose whenever needed, what is good for them in the long term, find growth and success. They become an asset to whatever initiative or team they belong to. They tend to justify the roles they adorn in life, becoming useful and preferable to all those who depend on them or the roles they play. Becoming dependable and stable thus, they become the reason for sustainable progress, and bring prosperity and well

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[7] anyacchreyo'nyadutaiva preyasteubhenānāthe puruṣaṁtasanītaḥ |
tayoḥ śreya ādadānasya sādhu bhavatata hīyate'thāmadya u preyovṛṇīte ||
śreyaśca preyaśca manuṣyametaḥ tausamparītya tavatavanakti dhīraḥ |
śreyotaha dhīro'tabha preyasovṛṇīte preyomandoyogakṣemādvṛṇīte ||
Kathopanishad 1.2.1 and 1.2.2

[8] In the Bhagavad Gita, Sri Krishna tells Arjuna, 'svalpam apyasya dharmasya trāyate mahato bhayāt', meaning, 'Even a small effort towards Dharma can save us from grave dangers'.

being. Becoming part of that which sustains (dharanam), they become instruments of Dharma.

Conclusion

Amma says, "Dharma is something that gives maximum happiness to the maximum number of people for maximum time. Dharma witnesses all external differences, and considers each in its own place. In this vision, there is no place for hatred or vengeance. There is no despair or anger. It teaches us to imbibe the good in everyone and everything.

Typically, we encounter two viewpoints in the world. First, "I want to secure my rights." Second, "I must fulfil my Dharma—my duty." Among these, Sanātana Dharma gives importance to the second. The first is the way of conflict and competition. The second is the way of harmony, wellbeing, and peace. If each person thinks only of their own rights, then the result will be hostility and discord. However, if each person fulfils their Dharma, then everyone's rights will naturally be protected. Peace and prosperity will reign.

Violating the law of Dharma will have its repercussions. Just as gravitational force is a law of nature, Dharma is a law of the universe. A nation's constitutional law can be changed by governments, but the law of the universe, Dharma, cannot be changed or amended. When we do our part to protect Dharma, Dharma will protect us."

Explore

In discussions about right and wrong, we talk about ethics and morality. Where does Dharma come in here? What is the relationship between Dharma and Ethics & Morality?

Chapter 10

Ancestral Anchors: The Indian Family

The concept of family has always held a central place in Indian culture, rooted deeply in ancient literature and philosophical teachings. In the current context, a fast-paced world where consumerism and individualism are on the rise, it becomes crucial to revisit the age-old wisdom present in ancient Indian texts that underscores the significance of family in the development of youngsters. This article aims to delve into the teachings from ancient Indian literature, explore the role of family in shaping young minds, and the importance of marriage for a prosperous society.

To say that we are living in a very fast-paced and secluded society, surely won't be an exaggeration. The rate of growth in every sector of work has increased, which in turn demands people to handle more complex situations in their workplaces. In this new world order, where change is the only constant, uncertainty seems trivial. Today, everyone seems to be so immersed in their tiny universes, struggling to find a heartfelt connection with other individuals.

In the recent past, the human race has made highly commendable

accomplishments in material comforts and technology. However, for a substantial proportion of the population, the aspect of Quality Of Life (QOL) stands a distant dream. Mental health and lifestyle diseases that cripple humanity, especially young adults, are a cause for concern. Every year the cases of divorce, anxiety, depression, etc. are only rising[1].

One reason for this situation is that a weak family system makes individuals more vulnerable, increasing their chances of meeting with unhappy situations.

This is where we must take a look at the way of life prevalent in our country. After observing the life cycle of a human being, based on the primary responsibility of an individual at different junctures of life, our ancestors divided human life into four stages. They called these four stages as Ashramas. The Brahmacharya (Student Life), Garhastya (Married Life), Vanaprastha (Retirement Life) and Sannyasa (Renunciation). The Four-Ashram System in India is, in that way, a very thoughtful system that ensures a purposeful living at every stage. It provides clear short-term goals for success in life.



The Four Ashrams

[1] https://ijip.in/wp-content/uploads/2023/05/18.01.165.20231102.pdf

Out of these four Ashramas, the Garhastya plays a pivotal role in shaping not only an individual, but rather generations. It is through married life; a person enters into a more responsible role of creating and sustaining a family. That is why marriage is considered sacred and celebrated more than any life event. Rigveda blesses the newly married couple thus, "Abide here together; may you never be separated; live together all your lives, sporting with sons and grandsons, happy in your own home."[2]

The family has been considered as the basic unit of a community in the Indian peninsula for ages. Its roots can be traced back to our ancient literature and philosophical teachings. It was clear for the wise-men of ancient India that, humans being a highly evolved social animal, collectiveness would play a crucial role in leading a purposeful life. They knew that the primary relationship that a person can naturally have is with their parents and siblings. Thus, the family institution was given utmost importance in one's life.

That is why unlike the USA or UK, the family system is an inseparable part of Indian society. When the western world with their short sightedness promoted and modelled their social system around an individual, our ancestors made family as the primary unit of a society. The western world started facing the issues of individualism only when they realised that the promised personal freedom and economic independence comes with a hefty price. They hence started promoting collectivism as an accepted social model. If you look at the current Indian diaspora, they are very particular on imparting their family values to the coming generations.

The Indian scenario is a little different at present. Globalisation and the pervasive nature of information technology, has drastically altered the aspirations of an average Indian youth. In their

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[2] ihaiva stam mā vi yauṣṭaṃ viśvam āyur vy aśnutam | krīḻantau putrair naptṛbhir modamānau sve gṛhe ||
Rigveda 10.85.42

pursuit of becoming a global citizen, we witness a generation who are primarily money oriented than wealth oriented. It could also be that they got fooled by colourful advertisements, and hence failed to realise that their character, health, personal connections, emotional bonding with family, etc. are the greatest wealth which money can never buy. The Purusharthas in Indian tradition, advises us to make as much money as we can, by following a more holistic approach.

The veterans, after sailing through the ocean of life, underscore that a life cannot be successful just by acquiring materialistic wealth. Rather, finding a sense of fulfilment and contentment from within makes one's life successful.

> The Indic name for 'family' is 'Kutumbam'. Do you know what that means? In Sanskrit, the word 'Kutumbam' means, 'that which supports and nourishes'.

A well known decade-long Harvard research on human happiness reaffirms that, "close relationships, more than money or fame, are what keep people happy throughout their lives…"[3] That is why we all need a family.

Just look around, at the families of your friends and classmates. The atmosphere in every family would not be the same. But irrespective of that, every family strives to provide the best to their succeeding generations.

Some very common roles that a family plays in shaping an individual are:

1. Moral and Ethical Foundation

Even though the authority pattern and division of labour within the

[3] ihttps://news.harvard.edu/gazette/story/2017/04/over-nearly-80-years-harvard-study-has-been-showing-how-to-live-a-healthy-and-happy-life/

Indian family system is changing, there must be some foundational principles that remain intact. They are value systems and ethics. Most of us have learnt the basics of human values, ethics and morality from our family outset. This is possible because you have members from different age groups who accept you as one of them, and provide a comfortable atmosphere for interaction. Respecting elders, helping others, etc. are some of the early lessons that every individual receives from a family. These values serve as a compass guiding them through life's challenges.

2. Cultural Transmission

Families play a crucial role in transmitting culture and heritage. Through rituals, traditions, and storytelling, youngsters are introduced to the rich tapestry of their cultural fabric. This connection with one's roots fosters a sense of identity and belonging. We must remember that, 'Unity in Diversity' in our country is not accidental, but the result of an unbroken chain of cultural transmission, through the families of Bharat.

3. Emotional Support and Well-being

The family acts as a support system during both joyous and challenging times. Youngsters, when nurtured in a loving family environment, develop emotional resilience and a sense of security, essential for their overall well-being. This is very crucial during the early stages of child development. No wonder why Indian tradition reveres parents as God in human form (Mata-Pita-Guru-Daivam). They have done the most sacrifice and provided the care and support for the well-being of a child.

4. Inculcating Social Responsibility

Families serve as the first school where youngsters learn about their social responsibilities. Our ancient texts highlight the interconnectedness of individuals within a community and

stress the importance of contributing positively to society, starting with one's own family. That is why even in the business world, the term 'family' has got a deeper meaning. If you look at the employees of Tata for example, they are proud to say they belong to the Tata Family. This was not the case when the industrial era took birth. They had only a master-servant relationship. Only when Indian thoughts came into business management a better human approach in the industrial world came into existence. The highest form of this concept is 'Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam', meaning, 'the world is one family'. This stands as the most practical form of socialism and humanism.

Take a moment to think about your childhood and list a few positive roles that your family played in your upbringing.

When we think about our families, there might be some shortcomings and issues. But no matter what, every individual is immensely influenced by their family. Just think about the comforts that you're having now. You owe your parents a lot for that. The strength that a family provides to a human being is invaluable. There is a deeper sense of belonging, openness, trust, and emotional support in a family ecosystem.

But what are your thoughts on raising a family of your own? Sounds cliche? According to U.S. Census Bureau statistics, more than 1 in 3 (34%) people have never been married in 2022. That's up from about 1 in 4 (23%) in 1950. In a survey[4] more than half of the GenZ group said that they did not want to have a marriage or lead a family life. They prefer living-together, rather than a long-term legal commitment.

In this world of instant gratification, lust overpowering love can only be natural. Here, individuals primarily care about their

[4] https://thrivingcenterofpsych.com/blog/millennials-gen-z-marriage-expectations-statistics/

pleasure alone and are not ready to take up responsibility for their actions which creates a lot of troubles in modern families. Another cause could be the image that is portrayed in society about the institution of marriage. The lack of education in entering a married life makes the lives of many youngsters miserable but it is portrayed as the problem of the institution called marriage itself.

Another thing we must understand is the role consumerism plays in this scenario. The business world at large wants you to spend all your money and buy goods. But countries like India, where family systems and traditional values are solid, tend to follow a more savings-oriented culture due to their strong commitment to family. So the best option to promote consumerism would be disintegrating the family and promoting individualism. This idea is promoted through mass media and advertisements, and we are made to believe that family is a burden.

The younger generation has to understand the importance and role of a family in shaping their past, present, and future. They must also understand the role of family as a foundational unit of a society. Having a family and making it a happy place to live in, is a great exercise to a person's journey towards perfection. It is a playground where you get trained in caring and sharing, learning and mentoring, adjustability and adaptability, and a lot of memories to cherish for a lifetime.

> **Activity:** Create a family tree. Try to trace back as many generations as you can.

Conclusion

The Indian family concept is a very positive, individually empowering, sustainable model that acts as a basic unit of humanity and is capable of transforming social, economic, and personal conditions positively. There is no doubt that if assimilated and applied in its proper sense, this model will serve as a solution to most of the problems that mankind is facing today.

Chapter 11

Decoding the Idea of India

It is often said that Indian history is not very different from that of other parts of the world - the same power struggles, the same tales of warfare, treachery or conquest, the same social injustices and exploitation. The implication behind such statements is that shared historical experiences lead to common challenges and solutions, suggesting that modern European solutions are required for progress in all countries. The conclusion, explicitly stated or not, is that India's road to progress lies in the modern "idea" of a "secular" nation built on the democratic structures and principles that post-Enlightenment Europe created for itself. This perspective further posits that India's present identity as an independent nation is intricately linked to the legacy of over 300 years of European colonial rule.

Is the unity of this country a mere colonial creation, or did something identifiable as "India" exist earlier?

Till a few decades ago, the concept of India's cultural unity was so self-evident that only few scholars or statesmen would have thought of questioning it. Let us consider the following

observation -

> "The most essentially fundamental Indian unity rests upon the fact that the diverse peoples of India have developed a peculiar type of culture or civilization utterly different from any other type in the world. That civilization may be summed up by the term Hinduism."

This straightforward statement is found in the introduction to Vincent Smith's classic Oxford History of India [1].

Again, we are confronted with some fundamental questions. Was there or not in ancient India a sense of cultural unity throughout this geographical expanse? And was there a political unity—and if so, when, and to what extent?

Cultural Unity: A Sacred Geography

India's geographical unity, at least, is not questionable. The Vishnu Purana, a text at least 1,500 years old defines unambiguously -

उत्तरं यत्समुद्रस्य हिमाद्रेश्चैव दक्षिणम् ।
वर्षं तद् भारतं नाम भारती यत्र संततिः ।।

uttaraṃ yatsamudrasya himādreścaiva dakṣiṇam
varṣaṃ tad bhārataṃ nāma bhāratī yatra saṃtatiḥ

The country that lies north of the ocean, and south of the snowy mountains, is called Bharata.

Vishnu Purana 2.3.1

Indologists have long identified a few mechanisms that helped create the unity underlying the rightly celebrated, mind-boggling diversity that strikes any student of India. One of them is the institution of pilgrimage, a most effective way, along with trade, to get people to travel the length and breadth of the subcontinent. Bharata is not an abstract expanse; it is a

sacred geography[1] given shape to by dense networks of holy places, tirthas that skilfully crisscross the Indian landmass. Among the many lists of such pilgrimage sites, let us mention -

- Shakti Peethas, 51 (or 52) in number, covering the whole of India, with some of them in Nepal, Bangladesh, Pakistan and Sri Lanka. In this tradition, the very land becomes the body of the Mother Goddess.
- Twelve Jyotirlingas, from Gujarat and Maharashtra in the west to Kedarnath in the north, Vaidyanath (Deogarh) in the east, and Rameswaram in the south;
- Four Char Dham pilgrimage sites of the Himalayas (Yamunotri, Gangotri, Badrinath & Kedarnath);
- Four locations for the Kumbhamela (Allahabad, Haridwar, Ujjain and Nashik);
- Five sacred confluences (among many more): Vishnuprayag, Nandaprayag, Karnaprayag, Rudraprayag, Devprayag;
- 108 Divyadesams or Vaishnavite shrines, most of them in the South;
- Five important temples of Shiva in the South, each associated with one of the panchabhutas;
- Pilgrimage routes established by India's spiritual figures, from Shankaracharya to Swami Vivekananda, also tended to frame as much of the land as possible, "from Kashmir to Kanyakumari."

In the below provided picture of India, can you mark the location of twelve Jyotirlingas, four Char Dham sites, four locations of Kumbhamela and the five sacred confluences of rivers?

Is such an interconnected web possible if there was no culturally

[1] The phrase 'Sacred Geography' refers to places that hold a unique spiritual or divine significance. People visit such places to connect with what they hold as sacred or divine, to embrace their spiritual beliefs and cultural legacy.



unified land called India?

> "India has, for ages past, been a country of pilgrimages. All over the country, you find these ancient places, from Badrinath, Kedarnath and Amarnath, high up in the snowy Himalayas down to Kanyakumari in the south. For, from the very beginning of history, the people of India always thought of themselves as a people belonging to one great country. What has drawn out people from the north to the south, and from the south to the north in these great pilgrimages? What is the common thought that has made them travel from one region to the other? It is the feeling of one country and one culture, and this feeling has bound us together."

The author of these remarks is not some Hindu communalist but the very embodiment of Post-Independence secularism—Jawaharlal Nehru himself.

Second mechanism, closely related to the first, is the creation of a sacred geography in which mountains, rivers, trees and animals are imbued with divinity. Such a web created on the map the concept of punyabhumi - a sacred land present and living in everyone's mind. It was constantly recalled to one's memory through a variety of devices, for instance the many mantras and prayers listing India's sacred rivers in various orders (generally starting with Ganga). One example of such a mantra is,

गङ्गे॑ च यमुने चैव गोदावरि सरस्वति।
नर्मदे सिन्धु कावेरि जलेऽस्मिन् संनिधिं कुरु॥

gaṅge ca yamune caiva godāvari sarasvati
narmade sindhu kāveri jale'smin saṃnidhiṃ kuru

O Ganges, Yamuna, Godāvari, Sarasvatī,
Narmadā, Sindhu and Kāverī,
please make your presence felt in this water.

Third is the spread of the two Indian Itihasas, Mahabharata and Ramayana, across the subcontinent and far beyond. It is remarkable how these two grand tales, replete not only with heroism, but with human frailty and treachery, captured people's imagination. They not only mention most regions of India (Mahabharata especially), but were warmly adopted by every region, to such a point that it is hard to find a place in India through which the Pandavas or Sri Rama did not pass at some time or the other! The unparalleled cultural integration effected by these two Itihasas were so powerful that it extended to much of South East Asia. This is a fact readily acknowledged by nations such as Thailand, Malaysia, Indonesia, Cambodia and Vietnam.

Mahabharata lists 363 communities (janas) across the map, and many of them, including some that we today call "tribal", returned the compliment by taking pride in owning the Itihasa, translating, adapting or retelling it in endless variations. In Tamil Nadu alone, about a hundred versions have come down to us in folklore forms.

A fourth mechanism is the various testimonies of foreign travellers. Said-al-Andalusi, a Spanish historian and astronomer, for instance, wrote in 1068 CE-

> "The Indians, among all nations, through the centuries and since antiquity, were the source of wisdom, justice and moderation. They were a people endowed with virtues of self-control, creators of sublime thoughts, universal fables, rare inventions and remarkable conceptions."

Early Greek, Chinese and Arab travellers recognized it as such and referred to India as one country, not several. Islamic invaders too (or their chroniclers, such as Al Beruni) had no doubt in their mind that Al'hind (India) was one country, not many separate ones. When the ancient Greeks referred to this

country as "India", the Chinese as "Tianzhu" or the Arabs as "Al'Hind", they had in mind something more than a mere geographical expanse beyond the Hindu Kush or the Himalayas. What their testimonies express is an underlying cultural unity as an identifying factor for "India".

> "India has all along been trying experiments in evolving a social unity within which all the different peoples could be held together, while fully enjoying the freedom of maintaining their own differences… This has produced something like a United States of a Social Federation, whose common name is Hinduism." [2]

Again, is this the utterance of some jingoistic mind? Judge for yourself, since Rabindranath Tagore is its author.

The whole process (all the mechanisms) was not one ordered by some central religious or political power; it was organic, decentralized and self-regulated. And note the word "Hinduism", clearly not in the sense of a narrow set of dogmas imposed by a privileged coterie, but as a bewilderingly complex phenomenon of interaction between all layers of Indian society, in which deities, rituals, beliefs and even texts freely travelled back and forth.

In a seminal essay entitled, 'The History of Bharatavarsha', Tagore, again, gave a beautiful description of India's "talent" in the field -

> Providence has pulled in diverse people onto the lap of Bharatavarsha. Since antiquity Bharatavarsha has been provided with the opportunity to put into practice the special talent her people were endowed with. Bharatavarsha has forever been engaged in constructing with varied material the foundation of a unifying civilization. And a unified civilization is the

> highest goal of all human civilizations. She has not driven away anybody as alien, she has not expelled anybody as inferior, she has not scorned anything as odd. Bharatavarsha has adopted all, accepted everybody. And when so much is accepted, it becomes necessary to establish one's own code and fix regulation over the assorted collections. It is not possible to leave them unrestrained like animals fighting each other. They have to be appropriately distributed into separate autonomous divisions while keeping them bound on a fundamental principle of unity. The component might have come from outside but the arrangement and the fundamental idea behind it were Bharatavarsha's own. ... It needs talent to make outsiders one's own. The ability to enter others' beings and the magic power of making the stranger completely one's own, these are the qualities native to genius. That genius we find in Bharatavarsha.

Making the other "one's own"—provided he lends himself to the process—is not "composite culture," which, at best, would result in a formless hodgepodge. It is India's way, and one day it will have to be the world's way.

References

1. The Oxford History of India by Vincent A. Smith, edited by Percival Spear (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 4th ed., p. 7.
2. Rabindranath Tagore, "Nationalism in India" (republished New Delhi: Macmillan, 1999), p. 69.

Test Your Comprehension

If you have thoroughly assimilated the contents of this chapter, test your knowledge by attempting to answer the following set of questions.

1. Which Purana states that "The country that lies north of

the ocean, and south of the snowy mountains, is called Bharata."?

2. Who referred to India as "Tianzhu"?
3. Which ancient Itihasa mentions about 363 communities (janas) in it?
4. Who has written the "History of Bharatavarsha"?
5. Kumbhamela happens at which locations in India?

Opportunities for Research

If you aspire to pursue further research in this direction, feel free to engage with the following set of tasks.

1. The author presents a multitude of testimonies to substantiate the cultural coherence of India as a singular geographic entity. He quotes how the land was perceived by foreigners who frequented for several thousand years, the comprehensive view of the entire land from the Himalayas to Kanyakumari as depicted in Indian scriptures such as the Puranas, how the pilgrimage mechanisms devised by unknown visionaries connects various parts of the same land through the travel routes, how Ramayana and Mahabharata have influenced the entire landscape and what it mentions about the communities etc. Can you try and research and find additional evidence that further supports the cultural unity of this country.

2. The author employs diverse mechanisms to establish the cultural unity of this region. What about the political unity of India? Was India politically unified by the British Crown? Furthermore, what proportion of India's geographical area was under British control upon their departure in 1947? Prior to the arrival of the British or any other colonial powers, was there no political unification

in this land? Extensive research is encouraged to gain a comprehensive understanding of these matters.

Chapter 12

Nation Builders of Bharatavarsha

We are often told that India as a nation state was born only in 1947 after the British left India. Also, we are told that India in the pre-British period was divided into small warring kingdoms and that there was no concept of a nation. But when we examine the annals of Indian history, we find that our national consciousness was highly developed long before the colonial era.

The Vishnu Purana says:

उत्तरं यत्समुद्रस्य हिमाद्रेश्चैव दक्षिणम् ।
वर्षं तद् भारतं नाम भारती यत्र संततिः ।।

uttaraṃ yatsamudrasya himādreścaiva dakṣiṇam
varṣaṃ tad bhārataṃ nāma bhāratī yatra saṃtatiḥ

The country that lies north of the ocean, and south of the snowy mountains, is called Bharata.

Vishnu Purana 2.3.1

Whenever our civilization faced difficult challenges, we found that this national consciousness helped in the shaping of epoch-making leaders who worked for the betterment of their motherland and brought about extraordinary developments in our national life.

In this chapter, we will look at a few examples of such great historical and national characters who represent the essence of Indian Culture and Heritage.

The Story of King Bharata

The name of our motherland Bharata is derived from the name of the Chakravarti (Emperor) Bharata, who is a legendary king featured in our Itihasa Mahabharata. He is a member of the Chandravamsha (Lunar Dynasty) and is regarded to be the ancestor of the Pandavas, the Kauravas, Brihadratha, and Jarasandha. The story of King Bharata is featured in the Adi Parva of Mahabharata, where he is mentioned as the son of Dushyanta and Shakuntala and this episode was later immortalised in Kalidasa's famous play, Abhijñānashākuntalam.

Kalidasa depicts Bharata to be so brave that he was surrounded only by wild animals, he grew up to be a strong child and made a sport of opening the mouths of tigers and lions and counting their teeth. Hence, he was named Sarvadamana - the conqueror of all.

King Bharata is also known to have departed from the tradition of appointing the eldest son of the royal family as the successor to the throne. Bharata was unhappy with the incompetence of his biological sons and is said to have made his adopted son the king instead. Thus, he set an example that the King's commitment should always be to the welfare of his people and not merely to fulfil his self-interest.

Rama and the Ideal of Rama Rajya

We often find that modern writers equate or draw a false equivalence between western concept of nation state and monarchies with that of the unique idea of 'Rashtra' and traditions of Indian monarchy. It is important to note the differences too. In the Indian system of monarchy, the king's power was not absolute as it was the case in western history in many instances. The king's power was often checked or circumscribed by an efficient system of the council of ministers called the 'mantri parishad'. The king in Indian tradition was considered as an incarnation of Lord Vishnu because Vishnu represents the power of protecting the balance of Dharma. The king's first commitment was to Dharma and to the welfare of his people.

Of all the celebrated rulers in India, the most popular character who is firmly etched into the collective consciousness of our people is Sri Rama. Valmiki says that after the conquest of Lanka and Ravana's vanquishment, Rama ruled for a long period of time. This period of Rama's reign is portrayed as the Golden Age of good governance, peace and prosperity.

Gandhi wrote in 'Young India' in 1929 thus: "... the ancient ideal of the Ramayana is undoubtedly one of true democracy in which the meanest citizen could be sure of swift justice without an elaborate and costly procedure." Though Gandhiji may have coined the term in its modern avatar, the concept of 'Rama Rajya' has been a part of Indian thinking for centuries.

According to Gandhi, the ideal of Rama Rajya may be politically described as, "the land of dharma and a realm of peace, harmony and happiness for young and old, high and low, all creatures and the earth itself, in recognition of a shared universal consciousness."

King Janaka and the Ideal of Raja Rishi

King Janaka of Mithila is described as a perfect combination of the qualities of a king with the wisdom and maturity of a Rishi's mind or a Raja Rishi.

Sri Krishna says in the Bhagavad Gita:

कर्मणैव हि संसिद्धिमास्थिता जनकादयः ।
लोकसङ्ग्रहमेवापि सम्पश्यन्कर्तुमर्हसि ॥

karmaṇaiva hi saṃsiddhimāsthitā janakādayaḥ
lokasaṅgrahamevāpi sampaśyankartumarhasi

"Even kings like Janaka and others attained the perfectional stage by performance of prescribed duties. Therefore, just for the sake of educating the people in general, you should perform your work."

Bhagavad Gita 3.20

It is said that King Janaka would fulfil his royal duties and responsibilities during the day and would then spend the whole night studying the scriptures with his Guru Ashtavakra or meditating on the teachings. Janaka attained Self Knowledge while fulfilling the duties of a king and he is regarded as a 'Jivanmukta', a person who attained moksha while living, from the karmic bondage of future births and deaths.

Raja Dharma of Mahabharata

In the Shanti Parva of the Mahabharata, we find a detailed exposition of the character, values and duties of an ideal King through discourses on Raja Dharma. Bhishma gives advice to Yudhishthira on the duties and responsibilities of a king. A king is one who delights in the welfare of his people or whose mind is focussed on the good of his subjects. Sri Krishna supports Yudhishthira's aspiration to become the Chakravarti

Raja or Emperor of Bharatavarsha because of his unwavering commitment to Dharma.

Yudhishthira governed Indraprastha with absolute commitment to Dharma, with a strict adherence to duty, and with the welfare of the people as his focus. Hence, his kingdom grew prosperous, and people from other kingdoms too were attracted to it.

Throughout our epics, we find that such ideal examples of kings have been placed before us, who strived for the welfare of our nation and the people.

But these examples were not confined to Itihasas alone. Let us look at some examples from Indian history of such great Kings who practised these principles in fulfilling their duties and responsibilities as the rulers.

Chandragupta Maurya (321- 297 BCE)

The founder of the Maurya Empire, Chandragupta Maurya was guided by his Guru Chanakya and the principles of the Arthashastra in his policies and administration. After unifying a large portion of India and bringing it under the banner of the Maurya Empire, Chandragupta Maurya established an efficient centralised administration from his capital city of Pataliputra (now Patna). The Emperor was advised by a council of ministers called the 'Mantri Parishad' with Chanakya as the Chief Minister (Amatya). He also implemented a series of political and economic reforms, a reflection of which we find in the principles of the Arthashastra.

Harshavardhana (590 CE - 647 CE)

The Chinese traveller Hiuen Tsang (Xuanzang) narrates graphic details of the charity and welfare activities taken up by Emperor Harshavardhana (607-647 CE). Hiuen Tsang states that Harsha banned animal slaughter for food, erected several thousand

100-feet high stupas on the banks of the Ganges river, and built well-maintained hospices for travellers and poor people on highways across India. He organised an annual assembly of global scholars, and bestowed charitable alms on them. Every five years, he held a great assembly at Prayag. Hiuen Tsang was also summoned by King Harsha to the Kumbh Mela in Prayag, where he witnessed King Harsha's extravagant gift-giving to the poor.

"The story of Harsavardhana, the renowned seventh century Indian king, who used to empty his treasury every few years and share his riches with his people, is well known. And when Hiuen-Tsiang, the revered Chinese scholar who visited India during the reign of Harshavardhana, describes the festivals of sharing that Harsavardhana organised, it reads almost like the descriptions of grand giving and sharing that happened unceasingly during the great yajnas of Sri Rama and Yudhisthira and other celebrated kings of classical antiquity."[1]

Sri Krishnadevaraya (1471 - 1529 CE)

Sri Krishnadevaraya, the Emperor of Vijayanagara, is considered one of the greatest and most powerful rulers in Indian history. He presided over one of the largest empires in India after the fall of the Delhi Sultanate. He defeated the Sultans of Bijapur, Golconda, the Bahmani Sultanate and the Gajapatis of Odisha and established his supremacy.

Foreign travellers such as Domingo Paes, Fernao Nunez, Ibn Batuta, Nicolo de Conti, Abdur Razzaq and Duarte Barbosa who visited Vijayanagara spoke highly of the efficiency of his administration and the prosperity of the people during his reign.

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[1] Annam Bahu Kurvita, The Indian Tradition of Growing and Sharing Food by J. K. Bajaj and M. D. Srinivas

Writing about the prosperity of Vijayanagara, the Persian chronicler Abdur Razzaq writes:

> The bazaars are extremely broad and long. Flower sellers have tall platforms in front of the stalls, and on both sides, they sell flowers. There are aromatic flowers continually in bloom, and as necessary as they deem food to be, they cannot bear without flowers. The practitioners of every craft have stalls adjacent to one another. The jewellers sell pearls, diamonds, rubies and emeralds openly in the bazaar. All nobles and commoners of the region, even the craftsmen of the bazaar, wear pearls and jewels in their ears, around their necks and on their arms, wrists and fingers.[2]

Krishnadevaraya was himself a polyglot, fluent in Kannada, Telugu, Tamil, and Sanskrit, and composed an epic poem in Telugu called Amuktamalyada. He generously supported all traditions of Sanatana Dharma, and their places of worship. He gave generous land grants to the temples of Tirumala, Srisailam, Amaravati, Chidambaram, Ahobilam, and Tiruvannamalai. He made Tirumala Venkateswara his patron deity and visited the Balaji temple several times. A statue of Krishnadevaraya with two of his wives is an iconic attraction at the temple complex of Tirumala.

Sri Krishnadevaraya's reign is considered as a golden age of economic prosperity, literature, arts, religion, and culture which was a result of his benevolent and efficient administrative policies.

Chatrapati Shivaji Maharaj (1630 - 1680 CE)

When India was going through one of it's most turbulent moments in history under the tyrannical rule of Aurangzeb, Shivaji rose like a flame of resistance of the unbeatable spirit

[2] Description of Vijayanagara Empire as described by foreign travellers, Ms Jayalaxmi M and Dr. Kavita Charles Makhwan, JETIR January 2023, Volume 10, Issue 1

of Indian civilization which refused to give up its commitment to the eternal values and Dharma.

This is what Swami Vivekananda had to say about the life and times of Shivaji Maharaj when one of his disciples narrated some negative stereotypes about Shivaji that they were taught in the English schools:

> … the greatest king that India had produced within the last three hundred years; one who was the very incarnation of Shiva, about whom prophecies were given out long before he was born; and his advent was eagerly expected by all the great souls and saints of Maharashtra… and one who succeeded in the establishment of the Dharma which had been trampled under foot by the depredations of the devastating hordes of the Moghals…
>
> This is what comes of your reading Indian History written by foreigners who could have no sympathy with you, nor could they have any respect for your culture, traditions, manners and customs which they could not understand. Is there a greater hero, a greater saint, a greater bhakta and a greater king than Shivaji?

"Shivaji was the very embodiment of a born ruler of men as typified in your great Epics. He was the type of the real son of India representing the true consciousness of the nation. It was he who showed what the future of India is going to be sooner or later, a group of independent units under one umbrella as it were, i.e., under one supreme imperial suzerainty."[3]

Writing about the striking contrast between the character of Aurangzeb and Shivaji, Dennis Kincaid, the author of the classic biography, Shivaji, the Grand Rebel says:

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[3] by Dr. Mc Nanjunda Rao, From the Archives of The Vedanta Kesari, The Echoes of Teachings of Swami Vivekananda, IV(November 1914, p. 218-219)

"... it is remarkable how little religious animosity or intolerance Shivaji displayed. His kindness to Catholic priests is an agreeable contrast to the proscriptions of the Hindu priesthood in the (largely Marathi-speaking) Indian territories of the Portuguese. Even his enemies remarked on his extreme respect for Mussulman priests, for mosques and for the Koran. The Muslim historian Khafi Khan, who cannot mention Shivaji in his chronicle without adding epithets of vulgar abuse, nevertheless acknowledges that Shivaji never entered a conquered town without taking measures to safeguard the mosques from damage; whenever a Koran came into his possession he treated it with the same respect as if it had been one of the sacred works of his own faith; and that whenever his men captured Mussulman ladies they were brought to Shivaji, who looked after them as if they were his wards till he could return them to their relations. It is perhaps worth remembering that this century in Europe was noteworthy for the activities of Tilly in Germany and of Cromwell in Ireland." (p.95)

Conclusion

Thus, we see that from time immemorial, the cultural and spiritual consciousness of Bharatavarsha has been preserved and nurtured through the sacrifice and example of great Raja Rishis and heroes whose lives and actions are worthy of adoration and emulation. That India has been blessed with such illustrious nation builders in every period of its history is a testimony to the inherent strength and vitality of our ancient civilization. May the 21st century also witness the rise of an economically strong and spiritually awakened India that strives for lokahita.

Chapter 13

Civilisational Bridges: India and the World

Introduction

This is a letter from Bishop Severus Sebokht to the monk Basil of Cyprus, ca. 662 CE.

> "I wrote to you brother because of the fact that some of the Greeks you are with are saying that the Syrians know nothing about these things – and I am speaking of the calculation of the stars and the eclipses of the sun and the moon – while the Greeks think they alone have all knowledge, as if because they speak in Greek, they were first to know these things before the wise Babylonians. But concerning this knowledge, the Babylonians were first in finding it and not the Greeks – as all the Greeks' own writings testify; after the Babylonians, then the Egyptians, and then the Greeks. But the Babylonians – I mean the Syrians – know something about these things, as they [the Syrians] were the first discoverers and teachers of these many children…

> …But thus far I have kept silent from speaking about the knowledge of the Hindus – and these are not even Syrians! – and about their careful discoveries of this teaching of astronomy and the methods of speaking of their calculations – calculations which surpass description – but I speak of the nine characters. These are more skilled than the Greeks and the Babylonians! If some perceive of themselves that they alone have achieved the end of knowledge because they alone speak Greek, perhaps they may find – albeit slowly – that there are also others that know something; not Greeks alone, but also people from other nations with a different language."

This letter affirms India's pre-eminent status as a centre for knowledge development and emphasises the importance of cross-cultural exchanges for the dissemination of knowledge and progress of humanity.

As seen from the above letter, India (also referred to as Bharat) is not a stand-alone civilization; since the beginning of time, it has constantly engaged with other countries and communities. We shall talk about the nature of these exchanges and how they influenced 'humanity's collective civilizational growth' in this chapter. The channels of engagement were many. Initially, commerce channels were the primary means of engagement; later, colonisation, knowledge, and spiritual routes were added.

The following is a list of some of the most notable instances of these cross-cultural exchanges.

1. Trade Routes
2. Colonisation
3. Knowledge Seeking Routes
4. Spiritual Routes

Trade Routes

From the start of recorded history, India experienced a positive trade balance, which led to the country's accumulation of gold reserves.

In addition to Iran and Central Asia via the Afghan mountain ranges, the Sindu Saraswati societies were shipping timber, semi precious stone beads, shell bangles, ivory objects, pearls, etc. to Oman, Bahrain, and Mesopotamia, via the Persian Gulf. Consequently, numerous sites in those locations have yielded the discovery of Sindu Saraswati seals and other indications of trade. This period is around 2700 -1500 BCE [1].

Trade with the Phoenicians, who seem to have reached India's western shore, began from the start of the first millennium BCE. Aside from "exotic" creatures like monkeys and peacocks, spices, ivory, jewels, wood, silks, and other textiles made their way from the western coast of India to Egypt, Asia Minor (asian part of modern day turkey), the Near East (comprising the countries of the Arabian Peninsula, Cyprus, Egypt, Iraq, Iran, Israel, Jordan, Lebanon, Palestinian territories & Syria), and ultimately Greece and Rome.

Trade with the Roman Empire began gradually in the third century BCE, peaked in the first centuries BCE and CE, and then declined steadily. They returned home with wood, sandalwood, precious and semiprecious stones (like beryl or quartz), pearls, ivory, tortoise shells, spices (especially pepper, which they not only consumed but also used for mummification), textiles (especially muslin), perfumes, aromatic and medicinal plants, and peacocks. They brought glassware, wine, or olive oil in sealed amphoras (tall conical jars with a pair of handles), pigments, coral, and metals (sodium, lead, and tin)[1].

[1] Trade: A Survey, CBSE', Class 11 textbook - Knowledge, traditions and practices of India,

Additionally, Indian Wootz Steel was shipped to the Mediterranean region, where it was employed to manufacture lighter and more cutting-edge swords, among other weapons. In 77 CE, the Roman historian Pliny the Elder complained [2],

> By the lowest reckoning India, China and the Arab peninsula draw from our empire 100 million sesterces every year. … In no year does India absorb less than 50 million sesterces of our empire's wealth, sending back merchandise to be sold with us at a hundred times its prime cost.

The sesterce was a Roman currency, and some scholars have counted this massive drain on the treasury among the causes for the decline of the Roman Empire.

Chinese historical records date back to 2nd century BCE, when sea traders were bringing Indian goods to China. The discovery of glass beads and bangles in Borneo, Java, and the Malay Peninsula suggests that commercial contacts with Southern India date back to the 1st millennium BCE.

The following millennium saw Kalinga (present-day Odisha) and Bengal involved in a thriving trade with Burma, reaching as far as Java. Hiuen Tsang, a Chinese traveller from the 7th century CE, recorded that traders departed from Puri "for distant countries". The Cholas, Kings of South India, had developed a navy by 9th Century CE, that was strong enough to temporarily subjugate portions of Indonesia (the Śrīvijaya kingdom) and Malaysia (Perak). Indian traders frequently travelled to Southeast Asian nations and islands, where they sold luxury goods like silk and diamonds and brought back aromatic woods, camphor, and spices.

> **Activity 1:** What was the 1721 Calico Act? Compare it with current international trade practices.

Exchange of knowledge was aided by these trading channels as well. This is attested to by the fact that Indian mathematical ideas like zero and the decimal system were first brought to Arabia and then, throughout the Middle Ages, to Europe [3].

Knowledge Seeking Journeys

Beyond goods, another motivation for cross-cultural interactions is the pursuit of knowledge.

There is ample documentation on the history of the first international universities, such as Takshashila and Nalanda. We'll talk about how Panchatantra stories spread over the world as a result of the search for a plant that grants immortality [4].

Shah Nama[2] states that a Persian physician named Borzuy (550 CE) travelled to India in quest of a herb that might bring back the dead (he most likely heard about the Sanjivani herb). Clearly, he was unable to locate the herb. But then he saw a sage who gave him the herb's metaphorical meaning.

> The herb is the scientist; science is the mountain, everlastingly out of reach of the multitude. The corpse is a man without knowledge, for an uninstructed man is everywhere lifeless. Through knowledge man becomes revived.

The sage then introduced him to Panchatantra and the wisdom within. He then translated Panchatantra to Pahlavi language. This marked the beginning of Panchatantra's translations into other languages, which have since spread over the globe and been translated into over 50 languages. The Panchatantra stories have been a wellspring of knowledge for handling everyday situations for both children and adults.

[2] The Shahnameh, also spelled Shahnama, is a famous epic poem written by the Persian poet Ferdowsi between 977 and 1010 CE. It's considered the national epic of Greater Iran (which includes Iran, Afghanistan, and Tajikistan)

Activity 2: Identify the origin of the mathematical terms Sin θ and Cos θ.

Colonisation

In addition to serving as a trading and military route, colonisation served as a bridge for cross-cultural interactions during the Middle Ages. We'll talk about a lesser-known facet of European colonisation of India. During India's colonial history, these cross-cultural exchanges persisted and even intensified in certain ways.

Early contacts between Europe and India increased the interest in ancient Sanskrit language. There were several reasons why Europeans wanted to learn Sanskrit. While some people utilised knowledge for administrative and religious control throughout colonialism, others merely wanted to learn new things. But the spread of Sanskrit throughout Europe led to an unforeseen development in the field of chemical sciences. All of us studied the periodic table of Mendeleev during school days but did you know that Sanskrit played a part in his discovery?

Subash Kak writes [5],

> He (Mendeleev) noted the comprehensiveness of the two-dimensional arrangement of the Sanskrit alphabet (varṇamālā) which is apparent to even the beginning student of the language. The tabular form of the Sanskrit letters is due to the two parameters (point of articulation, and aspiration) at the basis of the sounds, and Mendeleev must have recognized that ratios / valency and atomic weight likewise defined a two-dimensional basis for the elements.
>
> Convinced that the analogy was fundamental, Mendeleev theorized that the gaps that lay in his table must correspond to undiscovered elements. For his predicted eight elements,

he used the prefixes of eka, dvi, and tri (Sanskrit one, two, three) in their naming.

Here, we can observe how Mendeleev was aided in his efforts to forecast the existence of elements and their positions in the periodic table indirectly by the spread of the Sanskrit language to European and then Russian society.

Table 1
The List of Mendeleev's Predictions with Sanskrit Names

Mendeleev's Given Name	Modern Name
Eka-aluminium	Gallium
Eka-boron	Scandium
Eka-silicon	Germanium
Eka-manganese	Technetium
Tri-manganese	Rhenium
Dvi-tellurium	Polonium
Dvi-caesium	Francium
Eka-tantalum	Protactinium

Since independence, this phenomena has grown significantly, and aspects of Indian culture—such as Yoga, Vedanta, Classical Music, and Sanskrit—have spread throughout the world.

Spiritual Routes

Once the quest for materialistic wellbeing and conquering is done, humans started the higher forms of happiness. In addition to exploring new lands and pursuing worldly prosperity, humanity also looked for more transcendent types of happiness.

Philosophical search to identify the 'true nature of life' started with this, and many times this search crossed borders to remote locations, to quench the thirst.

Records of correspondence between China and India go all the way back to the second century BCE. After Buddhism arrived in China from India in the first century CE, interpersonal interactions also took off in the form of pilgrimages and visits of masters.

After spending ten years in India in 402 CE, the Chinese monk Fa Xian (Fa-Hsien, CE 399–414) translated numerous Buddhist books from Sanskrit into Chinese upon his return. His work, Fo Guo Ji, or the 'Record of Buddhist Kingdoms', is a travel journal and a valuable historical document. Even now, people respect Kumarajiva's translations of Sanskrit sutras into Chinese.

Kumarajiva was born to an Indian father and a Chinese mother. In the seventh century CE, under King Harsha Vardhana's rule, Xuan Zang (Hiuen Tsang) travelled to India in search of Buddhist texts. His journey became part of traditional Chinese lore narrated in a later period book called "A Journey to the West".

It is reported that more Buddhist masters travelled to South China and were welcomed by Prince Liu Ying of Chu. Around the same time as the first two Indian Buddhist masters, Kasyapa Matanga and Dharmaraksa, arrived in Luoyang. Their specifics are unknown, though. It is stated that Bodhidharma, the founder of Chan Buddhism, was one of the masters who travelled from India to South China. Bodhidharma, also known as Da'mo in Chinese, was the third son of a Pallava king and is believed to have been born at Kanchipuram, close to Chennai. The boy's name was changed from Bodhitara to Bodhidharma by his instructor, Prajnatara. Bodhidharma spent many years serving

Prajnatara and promoting Buddhism after the passing of his father.

Following his master's final request, Bodhidharma left his monastery in India to go to China to propagate Buddhist teachings when Prajnatara passed away. The Luoyang Jia Lan Ji, or "The History of the Monasteries of Luoyang" penned by Yang Xuanzhi in 547 CE, is the first known historical account of Bodhidharma [6]. The 'Chan Buddhism' he founded later, became the origin of Zen buddhism.

The spread of Ramayana and Mahabharata to Southeast Asia is also an example of spiritual routes and its effects.

> **Activity 3:** Identify the connection between Ayodhya (Indian city), and South Korea.

Conclusion

These cross-cultural exchanges facilitated the spread of not only scientific concepts and technologies, but also fashion, cuisine, health habits, art forms, economic ideas, values, philosophies, and sociological trends far beyond their original locations. However, these exchanges left certain scars on the collective memory of society.

As stewards of the modern era, let us recognize and value the advantages of these cross-cultural exchanges while avoiding a replication of the misery-inducing errors of the past.

> The future belongs not to the 'single' entities, who stand divided, but to those who mingle and cooperate with others. Countries and societies that try to rise on their own will surely fail. This is a warning from nature to humankind. Hence, let our mantra be 'Mingle' not 'Single'.
>
> Amma, Civil 20 India Inception Conference in Nagpur

As guided by Amma, let us use "Intercultural Interactions" as a mantra to increase the interaction between societies and countries across the planet, and to combat various challenges we are facing today.

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Chapter 14

"Children, Have You Learnt Your Lessons Yet?"

When I am in an introspective or reflective mood, I ask myself, "Have you learnt your lessons yet?" Countless are the lessons taught by this holy land, anointed by the footsteps of the Divine Mother. They cannot be contained in the puny receptacle of words. I certainly have not imbibed all the lessons. And the learning is by no means over. When will it end? I don't know, and I don't need to know either.

I am also anxious and eager to untie the knots formed by the accumulated karmas (actions) of innumerable lives. In Amma's sacred presence, I have seen thousands of complicated knots unravelling.

Many such experiences are tucked away in the inner recesses of my mind, ready to emerge at the slightest prodding. Let me relate one of those experiences. It happened many years ago, during one of Amma's house visits.

Why Tighten the Knot?

A little boy from that house had just returned from school. He was about seven years old. Before entering the house, he

tried to take out his shoes quickly. Perhaps, he was hungry and thirsty, or eager to play with his friends after a drink and some snacks. In his eagerness to remove the shoes, he inadvertently tightened the knot of the shoelaces. The more he tried to untie the knot, the more complicated it became. The boy got more and more impatient and frustrated. When it seemed that his efforts were becoming futile, he did what any other child of his age would have done: he started crying, calling out to his mother. She came running to him. When she discovered what the problem was, she untied the knot, removed his shoes and took him inside the house.

The problem started when the boy did not exercise enough patience to untie the knot.

Amma was watching this incident with keen interest. She said, "Often, we too act in a similar way. We tie the knots and, because of our impatience and lack of attention, make the knots tighter and tighter, more and more complicated. How we work is very important. The results of an action depend upon how much attention we pay to it, to the degree to which we are involved in it. In other words, it depends on shraddha. The amount of shraddha we express is a good indicator of the probable outcome of our actions. For example, if a sharpshooter aims without thinking about the outcome, chances are that he or she will hit the target. But a competitor who is more focused on medal prospects may falter, causing the bullet to miss the mark.

Ask those who have climbed the ladder of success, "How did you reach the top? What is the secret behind your success?" Their reply would probably be, "Before taking the plunge, I ask myself, what is the worst that can happen? OK, I am prepared to face that. Let me try my hand at it." Once you have this determination, you will never turn back. You will walk the path of karma courageously. Have you seen people jump from the diving board into the

swimming pool? In a sense, the diving board is an answer to the question, "What is the worst that could happen?" It is symbolic of courage, an ideal attitude that empowers a person to boldly step onto and walk the path of karma.

I am reminded of the story of a young man tormented by mental agony and anguish. He said, "I was yearning to express my feelings to a girl. But I was scared. I imagined all possible reactions. This fear prevented me from opening my heart and expressing my love to her."

The youth continued. "I visualised her abusing me; hurling ice-cream at my face; spitting on me and walking away scornfully; her brothers beating me up; shooing me away with her sandals… However, one day, I decided to confess my feelings to her, come what may. 'Whatever will be, will be,' I told myself. I prepared myself for the worst, and then, my fears and doubts vanished. I plunged boldly into action."

It is difficult to reach this stage when one can say "yes." Before that, one must learn many lessons and gain maturity. It is not easy to drive away fears and anxieties.

Eye of the Eye

More than anything else, Amma says that the "blessings of our own mind are most important." No one else is going to scatter flower petals or thorns in our path. It is our own mind that creates such illusions. The lessons of life will put us through an ordeal by fire. Our life thus gains in strength, acquires a certain glow. To gain the necessary power of discrimination, to recognize our weaknesses and eliminate them, we need to gain the power of meditative silence. To gain this power, we need the third eye. The third eye or the spiritual eye is also described as kundalini shakti, and this eye must open within.

As Amma says, this does not mean that an eye, like the two we have, will appear between the eyebrows. One who waits for such an eye to open will be disappointed. The third eye symbolises the ability to welcome all kinds of experiences with even-mindedness and to see unity in this world of diversity. That is the significance of the third eye on Lord Shiva's forehead.

The famous poet, Ezhutacchan, hailed the third eye as "the eye of the eye — the mind's eye — which is the essential eye."

The third eye is not a proprietary claim of any religion or the gods associated with it, nor of any saint or avatar. The power to see and experience the world through the mind's eye is within everyone.

I have heard Amma say that many new truths and experiences await us. All we need to do is open the door of our hearts and invite them inside. How do we do that? By changing our attitude, our approach to analysing and evaluating life's experiences. We will then see a new world opening up before us.

Lessons that Sorrow Teaches

All of us experience shocks in life. A shock is like a hard blow on the head, received while sleeping. Our mental balance, our very being, gets upset. Those who have undergone such experiences use words like "harrowing," "catastrophic" and "tragic" to describe them. But actually, they are golden opportunities for us to learn the lessons of life.

Amma constantly reminds us that we are enriched more by the lessons taught by sorrow than by pleasant moments.

In the light of the truth, you will see that there is almost nothing in life that may be condemned as useless. When the Lord of the universe prepares the package of life for each being, He includes a mix of big and small events, as well as happy and sorrowful

experiences for each one of us. We may accept and use this precious gift from the Lord or reject it — the freedom is ours.

No matter where you are from, you would have seen people strolling or jogging in parks, on beaches or along roadsides, in the morning and evening.

Try asking one of them, "Friend, how long has it been since you started exercising?"

"Well, I had a mild heart-attack some time ago. Since then, I have been exercising regularly," one may reply, gasping for breath. Someone else may say, "My blood pressure increased recently. That's when I started morning walks." Or "Ever since I was diagnosed as diabetic, I started exercising to keep my sugar level under control."

Why did these people start exercising only after being struck by disease? Why couldn't they have prevented it with exercise instead of trying to cure it with exercise?

"From now onwards, I must study hard if I want to pass the examinations. I can't afford to waste time anymore." The student who realises this will start studying in earnest, right away.

The surprised parent may ask, "What happened? I didn't scold you or order you to study, did I?"

The probable answer would be, "No, but I am feeling guilty and worthless."

When does a person earnestly seek a job? Or, when does someone realise, "I'm not doing anything. I'm just wasting my time," and start looking for a job? When that person confronts certain situations, like not being able to pay the children's school fees or the bills, or having to avoid the milkman and grocer! When you become desperate for money, you will go job-hunting.

Similarly, when people who have not prayed even once in their lives become helpless, when they have lost everything, and when there seems to be no other way, they pray, they seek solace in God. "O Lord! I have never prayed before. I have ignored You totally. I have not opened my heart to You. God, please forgive me! Everyone has forsaken me. You are my only refuge. Please bless me. Please save me."

Trials and tribulations are not bad experiences, or as bad as people generally think them to be. Adverse situations can, in fact, pave the way for good times, and change us for the better.

Hard Taskmistress

It is difficult for us to change, to accept a different way of life. Even when it is thoroughly monotonous, a majority likes to conveniently think and live according to a fixed pattern. We are like records that keep playing the same fragment when the needle of the gramophone gets stuck.

But nature is a hard taskmistress. She will not let anyone become complacent. When things are going smoothly with few or no problems, suddenly, you will face a terrible crisis or undergo a horrifying experience. This jolts you into an awakening. You open your eyes and start looking around. But this new awareness doesn't last long. Our minds are too fragile to endure this level of attentiveness or alertness. After the blow has softened a little, when things improve slightly, we return to our old ways. Then comes another blow out of the blue. We are thus battered, again and again.

What's the use? Even if we receive a thousand blows, we hardly learn anything; we remain where we were, in the same condition.

But nature doesn't give up so easily. Suppose you tell your uncle, "Don't bother disciplining me. I'm incorrigible. I will not change,"

chances are he will give up in disgust.

"Get lost. Do whatever you want. I can't be bothered with you anymore." That may be his reaction.

But the case is totally different with Amma. She will express Her love as anger because She cares for us and wants to see us change for the better. Amma is an expert in reforming Her wayward children and putting them on the right path. Of course, it won't be easy for us; in fact, it will be an ordeal. When She catches us by the neck, we will raise both hands in surrender. A strict disciplinarian, Amma does not relent at all. She will certainly teach us the lessons. When She loves, She is Love incarnate. But when She chastises, She can be formidable. So, be careful!

Learn Your Lessons

We should use the power gained from meditation to determine if the decisions we make are right, and if the changes in our life are healthy. This is the foundation of a spiritual life. True, we all make mistakes before making the right choices and taking the right decisions. But that's okay. Life is like a jigsaw puzzle: experiences come in bits and pieces. When we put them together, we get a bigger picture. We should make the necessary changes, the required corrections, at the appropriate time. We should not lose those opportunities.

We can make better decisions by learning from our own and other people's experience. But blindly imitating others to appear 'cool' or 'fashionable' is foolish. This is happening today, with many belittling native cultural precedents and embracing foreignness. If this epidemic spreads, Bharat will lose her glory and uniqueness.

This cannot and should not happen. While singing the glories of Coca-Cola and Pizza Hut, or hailing, "Michael Jackson Ki Jai" ("Victory to Michael Jackson"), we should not forget the

greatness and purity of this land, sanctified by the austerities and divinity of sages like Veda Vyasa. Let us not forget the lessons we need to learn. If we forget, the consequences will be disastrous.

Amma says, "Life is a preparation. It is not limited to a day or two. It continues until the end of our lives. The popular belief is that life is a battle to be won by fights and quarrels. But life is something to be acquired with love and patience, and a lot of tolerance."

Sadly, love today seems to be turning old and stale, and getting 'bed-ridden' even while young. The increasing number of divorces, an 'in-thing' in some circles, is symptomatic of this disease. When love is regarded as yet another commodity with depreciating value, culture starts deteriorating.

Life is not for the lazy and indolent, the ones content to be 'sleeping.' We need to be mentally awake and alert always. Imagine the fate of a soldier who falls asleep on the battlefront: he will lose his head! Similar is life.

Life is an awakening. It is not merely bargaining and evaluating. The maturity we gain from various experiences and the faith we keep — these are the things that count. Only these will help us see the light.

Suppose a farmer who wants to cultivate tapioca tills the field carefully and plants a hundred saplings — will he get a harvest from all the hundred plants? No. Rodents may eat some of the saplings. The rain may wash some away. Plant diseases may kill some. The drought may destroy some of the saplings. Some people may even steal a few of those saplings. In the end, the farmer may get a harvest from just 50 plants.

What is so special about this experience? Nothing. The farmer gains nothing by crying, "I am ruined! Rodents and robbers

have ruined me!" He or she should realise, "Well, this is life," and get on it. This is life made simple and easy. And that is what spirituality teaches.

"Life and spirituality are one and the same. Spirituality is the management of life." Remember these golden words.

"OK. I will try spirituality. I shall pray and meditate. Will I get the results immediately?

People ask such questions, as if spirituality were just another commercial enterprise. It is like asking, "I shall sow the seeds today. Can I reap the harvest tomorrow?"

"Sure! You will reap wet seeds." That would be the reply.

People who are calculating think only about what they can get from any transaction. That is wrong thinking. If we take the example of farming, the right attitude involves cultivating the field, sowing the seeds, adding manure, watering them and weeding. Equally importantly, we must wait patiently.

Do you aspire after joy and happiness, peace and prosperity? It's easy to get them. The way is through love, patience, faith and other such words that we use everyday. It is equally easy to make life a hell. Just do away with those very qualities.

"If only I got a good job…"

"If only I had worked hard, I would have become an eminent…"

"If I get a promotion, I will give up my habit of sleeping at work."

"If my salary is increased, I will stop falling sick and taking leave every week."

Such sentiments are not rare. We all know people who brag and boast. Even when they are in situations conducive for progress,

they don't make the most of them. Life deals harshly with such people. They will have to learn their lessons the hard way.

But those who do their work sincerely and conscientiously, without complaining or gossiping, attain success.

"He used to sell the shells and husks of coconuts. Look at him now — the car, bungalow and servants! The fate of some people!"

"You know that man? He used to be a small-time grocer, selling fruits and vegetables. Look at the scale of his business today!"

When we hear such expressions of envy, we should remember that success is not conferred arbitrarily upon a select few. We can also succeed if we are enthusiastic and patient. Some of us need to cultivate these qualities; others do not. That is the only difference. The lives of those who do nothing but curse or blame fate will be wasted.

Evaluate experiences intelligently. Cultivate the right attitude to changing circumstances. These two skills are of utmost importance in life.

Half our mind is possessed by memories of the past; the other half is preoccupied with painting exquisite, golden pictures of the future. Alas, while vacillating from one to the other, we miss the heartbeats of the present. If we do not learn the lessons of the present, we will have to pay a heavy price, we will have to suffer much agony.

What greater agony can there be than in losing our spiritual bearings? In our eagerness to reap the harvests, we suffer the greatest loss — the loss of our soul. The most important thing in life is realising our Self. Let us not delay any further. Let us not neglect learning our lessons.